

**RECUEIL de TEXTES
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10 CANCER-FIGHTING FOODS

Foods that fight against cancer include fruits, vegetables, legumes, whole grains, fish and fermented foods. Found abundantly in the Mediterranean diet, they contain several protective compounds that work together to lower cancer risk. [...] Although no single food can stop cancer, consistently including a variety of cancer-fighting foods as part of a healthy diet is key to reducing risk. Choose these foods in their whole form which contains more nutrients.

Our list of top 10 cancer-fighting foods includes [...] berries that are among the healthiest foods you can eat. Their vitamins, fiber and antioxidants [...] can ward off cancer in our digestive tract. The magic likely resides in their blue, purple and red pigments. They are delicious alone or as a dessert.

The next on our list are cruciferous vegetables that include broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage and Brussels sprouts. Frequently eating these foods is associated with a lower risk of many cancers. Fish, particularly oily fish, such as salmon, tuna and anchovies are third on our list and one of the highest food sources of omega-3 fatty acids. Fish combats inflammation and protects against breast and colorectal cancer. [...] All nuts, especially walnuts, also have cancer-fighting properties since they are a great source of fiber and healthy fats. [...]

The American Cancer Society also recommends legumes and beans as one of the most important food groups for prevention. Rich in vitamins, minerals, protein and fiber, they are among the most inexpensive cancer-fighting foods. Cheap, healthy, versatile and delicious, legumes are a food staple worldwide, available dry and canned. [...]

Eating dark chocolate with high cocoa content can deliver fiber, antioxidants and minerals that may also lower the risk of certain cancers. Chocolate is a good source of polyphenols and flavanols, which are rocket fuel for healthy gut bacteria. [...]

Whole grains such as brown rice and whole wheat bread also contain protective antioxidants as Vitamin E, lignans and fiber. Eating whole grains reduces the risk of at least 18 types of cancer, and each 10-gram increase in dietary fiber from this food group is linked with a 7% reduction in colorectal cancer risk. The carotenoids found in leafy vegetables or leafy greens, such as spinach, act as antioxidants to boost the body's own defenses.

Fermented foods, such as yogurt, are also on our list. They provide probiotics - healthy bacteria that improve immune function and protect against cancer. These good bacteria can bind and destroy potential carcinogens, and may be especially effective in preventing colorectal cancer.

Last but not least, garlic has long been used both for cooking and medicine. A root vegetable, garlic contains allicin, a protective sulfur compound that inhibits cancer progression. Eating garlic frequently lowers the risk of colorectal cancer. [...]

Adapted from *Moffitt Cancer Center*
October 2025
(450 words)

A FROG, A LOBSTER AND A UNICORN WALKED INTO A NO KINGS PROTEST

Even before the No Kings rallies kicked off last weekend, some Republicans cast the protests in a sinister light. House Speaker Mike Johnson called them "Hate America" rallies. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent warned that they would attract "the most unhinged in the Democratic party." [...]

In Washington, a poodle and a chicken danced to drum music with three dinosaurs next to the National Gallery, a short walk from the U.S. Capitol. Scott Rohrbach, a senior optical engineer at NASA, came dressed as a unicorn. It was not his first choice. "I would have come as a frog, but I couldn't find a frog," said Rohrbach, disappointed that all the frog costumes were sold out. Rohrbach said he came to protest because he fears that under President Trump, future elections may not be fair. He wore the costume to counter the Republican narrative that protesters like him are hate-filled, anti-American radicals. "One of the things fascists can't handle is humor," said Rohrbach, who added that fellow protesters posed with him for selfies and kids gave him high-fives.

President Trump has said repeatedly that he is neither a fascist nor a king and dismissed the rallies. "I think it's a joke," he told reporters. "I looked at the people. They're not representative of this country."

The president answered the demonstrations with his own brand of humor, posting an AI-generated video of him wearing a crown while flying a jet and dumping what looked like excrement on protesters.

So what inspired Rohrbach and so many others to dress up like animals and mythical creatures last weekend?

It all started earlier this month in Portland. A man in a frog suit was trying to help a fellow protester at an anti-ICE rally. A law enforcement officer responded by spraying the suit's air valve with a chemical agent as captured on video.

The image of the officer in a black helmet and shield going after the protester in the frog costume caught the eye of many, including Jordy Lybeck, a political streamer. Lybeck began brainstorming in real time with his viewers. "How much are those outfits?" Lybeck wondered aloud. "Are you thinking what I'm thinking? What if somebody bought a lot of them and distributed them at the facility?"

That's exactly what Lybeck and Brooks Brown, who streams about philosophy, did. They raised money online, bought more costumes and drove them to the ICE facility in Portland. [...]

Similarly, the No Kings protest had a carnival-like feel. [...] Brown says the funny-looking outfits change the optics of protests so that government force looks more like farce. After all, it's not easy to portray an inflatable frog – or unicorn – as "the enemy from within."

Adapted from *Npr.com*
October 2026
(458 words)

A NEW VERSION OF MINECRAFT TO HELP CHILDREN LEARN

A new version of Minecraft aims to teach students about coastal erosion, flood resilience and climate adaptation, and shows how children can use computer games to learn about complex situations. CoastCraft can be added to the game. It is set in the seaside town of Bude, Cornwall, and players attempt to protect the coastal landscape from the effects of sea-level rises and climate change. Bude is experiencing increasing coastal erosion and the project was developed in conjunction with the UK Environmental Agency and Cornwall Council as part of a £200 million flood and coastal erosion innovation programme. In the game, students use animations to understand coastal erosion and rising sea levels before being able to explore and engage with a range of coastal management strategies (including relocating key infrastructure, using nature-based solutions such as plants, or potentially doing nothing at all).

I played the game for a few hours and found that the mechanics of Minecraft lent themselves very well to understanding the principles of environmental management. If you do a bad job, the sea encroaches on the terrain and certain infrastructure is lost (for instance, a car park or toilets). These dynamics add to the immersive experience of the game. They also nail the realities of future climate change in a way that is potentially far more relevant and digestible than scientific models and projections.

In making the decisions, you get to move around the map to chat with key people about the potential impact of going ahead with a decision and any other factors. You are limited by how much you can spend. Some decisions, like relocating the lifeguard hut, are very expensive (costing 75% of your total funds), while nature-based management, such as sand dune protection, costs nothing. Through this, players are actively introduced to decision-making and the implications of their actions.

Throughout the game, there is a major emphasis on balancing the economic, social and environmental impact. You are able to fast-forward to 2040 and then again to 2060 to see what your decision-making looks like down the line.

After each round, you are sent back to a roundtable of NPCs (non-playing characters) who scrutinise your decisions before revealing a sustainability score on how well you managed to reconcile the competing economic, societal and environmental demands. [...]

At the University of East Anglia my team ran a series of workshops with staff and students to help establish what and how climate change should be taught. [...] Games can be used as a teaching method to convey complex environmental stories and immerse students in situations they may not otherwise have access to. [...]

Adapted from *theconversation.com*

October 2025
(448 words)

A STUDY FOUND LEAD IN POPULAR PROTEIN POWDERS. HERE'S WHY YOU SHOULDN'T PANIC

A Consumer Reports investigation has found what it calls "concerning" levels of lead in roughly two dozen popular protein powder brands – but says that's not necessarily cause for tossing them. The nonprofit organization tested multiple samples of 23 protein powders and ready-to-drink shakes from a range of stores and online retailers over a three-month period beginning last November. The results [...] show that more than two-thirds of the products contain more lead in a single serving than Consumer Reports' experts say is safe to consume in an entire day. [...]

Consumer Reports says lead levels were especially high across plant-based protein powders – on average, nine times higher than those made with dairy proteins and twice as great as those of beef-based powders. [...]

The Council for Responsible Nutrition, a trade group representing the dietary supplement industry, released a statement [...] urging caution in interpreting the study's results. It says that modern testing methods are sensitive enough to identify trace amounts of naturally occurring heavy metals, and that alone does not equate to a health hazard. "A finding that a product exceeds Consumer Reports' self-imposed threshold is not the same as exceeding a government safety limit, nor is it evidence of any safety risk to consumers," the trade group added. Consumer Reports' study adds to a growing body of research into heavy metals in a variety of everyday products, from cinnamon to tampons. [...]

The findings come at a time when many Americans are making part of their regular routines amidst the country's protein craze. There is no known safe level of exposure to lead, which is present in many of the environments in which food is grown, raised and processed. But experts say the greatest risk of adverse health effects – like reproductive problems, kidney damage and cognitive impairment – comes from repeated exposure at high doses.

While Consumer Reports advises against downing a protein shake every day, it says the bulk of the products it tested are fine to have occasionally. [...] "The real risk with lead is even if you are exposed to kind of low levels consistently over time, that lead could kind of build up in the body and eventually cause problems farther down the line. The advice is more, scrutinize your protein shakes and take a look at what you're using to make an informed decision, rather than immediately freak out. [...]

Huel, a British company that makes plant-based meal replacement products, published a lengthy FAQ rebutting Consumer Reports' investigation. [...] It criticizes Consumer Reports for basing its comparison on Prop 65, which it says sets an "exceptionally conservative threshold". [...]

Adapted from *NPR*
October 2025
(446 words)

ADOLESCENCE STAR STEPHEN GRAHAM LAUNCHES GLOBAL PROJECT ASKING FATHERS TO WRITE TO THEIR SONS

Stephen Graham, the Emmy-winning actor best known for Netflix hit *Adolescence*, has launched a new project asking fathers, reflecting on their experiences of fatherhood, to write letters to their sons about what it means to be a man, to form a book about masculinity. [...] Graham will work with psychology lecturer Orly Klein to compile *Letters to Our Sons*, a book due to be published by Bloomsbury next October.

"There is arguably an even bigger disconnect between fathers and sons than ever before," Graham said. "We want to hear from men of all ages, first-time fathers, absent fathers, fathers who've been there but never truly been there, fathers who've lost and fathers who just want to find a way to say I love you, to tell their sons what they mean to them and to talk openly about what it means to be a man."

Fathers can submit their letters [...] until 12 January 2026, [...]. Selected letters will appear alongside contributions from [...] other well-known figures.

The project follows the success of *Adolescence*, a limited TV series co-created by Graham. The show, which became Netflix's second most-watched English-language programme globally, examined modern masculinity and the pressures facing teenage boys in a digital world. [...]

The series sparked widespread debate in the UK and beyond about the role of fathers, male role models and toxic online influences. MP Anneliese Midgley urged for it to be shown in parliament and in schools, arguing that it could help address violence against women and girls. Prime minister Keir Starmer supported the proposal, saying that watching the show with his teenage children "hit home hard". On 31 March, it was announced that the series would be made available for free to UK secondary schools.

[...] Klein, whose academic work focuses on marginalisation, identity and youth culture, has previously worked on projects such as *Room to Rant*, which uses rap as a therapeutic tool for young men.

Campaigners and educators have warned of the growing influence of "manosphere" figures and extremist ideologies targeting vulnerable young men. Earlier this year, a study found that 69% of boys aged 11-14 had encountered posts promoting misogyny. Meanwhile, research from the NSPCC found that 42% of parents reported hearing their sons make inappropriate comments – including sexual, violent or degrading remarks – about women and girls, because of what they had seen online.

The book's publisher, Bloomsbury, described it as a project with the potential to spark a "genuine social and cultural movement". [...] Graham and Klein will be making a donation [...] to the charity MANUP? and social enterprise Dad La Soul, two organisations helping young men struggling with mental health.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(456 words)

AMAZON MAKES 'FUNDAMENTAL LEAP FORWARD IN ROBOTICS'

Amazon said it has made a “fundamental leap forward in robotics” after developing a robot with a sense of touch that will be capable of grabbing about three-quarters of the items in its vast warehouses.

Vulcan – which launches at the US firm’s “Delivering the Future” event in Dortmund, Germany, on Wednesday and is to be deployed around the world in the next few years – is designed to help humans sort items for storage and then prepare them for delivery as the latest in a suite of robots which have an ever-growing role in the online retailer’s extensive operation.

Aaron Parness, Amazon’s director of robotics, described Vulcan as a “fundamental leap forward in robotics. It’s not just seeing the world, it’s feeling it, enabling capabilities that were impossible for Amazon robots until now.”

The robots will be able to identify objects by touch using AI to work out what they can and can’t handle and figuring out how best to pick them up. They will work alongside humans who now stash and retrieve items from shelving units which are manoeuvred to them at picking stations by wheeled robots – of which Amazon now has more than 750,000 in operation.

Vulcan will be able to stow items on the upper and lower levels of the shelving units – known as pods – so that humans no longer need to use ladders or bend so often during their work. [...]

The development is likely to raise fears of job losses as retailers reduce human involvement in distribution centres, which employ thousands of people.

Many retailers have said that they are increasing investment in automation as labour costs rise around the world. Amazon has faced industrial action in the UK and elsewhere over low pay in its warehouses.

Economists at Goldman Sachs speculated in 2023 that 300m jobs worldwide could be automated out of existence by 2030 as a result of the development of generative AI, with many more roles radically transformed. [...]

However, Tye Brady, the chief technologist of robotics at Amazon, said robots could not completely replace humans in the group’s warehouses and were there to “amplify the human potential” and to improve safety in the workplace. The self-confessed “Star Wars geek” said the robots he helps design could be likened to R2D2 as “an amazing collaborative robot”.

“People will always be part of the equation,” he said, while machines will take on “the menial, the mundane and the repetitive” tasks.

“There’s no such thing as completely automated. It just doesn’t exist, because you always need people to understand the value of the operation, just using common sense, like, is that really doing the job?”

Adapted from *The Guardian*
May 2025
(455 words)

AMAZON WEB SERVICES OUTAGE SHOWS INTERNET USERS 'AT MERCY' OF TOO FEW PROVIDERS, EXPERTS SAY

Experts have warned of the perils of relying on a small number of companies for operating the global internet after a glitch at Amazon's cloud computing service brought down apps and websites around the world.

The affected platforms included Snapchat, Signal, Pokémon Go, Epic Games, PlayStation Network and Duolingo as well as a host of Amazon-owned operations including its main retail site.

More than 2,000 companies worldwide have been affected, according to Downdetector, a site that monitors internet outages, with 8.1m reports of problems from users including 1.9m reports in the US, 1m in the UK and 418,000 in Australia. Many of the sites were restored after a few hours, but some experienced persistent problems throughout the day.

In the UK, Lloyds bank was affected, as well as its subsidiaries Halifax and Bank of Scotland, while there were also problems accessing the HM Revenue and Customs website on Monday morning. [...]

Experts said the outage underlined the dangers of the internet's reliance on a small number of tech companies, with Amazon, Microsoft and Google playing a key role in the cloud market.

Cori Crider, the executive director of the Future of Technology Institute, a thinktank that supports a sovereign technology framework for Europe, said: "We urgently need diversification in cloud computing. The infrastructure underpinning democratic discourse, independent journalism and secure communications cannot be dependent on a handful of companies."

She believes "The UK can't keep leaving its critical infrastructure at the mercy of US tech giants. With Amazon Web Services down, we've seen the lights go out across the modern economy – from banking to communications." [...]

"The counter-argument is that it's these large hyper-scaling companies that have the financial resources to provide a secure, global and resilient service. But most people outside those companies would argue that is a risky position for the world to be in," she added.

Last year, airports, healthcare services and businesses worldwide were hit by the "largest outage in history", caused by a botched software upgrade from cyber-security company CrowdStrike that hit Microsoft's Windows operating system.

Amazon reported that the problem on Monday originated in the east coast of the US at Amazon Web Services, a unit that provides vital web infrastructure for a host of companies, which rent out space on Amazon servers. AWS is the world's largest cloud computing platform.

Experts said the outage appeared to be an IT issue rather than a cyber-attack. "The incident appears to have been caused by some accident within AWS, rather than being the result of any malicious intent," said Steven Murdoch, a professor of security engineering at University College London.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(459 words)

AN UNUSUAL 'VILLAGE' AIMS TO HELP PEOPLE LEAVE LONG-TERM HOMELESSNESS FOR GOOD

On a weekday morning, about two dozen formerly homeless men and women file into a small room at *The Other Side Village* near Salt Lake City. [...]

The people in this meeting have all been chronically unhoused – typically living outside for eight to nine years with significant addiction or mental illness. They are among the hardest to help, and that's exactly who *the Village* has targeted since it opened two years ago.

"Once you've forgotten how to work, forgotten how to engage with other people, forgotten how to solve human problems, forgotten how to manage finances, it takes a lot of work to restore some of those abilities," says Joseph Grenny, a co-founder of *The Other Side Village*.

Across the country, much-needed housing and treatment programs for the unhoused are in short supply. There's also heated debate over which should be a bigger priority, with President Trump calling for forced treatment.

This ambitious project in Utah offers short-term housing, rehab and mental health treatment, along with a kind of training program. People start in a prep school that teaches life skills for those who may have lost them. They must get and stay sober and are also required to work.

The Village runs businesses to help create jobs for that. After six to 12 months, fellow residents vote to decide when someone is ready to "graduate." At that point, they can move on to their own place, in tiny cottages *the Village* is building for permanent housing. [...]

The conversation at morning meetings is meant to build community, because supporting each other is a big part of the therapy here. Resident Patricia Jean Martin says it feels like starting a new life with people she can "actually trust, be honest with, be accountable with."

To help with that change, there are coaches who know exactly what people are going through. [...]

Typical shelter-based programs may only house people at night, leaving them essentially still homeless during the day. [...]. There's little structure, certainly no jobs, and dropout rates are high. Meanwhile there's very little residential rehab, and it's usually for people who have private insurance or can pay out of pocket. [...]

The program aims to eventually become self-sufficient through the businesses it runs. But to launch, it has raised money from donors and gotten several million dollars in state funding. It's also leasing a large patch of city-owned land for a dollar a year. [...]

There's an income limit, but otherwise people can stay here as long as they want.

A health clinic is also under construction that will include mental health services and dentistry, and there will be a grocery store. Both places will offer jobs for residents. [...]

Adapted from *NPR News*
October 2025
(456 words)

ARTIST EXPLORES THE TOXIC MINING LEGACY OF ZAMBIA'S "BLACK MOUNTAINS"

Zambia's notorious "black mountains" – huge heaps of mining waste that scar the Copperbelt skyline – are deeply personal to Sary Mwaba, one of the country's leading visual artists. "As kids, we used to call it 'mu danger' – meaning 'in the danger'," Mwaba tells the BBC. "The 'black mountain' was this place where you shouldn't go," says the painter. [...]

Nowadays, the young men heading to "mu danger" are looking for fragments of copper ore in the stony slag of these towering dumpsites – the toxic legacy of a century of industrial mining production in Zambia, one of the world's biggest copper and cobalt producers. They dig deep [...] and hew out rocks to sell to mostly Chinese buyers, who then extract copper.

It is tough, dangerous, often illegal and sometimes fatal work. But it can also be lucrative – and, in a region where youth unemployment is about 45%, for some young people it is the only way that they can make ends meet.

Mwaba's latest work [...] tells the story of the young people who mine the black mountain in the town of Kitwe. [...] The artist has painted a series of large portraits. [...] "They have stories that are important and are part of the bigger story." Mwaba hears stories of hardship and survival during the drawing, photography and performance workshops that he and other artists have held over several years. [...]

But the 49-year-old's interest in the impact of Zambia's mining as a subject for his paintings began [...] after he helped his daughter, Zoe, with a science project at the Chinese International School. [...] The task was to demonstrate how plants absorb minerals and water. He and Zoe went to the market and bought a Chinese cabbage. [...] Mwaba remembers that the use of Chinese cabbage made the audience "uneasy and so uncomfortable".

At the time, [...] tensions were high [...] against the Chinese, who are accused locally of dominating the Zambian economy and exploiting workers. So Mwaba turned the science project into a work of art – in which he explored the Chinese presence in Zambia's mining sector. [...]

He went to Kitwe, where he had spent some childhood years. But his focus changed from just exploring the Chinese presence in Zambia to trying to tell the story of the black mountain people. "I went back to a place where I grew up and things had changed so much," the artist says, adding that he "never, ever imagined that I would see the kind of the situation I see now - the poverty. It was a very emotional space and I was sad," Mwaba says.

Adapted from *BBC News*
July 2025
(444 words)

AS ANTI-TOURISM PROTESTS GROW IN EUROPE, WE NEED A RETHINK

After coordinated protests across Europe last weekend, it's easy for the ethically conscious tourist to feel uncertain. Across southern Europe – and particularly in Spain, Italy and Portugal – there are headlines blaming visitors for everything from overcrowding to housing shortages. In gentrifying neighbourhoods, slogans such as “Tourists go home” have appeared on walls and windows, with some angry residents grabbing headlines by squirting water pistols at tourists.

Does that mean a golden age of tourism is over? No. Does the complicated relationship between those who want to visit the world's most interesting places and those who live in them need a reset? Probably.

For the most part, protesters are calling for a total overhaul of a model of tourism that, they argue, drives up housing costs, harms the environment and creates low-paid, unstable jobs – while concentrating profits in the hands of a few.

I've seen this first-hand. I live in Lavapiés, a vibrant and multicultural neighbourhood near Madrid's main train station. When I moved here 12 years ago, the area was a haven of traditional bars and restaurants and independent shops. Today, many of those restaurants – once offering a full menú del día for €8 (£6.80) – have doubled their prices. Local businesses have been replaced by ground-floor tourist accommodation.

This is not just a story of tourists replacing local people; it's one of policy failure and economic imbalance. In Madrid, decent food is often still relatively affordable – but the same can't be said for accommodation. [...] There are roughly 15,000 illegal tourist apartments in Madrid alone, rising to more than 66,000 across the country. [...]

As Europe responds with growing resentment towards tourists, many people are asking: is it even possible to enjoy a trip without contributing to the problem? Can you still visit Madrid, Barcelona or the Canary Islands without encountering the “Tourists go home” signs – or being squirted with water pistols? Should you?

The answer is yes. First, it's important to put the water pistol incidents in perspective: these are symbolic, isolated acts and far from the norm. More importantly, tourism is vital to Spain's economy, accounting for roughly 12% of GDP. The country wants tourists, but that doesn't mean business as usual should continue. Governments must do far more to regulate short-term rentals, support local communities and invest in affordable infrastructure – for residents and visitors.

But travellers have an important role to play too: by choosing accommodation designed for tourists wherever possible; or by exercising judgment about where and when to travel. Opting to visit a resort town on the mainland rather than a city on an island might put less pressure on local communities and resources, for example.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
June 2025
(457 words)

AS SOCIAL MEDIA AGE RESTRICTIONS SPREAD, IS THE INTERNET ENTERING ITS VICTORIAN ERA?

A wave of proposed social media bans for young people has swept the globe recently, fuelled by mounting concern about the apparent harm the likes of TikTok, Instagram and Snapchat can cause to vulnerable minds. Australia was the first to announce restrictions on people under 16 having a social media account. New Zealand may soon follow, and Denmark's prime minister recently declared her country would ban social media for under-15s, accusing mobile phones and social networks of "stealing our children's childhood".

The moves are part of a growing international trend: the United Kingdom, France, Norway, Pakistan and the United States are now considering or implementing similar restrictions, often requiring parental consent or digital ID verification.

At first glance, these policies appear to be about protecting young people from mental health harm, explicit content and addictive design. But beneath the language of safety lies something else: a shift in cultural values. The bans reflect a [...] moral turn, one that risks reviving conservative notions that predate the internet. Might we be entering a new Victorian era of the internet, where the digital lives of young people are reshaped not just by regulation but by a reassertion of moral control? [...]

The Victorian era was marked by rigid social codes, modest dress and formal communication. Public behaviour was tightly regulated, and schools were seen as key sites for socialising children into gender and class hierarchies. Today, we see echoes of this in the way "digital wellness" is framed. Screen-time apps, detox retreats and "dumb" phones are marketed as tools for cultivating a "healthy" digital life – often with moral undertones. The ideal user is calm, focused and restrained. The impulsive, distracted or emotionally expressive user is pathologised.

This framing is especially evident in the work of Jonathan Haidt, psychologist and author of *The Anxious Generation*, a central text in the age-restriction movement. Haidt argues that social media accelerates performative behaviour and emotional dysregulation in young people.

Viewed this way, youth digital life involves declining psychological resilience, rising polarisation and the erosion of shared civic values, rather than being a symptom of complex developmental or technological shifts. This has helped popularise the idea that social media is not just harmful but corrupting. Yet the data behind these claims is contested. Critics have pointed out that Haidt's conclusions often rely on correlational studies and selective interpretations.

[...] While some research links heavy social media use to anxiety and depression, other studies suggest the effects are modest and vary widely depending on context, platform and individual differences. What's missing from much of the debate is a recognition of young people's agency, or their ability to navigate online spaces intelligently, creatively and socially. [...]

Adapted from *The Conversation*
October 2025
(457 words)

AUTISM

Autism Spectrum Disorders (or ASD), are a diverse group of conditions characterised by some degree of difficulty with social interaction and communication. Other characteristics are atypical behaviours, such as difficulty with transition from one activity to another, a focus on details and unusual reactions to sensations.

The abilities and needs of autistic people vary and can evolve over time. While some people with autism can live independently, others require life-long care. Autism often has an impact on education and employment opportunities. Societal attitudes and the level of support provided by local and national authorities are important factors determining the quality of life of people with autism.

Autism may be detected in early childhood, but it is often not diagnosed until much later. People with autism often have co-occurring conditions, including epilepsy, depression, anxiety and hyperactivity disorder. The level of intellectual functioning among autistic people varies widely, extending from profound impairment to superior levels.

It is estimated that worldwide in 2021 about 1 in 127 persons had autism, although the prevalence of autism in many low- and middle-income countries is unknown.

Available scientific evidence suggests that there are probably many factors that make a child more likely to have autism, including environmental and genetic factors including advanced parental age, maternal diabetes during pregnancy, prenatal exposure to air pollutants or certain heavy metals. [...] More research is needed to better understand the role of the factors that appear to be associated with a higher risk for autism, such as the use of various medicines during pregnancy. However, extensive research conducted over many years has demonstrated that the measles, mumps and rubella triple vaccine as well as other childhood vaccines do not increase the risk of autism. [...]

A broad range of interventions, from early childhood and across the life span, can optimise the development, health, well-being and quality of life of autistic people. Access to early psychological interventions can greatly improve the ability of autistic children to communicate and interact socially. [...]

All people, including people with autism, have the right to the enjoyment of the highest attainable standard of physical and mental health. And yet, autistic people are often subject to stigma and discrimination, including unjust deprivation of health care, education and opportunities to engage and participate in their communities.

People with autism have the same health problems as the general population. However, they may, in addition, have specific health-care needs. They may also be at greater risk of violence, injury and abuse and are more likely to die prematurely. [...] This is the reason why the World Health Organisation and partners recognise the need to strengthen countries' abilities to promote the optimal health and well-being of all autistic people. [...]

Adapted from *New Scientist*
October 2025
(453 words)

BANK OF ENGLAND TO REDESIGN BANKNOTES – AND WANTS YOUR HELP

Banknotes issued by the Bank of England are about to get their first major redesign in more than 50 years. Notable historical figures, such as Sir Winston Churchill on the current fiver, have featured on these banknotes since 1970 but could be on the way out.

The public are being asked for their views on new themes, such as nature, innovation, or key events in history. It raises the possibility of British birds, bridges, or bangers and mash featuring on the next series of £5, £10, £20 and £50 notes.

The monarch has appeared on Bank of England notes since 1960. Images of historical characters, starting with William Shakespeare, were first seen on the reverse side a decade later. At times the choices have landed the Bank in hot water. The absence of any women, apart from Queen Elizabeth II, on notes in 2013 prompted a huge backlash.

Now, the Bank is proposing that designs on the next series of notes could move on to a new theme. While notable historical figures remain an option, other possible subject matters suggested by the Bank include architecture and landmarks, arts, culture and sport, innovation, such as technology or discoveries, nature, celebrating plants, animals or natural landscapes. [...]

The public are being invited to give their views. They can also suggest their own themes, which may prompt plenty of jokes and debate.

"Banknotes are more than just an important means of payment. They serve as a symbolic representation of our collective national identity and an opportunity to celebrate the UK," said Victoria Cleland, the Bank's chief cashier, whose signature appears on notes.

"I am really keen to hear what themes the public would like to see represented."

Ms Cleland said banknotes were "little pieces of art in our pocket", but there were some extra considerations over what can go on them, such as accessibility and security features. [...]

However, while keen to widen the choice, albeit it needed to be enduring, and not divisive, she said. Banknotes issued in Scotland and Northern Ireland already carry images of landmarks and animals such as otters. Euro banknotes feature architectural styles. [...]

People can submit their view via an online form on the Bank's website, or by post, by the end of July. More than 4.7 billion Bank of England notes are in circulation, collectively worth around £86bn.

Cash use has fallen to 12% of transactions as payments technology evolves, but the Bank has said it is committed to providing cash for those who wish to use it.

Adapted from *BBC News*
July 2025
(444 words)

BRISTOL PIONEERS SUSTAINABLE POWER FOR FESTIVALS

Artists including Billie Eilish and Neil Young and festivals across the world have taken action to make their concerts more sustainable by harnessing green power.

The concept is being taken a step further in the south-west of England next summer when a “clean power hub” is set up in Bristol that festivals, large gigs and film crews will be able to tap into.

It is claimed to be the first time anywhere in the world that local administrations – in this case Bristol city council and the West of England mayoral combined authority – have guaranteed a supply of clean power to events and artists on such a scale.

Tony Dyer, the leader of Bristol city council, said making a city carbon neutral required all sections of the economy, including culture, to take action.

He said: “This is a welcome approach to exploring how we can support the events sector to move away from the use of fuel-driven generators, in turn improving air quality and lowering emissions.”

Describing it as an exciting development, Helen Godwin, the mayor of the west of England, said: “People across the west love culture and love our environment. Clean energy and the creative industries are both key growth sectors for us over the coming decade.”

The new scheme takes the concept further. Two sites have been chosen for the power hub in Bristol to which electricity from the National Grid, provided by 100% renewable suppliers, will be delivered. It will be stored in an array of batteries that can be taken to the site of whichever event or crew needs it.

Mark Donne, the lead producer of Act 1.5, a collective bringing together artists, technicians and scientists for the project, said no government or commercial body had attempted such a scheme on this sort of scale.

Donne said he expected more than 20 events would source their power from the scheme rather than using generators, which can harm the environment and the health of people who work at and attend festivals.

He accepted some event organisers may be nervous but said they could be persuaded to go 50/50 on clean power and conventional. “We’re realistic. Some people have long-running events and they have a formula, a way of working,” he said.

The project has also talked to some of the many film and television production companies that visit the south-west for the summer. “Three big production companies have said, yes, emphatically, we’re going to make use of it. So it’s really two creative sectors making use of all of the hardware,” Donne said. “This is a clean-air strategy as well as a climate one, and a world-first for Bristol.”

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(453 words)

BRITAIN CANNOT BE A BIG GLOBAL PLAYER UNLESS WE SPEAK MORE LANGUAGES

Lots of people told me not to study languages – including my own (monolingual) dad. “You’re never going to be as fluent as a native speaker,” I remember him saying when I was deciding on my university degree. “Why bother?”

A little more than a decade later, I’ve staffed Sotheby’s Madrid reception desk, taught theatre and English to Syrian children in Beirut, given a speech at the UN, and trained journalists in Ecuador. [...] And most important of all? I’ve changed my dad’s mind.

Nick Gibb, the former schools minister, was right when he told *The Times* that the UK’s decline in language-learning is “damaging to our reputation as a global player”. In Europe, we are among the least likely to speak a second language. In 1997, 82% of boys and 73% of girls took a modern language at GCSE, but by 2018 that had sunk to 50% and 38%.

Language-learning was once the preserve of elites, but wider access was under way until the 2004 Labour government removed the GCSE requirement. It has had a catastrophic effect ever since.

Spanish take-up is growing, while French has stabilised. German entries are falling despite it being the most-requested language in UK job ads. Worse, language-learning is again becoming the preserve of the elite: in poorer areas, only about 46% of pupils study a language, compared to 20 points more in affluent ones.

Lower uptake at GCSE triggers a decline in A-levels and university degrees. [...] Universities keep losing modern languages departments. Neither Brexit nor the pandemic helped.

I was fortunate to go to a school that prioritised languages, and luckier to be exposed to multilingualism. Where my dad saw little value, my mum – fluent in Italian – encouraged me to learn as many languages as possible.

Without the Spanish I started at 13, the Arabic I started at 18 and the Italian that’s been with me since birth, I wouldn’t be the journalist or person I am today. Languages bring resilience, creativity and openness to new ideas.

Multilingual people gain access to jobs that require such skills, as well as cognitive benefits from enhanced creativity to delaying Alzheimer’s. [...]

Despite a vague attempt to help with the English baccalaureate, the situation has become so bad that Duolingo is now sponsoring a Westminster language-learning challenge.

We should respect the diversity of languages emigrants bring to the UK and value heritage language-learning. Accounting for our indigenous languages would be a start too. [...] Combine the contribution immigrants make to our country with our ancient Celtic languages and one quickly realises the UK is not nearly as monolingual as we assume.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
August 2025
(454 words)

BRITAIN ONE OF LEAST 'NATURE-CONNECTED' NATIONS IN WORLD – WITH NEPAL THE MOST

Britain is one of the least “nature connected” nations in the world, according to the first ever global study of how people relate to the natural world.

Britain ranks 55th out of 61 countries in the study of 57,000 people, which looks at how attitudes towards nature are shaped by social, economic, geographical and cultural factors.

The most nature-connected nation is Nepal, followed by Iran, South Africa, Bangladesh and Nigeria, according to the study, which is published in the journal *Ambio*. Croatia and Bulgaria are the only European nations in the top 10, followed by France in 19th place.

Languishing below Britain are the Netherlands, English-speaking Canada, Germany, Israel, Japan and Spain, which is the least nature-connected of the 61 nations surveyed.

Nature connectedness is a psychological concept that measures the closeness of an individual's relationship with other species. Studies have found that people with higher levels of nature connectedness enjoy improved wellbeing and are more likely to act in environmentally friendly ways. Low levels of nature connectedness have been identified as one of three major underlying causes of biodiversity loss alongside inequality and the prioritisation of individual, material gains.

Researchers from Britain and Austria, led by Miles Richardson, professor of nature connectedness at the University of Derby, found the strongest indicator for a close relationship with nature was high levels of “spirituality” in a society. More religious societies and cultures where there was a preference for faith over science showed high levels of nature connection.

In contrast, the study also found that “ease of doing business” – a World Bank measurement of the business-friendly character of a country – was correlated with less nature connection.

Although Britain is believed to have one of the highest levels of membership of environmental organisations in the world, this apparently pro-nature indicator was found to have little impact on closeness to nature.

More concrete factors found by the study to be linked to a lack of connection with nature included levels of urbanisation, mean income and internet use.

“Nature connectedness is not just about what we do, but how we feel, think, and value our place in the living world,” said Richardson, who admitted he was not surprised that Britain languished so low in the nature connection league table.

“We’ve become a more rational, economic and scientific society. That’s obviously brought some fantastic benefits but it’s how we balance them with the unforeseen problems,” he said. “How do we reintegrate natural thinking in our very technological world? It’s obviously very difficult to change cultures but it’s about mainstreaming the value of nature, making it integral to our wellbeing, so it becomes respected and almost sacred.”

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(457 words)

BUTTERFLY NUMBERS HAVE FALLEN BY NEARLY A QUARTER SINCE 2000

In the United States, perhaps no bug has been counted as often as the butterfly. "There's a lot of passion for them, they're very charismatic," says Collin Edwards, a quantitative ecologist at the Washington Department of Fish and Wildlife. That passion sparked scores of volunteers to spend hundreds of thousands of hours over the past several decades monitoring butterflies.

"Frankly, the amount of volunteer effort in the U.S. gives us really one of the best insect datasets in the world," says Edwards. But that dataset was a patchwork of separate, slightly different monitoring programs scattered across the country. To get a single, country-wide look at the state of these bugs, Edwards and a team of more than 30 butterfly researchers brought together and analyzed all these efforts — a total of 12.6 million butterfly sightings. Researchers say, the picture that emerged is worrying.

Since 2000, the number of butterflies in the United States has fallen by 22%, on average, researchers report [...] in the journal *Science*. Butterfly abundance dropped in every part of the country, across a wide variety of species. "It doesn't sound like much, but 1 or 2% decline per year of any group is absolutely phenomenal when you compound that over more than one decade," says David Wagner, a biologist at the University of Connecticut [...]. "The tree of life is being denuded at unprecedented rates."

Only about 3% of the 554 species examined saw their numbers increase over this time period. Those more successful species tended to be ones that thrive closer to human development, the researchers found. [...] "The median species declined by more than 40%. That was where it really hit me that this is really big."

Butterfly numbers fell in every region of the country, though the southwest saw the biggest drop. Overall, it didn't matter much if the butterflies were big or small, specialized in living on certain plants or were generalists, or lived in moist or dry habitats — all sorts fared worse over the two decades. [...]

Large-scale conversion of natural lands, for agriculture or other kinds of development, have shrunk the habitats butterflies need to thrive. Pesticides used in farming are directly harming many species, especially in the Midwest. And climate change is pushing critters out of their comfort zones. [...]

These forces are likely driving declines in other, harder-to-study insects, from beetles to wasps, says Wagner. "If butterflies are declining at 1.3% a year, we can bet that these 10 million other species that share our planet and make it run are in trouble, too. Nature collapses without them." [...]

Adapted from *NPR*
March 2025
(452 words)

CAN A DOPAMINE DETOX RESET YOUR BRAIN?

Popular among Silicon Valley types, the idea is to abstain from quick-hit rewards in the hope of rediscovering simpler pleasures.

The claim is that all these vices overstimulate the brain's dopamine system, causing it to become "less responsive" and leaving people disillusioned and burnt out. A few weeks of abstinence, enthusiasts claim, can "reset" the brain.

[...] But where it goes wrong is the biochemistry. Proponents imagine that dopamine is the "pleasure molecule"; a finite resource that can be exhausted by overuse. That is not how dopamine works. It is involved not just in reward, but also in learning and movement. Fully "detoxing" from it would be disastrous. Parkinson's disease, for example, is caused by the loss of dopamine-producing neurons. Even the chemical's role in the brain's reward circuitry is widely misunderstood. "Dopamine is clearly not the pleasure molecule," says a neuroscientist at the University of Geneva.

Instead, bursts of it signal surprise – what scientists call a reward-prediction error. When something turns out better than expected, dopamine-producing neurons fire more often than usual. These spikes are teaching signals, strengthening connections between neurons and helping the brain learn which actions are worth repeating. A similar process, known as reinforcement learning, is used to train many modern artificial-intelligence models.

Eventually behaviour that used to be deliberate, such as selecting an app to message a friend, can become automatic: opening it absent-mindedly every time your phone lights up. Habits can be useful. They save the brain from having to think things through from first principles every time. But they can also be traps. Once a behaviour has become habitual, it can persist even when the outcome itself provides no pleasure.

Although taking a break from any harmful habit is a good idea, the idea of "dopamine hits" is most associated with social media. In many ways, apps are designed to be habit-forming, says a neuroscientist at Cambridge University, with algorithmic feeds providing a steady flow of low-effort, unpredictable rewards. The dopamine-fasters are right that pausing your use can interrupt this loop—though that happens through normal brain plasticity, not by replenishing dopamine.

Several studies have tested what happens when people take time away from social media. Most find that brief breaks do little for well-being, perhaps because there are short-term costs to being disconnected from social networks. When entire social groups ditch the apps for longer, results seem better. In one school-wide experiment in Britain, conducted by researchers from the University of York, students avoided social media for three weeks and, afterwards, reported better sleep and mood.

A dopamine detox, in other words, may well be worth trying – even if the mechanism by which it supposedly works is muddled.

Adapted from *The Economist*
November 2025
(452 words)

CAN BOWHEAD WHALES WITH THEIR 200-YEAR LIFESPAN HELP US TO SLOW AGEING?

With a maximum lifespan of more than 200 years, the bowhead whale lives longer than any other mammal. But how the 80-tonne beasts survive so long has never been fully explained.

Now scientists have found hints of an answer and are drawing up plans to see whether the same biological trick can be performed in humans. If so, it raises hopes for boosting healthy ageing and protecting organs and tissues during surgery and transplantations, they say.

“We were looking to understand the mechanisms of the exceptional longevity of the bowhead whale, the longest-living mammal,” said a Biology Prof at the University of Rochester in New York. “What we found is that maybe part of the mechanism is through very accurate and efficient repair of DNA breaks.”

All living organisms suffer DNA damage over the course of their lives. Cells attempt to mend the damage, but the repairs are not always effective. This leads to mutations building up over time, which can raise the risk of cancer and drive ageing by impairing how well cells and tissues function.

The researchers found that bowhead whales were particularly good at repairing a form of DNA damage [...]. As a result, the whales acquired fewer mutations. “What we’re finding is that these kinds of repairs are very important for long life” [...].

Through a series of experiments on whale cells, they showed that DNA repair is enhanced by a protein called CIRBP, which is triggered by cold exposure. Bowhead whales spend their lives in Arctic waters and produce 100 times more CIRBP than humans.

“This strategy, which does not eliminate damaged cells but faithfully repairs them, may be contributing to the exceptional longevity and low cancer incidence in the bowhead whale,” the researchers wrote in *Nature*.

The team went on to explore what happened when they increased levels of CIRBP in human cells. Boosting the protein doubled the proportion of double-strand breaks that cells repaired. Further experiments on flies showed that extra CIRBP increased their lifespan and made them more resilient to mutation-causing radiation. [...]

How big a role DNA repair plays in the bowhead whale’s longevity is unclear, but the researchers are now raising mice with boosted CIRBP to see how long they live. They also hope to test whether cold-water swimmers, or those who take cold showers, have raised levels of the protein, and how persistent any boost might be. [...]

A Professor who studies DNA damage and repair at the UK Dementia Research Institute at the University of Cambridge, said: “[...] translating this into humans will be far from straightforward, demanding a balance between resilience and the body’s natural limits on renewal.”

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(453 words)

CHICKEN RUN TURNED ME VEGETARIAN

By the age of 15, I was already torn between my love of animals and the deliciousness of a [...] McDonald's Mayo Chicken. As a child I was a fussy eater [...] but as I got older I found it harder to justify eating meat. A lifelong animal lover [...] I never missed an opportunity to pet a neighbourhood dog or say hello to a group of cows in a field.

So, going into my teenage years, I knew that eating meat was not really compatible with my way of thinking. But like most I found it easy enough to put those concerns to one side [...] Until at 15 I got the nudge I needed to take the leap into vegetarianism. It came in the unlikely form of an animated film aimed at five- to 10-year-olds: *Chicken Run*. I have always had a special attachment to the Aardman animation, centred on a group of chickens' desperate attempt to escape the farm where the evil owner Mrs Tweedy is planning to turn them all into pies. [...]

But at the age of 15 my attitude towards what I had previously viewed as an endearingly silly comedy suddenly changed. When I sat down to rewatch the childhood classic, my niggling doubts about my meat-eating habits became impossible to ignore. Suddenly I saw *Chicken Run* for what it really was: a battle between the workers (chickens) and the business owner (Mrs Tweedy). The hardworking hens [...] see no rewards from the profit of their work, only to be degraded even further when Mrs Tweedy sees that they could be more profitable in their death by feeding the people of Britain's insatiable appetite for pies. [...]

[...] Watching such clearcut hero/villain films, you usually want to identify with the hero and their struggle, and Aardman did such a good job depicting the lead hen Ginger that I knew I would never eat a chicken – or any animal – again. I can't pretend that it was the only factor in my dietary decision. I had been learning about battery-farmed hens at school and feeling increasingly aware that my animal-loving tendencies were not compatible with my meat-eating habits. But it was *Chicken Run* that was the final straw.

I cut out all meat immediately, a shock to my entirely carnivorous family. Although we shared a love for *Chicken Run*, no one followed my lead [...]. [...] I never really confessed the role of these fictional chickens in my decision, prioritising environmental concerns and a love for real-life animals in my explanations. To this day, when people ask me why I don't eat meat, I feel people are willing me to say it's a healthy lifestyle choice rather than a question of morality.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(454 words)

CHILDREN BEING SEDATED BY ALGORITHMIC YOUTUBE CONTENT, MPS HEAR

Lots of children's programming made for YouTube is "not entertainment, it's sedation", the UK children's laureate, [a writer celebrated for his outstanding contribution in his field], has warned.

Frank Cottrell-Boyce said "frictionless" programming in which children are "bombarded with information", such as CoCoMelon, a YouTube Kids channel with 180 million subscribers, failed to offer the "stimulation and nourishment" that previous generations had enjoyed.

Speaking to MPs in the opening evidence session of the culture, media and sport committee's inquiry into children's TV and video content, Cottrell-Boyce said research showed that for young children, "repetition is good because you're building familiarity, and slowness is good because you're making life navigable".

"I feel very privileged to have grown up in an era when lots of children's television had those qualities," he said.

The fragmented media landscape meant that children today missed out on the sense of "national unity and national identity" that came with watching the same shows, he said. "Shared culture is disappearing and what's left is an individual anxiety factory. I've been visiting schools for 20 years and I've seen anxiety levels rocket."

Cottrell-Boyce said he feared that platforms such as YouTube gave "the illusion of choice, but because it's algorithmically driven, you default to more and more of the same" [...]. The director of the Children's Media [...] agreed that the children's TV industry was "broken" and that UK production companies were "going to the wall".

Noting that 62% of viewing by under-16s was on YouTube and only 22% on broadcast TV, he said the former had "captured the eyeballs, imaginations and interest of a nation – but they haven't replaced the system that existed before, which is a curated system of content".

He added: "Children's wellbeing is damaged or not fostered by the algorithmic recommendation systems; they're falling down rabbit holes of all sorts of content." He said YouTube did not provide any upfront investment to fund new shows, and that the "creator economy" did not exist for children's TV due to its advertising rules.

As a result, people who made children's content received 80 to 90% less in revenue than other creators, despite the Children's Media Foundation estimating that YouTube made £700m from children's advertising in one year, he said.

YouTube needed a "form of regulation and ratings system" and the government should force the platform to act in the public interest if it does not do so voluntarily, he said. "The algorithm is capable of change ... We would like Google and YouTube to become part of society rather than apart from society," he added.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(448 words)

CLIMATE TALKS ARE GETTING WEIRD

One of the most consequential rounds of global climate negotiations has kicked off in Belém, Brazil, [...] known as COP30 this year. It will be a peek into what the shuffling world order means for the climate we live in now and for generations to come. [...]

This year marks a deadline for countries to submit ramped up national plans to achieve the Paris agreement, about a decade after they struck the deal. So far, more than 110 of the nations that are a member of the Conference of the Parties have done so. [...]

This is where the wheels are starting to come off the process. One government – which happens to be the world's leading oil and gas producer and second biggest climate polluter – certainly isn't falling in line. President Donald Trump signed an executive order this year on his first day in office to pull the US out of the Paris agreement as part of his crusade to boost the fossil fuel industry that backed his reelection. [...]

The US [...] might be shooting itself in the foot by losing a seat at the table where plans come together to shape the future of energy. "Everybody's still marching ahead, and it's really important that this COP shows that even without the US, the Paris agreement is working [...]," said Kaveh Guilanpour, [...] from the Centre for Climate and Energy Solutions. [...]

It's going to be an uphill battle, even aside from the Trump administration's sabotage. A global trend toward inward-looking nationalism has been steadily chipping away at the post-World War II-era of multilateralism. The rise of generative AI has led to soaring electricity demand, and we've seen companies' greenhouse gas emissions grow as a result. [...] Affordability crises have taken centre stage in local politics, with some pundits attempting to blame renewable energy for rising electricity costs even though onshore wind and solar are the cheapest new sources of power to build out in most places in the world. [...]

The bad news is that the most ambitious target of stopping global warming at 1.5 degrees Celsius is probably now out of reach, according to the latest UN emissions report. [...]

We're now roughly looking at between 2.3 and 2.8 degrees of warming this century, based on current climate policies. The better news is that this forecast is still much rosier than [...] when the Paris agreement was adopted [...] and researchers expected about 4 degrees of warming. [...]

The point is that climate change is [...] within our control, and every fraction of a degree of progress makes a difference in the kind of future we have. [...] The negotiations [...] set up what the world's next moves will be.

Adapted from *theverge.com*
November 2025
(450 words)

COLLEGE PROFESSORS ARE TURNING TO CHATGPT TO GENERATE COURSE MATERIALS. ONE STUDENT NOTICED – AND ASKED FOR A REFUND

Ella Stapleton noticed in February that the lecture notes for her [...] class at Northeastern University appeared to have been generated by ChatGPT. Midway through the document was the statement to "expand on all areas. Be more detailed and specific," which could have been a prompt directed to the AI chatbot. [...] She was taken aback, especially because the course syllabus distributed by her professor, Rick Arrowood, prohibited students from using AI.

"He's telling us not to use it and then he's using it himself," Stapleton told *The New York Times* [...]. Stapleton took the matter up with Northeastern's business school in a formal complaint, asking for her tuition for the class back. The total refund would be over \$8,000 for the course. Northeastern denied Stapleton's request [...] the day after she graduated from the university.

Arrowood, [...] who has been an instructor at various colleges for over fifteen years, admitted to *The New York Times* that he had put his class files and documents through ChatGPT to refine them. He said that the situation made him approach AI more cautiously and tell students outright when he uses it.

Stapleton's situation highlights the growing use of AI in higher education. A survey conducted by consulting group Tyton Partners in 2023 found that 22% of higher-education teachers said they frequently utilized generative AI. The same survey conducted in 2024 found that the percentage had nearly doubled [...].

AI use is becoming more prevalent among students, too. OpenAI released a study in February showing that [...] one-third of young adults in the U.S. aged 18 to 24 use ChatGPT, with 25% of their messages tied to learning and schoolwork. [...].

Tyton's [...] survey found that faculties who use AI are tapping into the technology to create in-class activities, write syllabi, generate rubrics for grading student work, and churn out [...] tests. Meanwhile, the study found that students are using AI to help answer homework questions, assist with writing assignments, and take lecture notes.

In response to student AI use, colleges have [...] released guidelines for using ChatGPT and other generative AI. For example, [...] NYU's policy mandates that students receive instructor approval before using ChatGPT.

Universities are also using software to uncover AI use in written materials, like essays. However, *New York Magazine* reported this month that college students are getting around AI detectors by sprinkling typos into their ChatGPT-written papers.

The trend of using AI in college could lead to less critical thinking. Researchers at Microsoft and Carnegie Mellon University published a study [...] that found that humans who used AI and were confident in its abilities used fewer critical thinking skills.

Adapted from *entrepreneur.com*
May 2025
(457 words)

COP30 CLIMATE TALKS DEADLOCK OVER FOSSIL FUELS

Fights over fossil fuels and money appear to have deadlocked the COP30 climate talks [...] and with many delegates already leaving, time is running out to secure a deal.

Host Brazil had hoped countries would agree to set out how to move away from fossil fuels - but a draft deal released on Friday morning failed to mention coal, oil and gas, whose emissions are the main cause of climate change.

That was unacceptable to a group of countries including the UK, while some poorer nations want stronger commitments on cash to help them cope with rising temperatures. [...] All countries present at these annual climate talks have to agree in order to pass a deal. [...] Different nations have competing priorities, based for example on their dependence on fossil fuels, economic position or vulnerability to climate change. [...]

Brazil's President [...] Lula da Silva wanted the talks to secure clearer steps for how countries would move away from coal, oil and gas.

"The world needs a clear roadmap to end its dependence on fossil fuels," he said ahead of the talks. [...] The idea of a "roadmap" had been backed by dozens of countries, including the UK, but strongly opposed by oil-producing nations. Some of these countries argue they should be allowed to exploit their fossil fuel reserves as others have done in the past.

And they have often called for the focus to be on reducing emissions, rather than fossil fuels themselves, through technology like carbon capture.

Many scientists have criticised that approach for failing to tackle the problem at source.

Some developing countries have not backed the fossil fuel deal, because they want richer nations to first deliver money to help them adapt to the impacts of climate change. Richer nations have historically underdelivered on those promises. Poorer countries have repeatedly called for greater support, arguing they are facing the worst impacts of climate change despite bearing relatively little responsibility for rising temperatures. The latest version of the agreement [...] had not a single mention of fossil fuels, which was viewed as unacceptable by many nations. [...]

The draft deal did include a call for efforts to triple finance available to countries by 2030, to help them adapt to climate change. But it did not say if this should come from governments of richer nations or from other sources [...]. President Lula has repeatedly defended fossil fuel development, arguing oil revenues can help fund the move to cleaner energy in Brazil. He has also pointed to his record in slashing rates of deforestation in the Amazon rainforest. Ahead of the talks, President Lula launched a fund to try to prevent the loss of tropical forests around the world. But getting nations to commit to the fund has proved challenging.

Adapted from *BBC News*
November 2025
460 words

COWS PAINTED LIKE ZEBRAS AND PIZZA-EATING LIZARDS: THE IG NOBEL PRIZES ARE BACK

Ever wondered whether painting a cow with zebra stripes might reduce the number of fly bites it gets, or which pizza toppings different kinds of lizards prefer? If so, you're not alone: There are scientists who have studied these and other unusual topics in great detail. Some of them were honored at the Ig Nobel Prize awards ceremony in Boston. The ceremony, which took place at Boston University, celebrates "achievements that first make people laugh, and then make them think." As has become tradition at the irreverent event, the in-person audience honors the winners by making and throwing paper airplanes. [...]

The prizes were presented by genuine Nobel winners. As well as the previously mentioned cow painters and lizard feeders, other winners included a scientist who was awarded the literature prize for recording and analyzing the growth of one of his fingernails for thirty-five years, and a team who won the pediatrics prize for their work looking into the experience of a nursing baby whose mother eats garlic. [...]

Other prize winners included four scientists, who tested the popular theory that drinking alcohol can improve people's ability to communicate in a foreign language, while another pair analyzed the less-explored avenue of "how foul-smelling shoes affects the good experience of using a shoe-rack" from an engineering design perspective. [...]

For Carly York, associate professor of biology at Lenoir-Rhyne University, who was not involved in the awards, this year's winners deliver on their aim of making people laugh and then think. "Beneath every experiment that sounds absurd on the surface lies real insight waiting to be uncovered," said York, whose book explains the importance of curiosity as a driver of scientific progress. "But if the value of this research isn't immediately obvious to you, consider this: Roughly half of all economic growth in the US can be traced back to scientists driven purely by curiosity," she added.

"Basic, curiosity-led research has paved the way for some of the most transformative medical and technological breakthroughs of the past century," said York, who cited the example of how some technology used on DNA grew out of research on how bacteria survive extreme heat. "And yet, this kind of research often gets sidelined in favor of projects with more immediate payoffs. We're seeing that now, as federal cuts hit the National Science Foundation, the largest supporter of basic science," she said. "But [...] basic research builds the foundation of knowledge that makes future breakthroughs possible."

And just in case you're wondering, cows that were painted with zebra-like stripes were nearly fifty percent less likely to endure horsefly bites, and rainbow lizards at a holiday resort in Togo were found to prefer four-cheese pizza.

Adapted from CNN
September 2025
(458 words)

CRUNCHING THE NUMBERS ON GLOBAL WARMING

Some industries are almost impossible to decarbonise. To compensate for these sectors and still reach net-zero emissions, experts agree that carbon capture will be necessary.

Here's how it works: carbon capture, utilisation and storage (CCUS) removes CO₂ directly from the air or from industrial waste gases and then transports it to be reused or stored deep underground, often in depleted gas stores. The removal process, transport, and finding of a suitable storage location are all technologically challenging and very expensive tasks.

CCUS comes with a hefty price tag: The Institute for Energy Economics and Financial Analysis estimates that European carbon capture plans will cost more than 500 billion euros, with as much as 140 billion euros covered by taxpayers. In August 2025, Norway's largest capture facility (owned by the fossil fuel companies and supported through heavy subsidies) stored its first units of carbon, with plans to reach five million tonnes per year. [...]

The brutal reality is that despite all the investment, carbon capture is still not growing to the extent required to make a real dent in our carbon emissions. Around 70 percent of projects planned to launch by 2020 were never realised, and the feasibility of ongoing projects remains questionable due to high costs, technical bottlenecks, and public opposition. [...]

Why, then, is Europe still spending so much on CCUS? Lobbying by the fossil fuel industry plays a role. Civil groups largely criticise carbon capture as a technique for industries to justify continued emissions with the argument that the carbon can simply be removed. In practice, CCUS could delay the shift to renewables and divert investment from less costly and more effective emission-reducing measures. In fact, 70 percent of current projects use the captured carbon in oil recovery processes instead of storing it, resulting in yet more new emissions. [...]

Still, the reality is that despite current failures, we're going to need it. Beyond massive emissions reductions, which should be the first and main priority by far, scientific consensus is that carbon capture is a necessary component towards zero emissions. CCUS should be strictly limited to industries like cement, steel, and chemical production, that are nearly impossible to decarbonise or where there aren't feasible alternatives. So far, 65 percent of the capture capacity we do have is employed at natural gas plants, while only 10 percent of the capacity is going towards industry. Instead, it should only be employed where carbon pollution is unavoidable. Further, a new study revealed that the global carbon storage capacity is 10 times less than previous estimates – we're running out of space before we've even begun.

Adapted from *The European Correspondent*
October 2025
(445 words)

DESPITE ALL THE GLOOM AT HOME, BRITAIN'S REPUTATION IS SURPRISINGLY BRIGHT

At home, Britain-bashing is a national pastime. But across four broad areas – foreign policy, business, culture and technology – Britain's international stock is in fact rising.

First, foreign policy. Britain has quietly rebuilt some of the diplomatic influence it squandered in the Brexit years. It can do little to alter the structural decline in power relative to America and China. But it can still aspire to punch above its weight. Defence's rise in the West's agenda has helped. Britain is one of the five nuclear-armed states with a permanent seat on the UN Security Council. It is a muscular member of NATO and its signals-intelligence service, GCHQ, makes it a pillar of the "Five Eyes" intelligence-sharing elite, with America, Australia, Canada and New Zealand. Sir Keir Starmer, the prime minister, has impressed European leaders with his ability to convene allies and stake out tricky positions, like his early call to boost defence spending at the cost of aid. Restored trust has helped Britain's "reset" with the EU and smoothed the way to bilateral deals with France and Germany.

On business, the second area, the Labour government has done Britain's reputation no favours by imposing higher taxes and extra regulations. Even so, this year's survey of 5,000 global business leaders by PwC, a consultancy, placed Britain as the second-most-attractive country for investment (behind America) [...]. Though Britain was hit by Donald Trump's tariffs in April, it was the first to strike a deal to mitigate them. Britain has pulled out all the stops, including a state visit with the king, to flatter Mr Trump. So far, it is working. "Together, we've done more good for humanity than any two countries in all of history," said Mr Trump at his Windsor Castle banquet [...].

Brand Britain's third key area is culture. Around 86% of the £5.6bn spent on British-made productions last year came from abroad. Ted Sarandos, the boss of Netflix, a streaming giant, has called Britain "one of the best countries in the world" for making television and films. Pinewood Studios, west of London, is set to become the world's biggest studio lot, with 51 stages [...].

Brainpower is also key to the final area: technology. Though it cannot compete with juggernauts like America or China, Britain has strengths in niches. Critically, those include artificial intelligence (AI). Britain "is in a 'Goldilocks' circumstance", said the head of Nvidia, a maker of AI chips. Britain, he told a tech conference in June, "has one of the richest AI communities anywhere on the planet". He said it's "the envy of the world" [...].

Adapted from *The Economist*
November 2025
(445 words)

EVOLUTION MAY EXPLAIN WHY WOMEN LIVE LONGER THAN MEN

We now have a better idea of why women live longer than men thanks to an analysis of the differences in lifespan between male and female mammals and birds.

The average global life expectancy is about 74 years for women and 68 years for men. There are various ideas to explain this phenomenon, including the suggestion that young men are more likely to die in accidents or conflicts, and that women are better protected against potentially harmful mutations in the sex-determining chromosomes than men, but the picture is far from complete.

To search for clues from other animals, a team of German researchers analysed data on life expectancy in 1176 species – 528 mammals and 648 birds – in zoos and in wild populations. They found that in 72 per cent of the mammal species, females live longer than males. But in birds, males tend to outlive females in 68 per cent of the species.

One of the reasons could be because of sex chromosomes. In mammals, females, who have 2 copies of the same chromosome, are better protected against harmful mutations because the second copy of the X chromosome acts as a backup, while males have two different sex chromosomes, an X and a Y.

In birds, females have two different sex chromosomes, called Z and W, while males have two Z chromosomes. So the different life expectancy trends in mammals and birds back up the idea that the sex with 2 different chromosomes has a shorter life. But the researchers found exceptions. [...]

Digging deeper into the data, the researchers found that mating systems seem to play a role too. In polygamous mammals where there is strong competition for mates – such as gorillas – males generally die earlier than females. This may be due to the large body size needed for mating competition that includes fights. Males that invest in costly traits to win mates may have shorter lifespans as a result. [...]

The researchers also found, even though there were exceptions, that the sex that invests more in raising offspring tends to live longer. In mammals, this is often the females. In long-lived species like humans or other primates, this is probably evolutionarily advantageous, because it helps females survive until their offspring are sexually mature themselves. [...]

Finally, the lifespan differences between sexes were also found to be smaller in zoo populations than in wild populations, probably because life in captivity minimizes environmental pressures and diseases which might also be why lifespan differences between the sexes in humans have been shrinking, although they might never go away entirely.

Adapted from *New Scientist*
October 2025
(458 words)

EXERCISE AND THERAPY CAN MEND A BROKEN HEART

Doctors may have discovered the secret to mending a broken heart in a world-first clinical trial.

Hundreds of thousands of people worldwide are living with takotsubo syndrome, known as broken heart syndrome [...]. It is usually triggered by severe emotional or physical stress, such as losing a loved one.

Patients may experience symptoms similar to a heart attack and face twice the risk of dying early compared with the general population. Some experience heart failure, resulting in debilitating symptoms such as fatigue, as well as a shorter life expectancy. There is no cure.

But now, doctors may have the answer. The world's first randomised controlled trial for broken heart syndrome has found that 12 weeks of tailored cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT), or a heart recovery exercise programme involving swimming, cycling and aerobics, helped patients' hearts recover. [...]

Dr David Gamble, a clinical lecturer in cardiology at the University of Aberdeen, who presented the research, said: "In takotsubo syndrome, there are serious effects on the heart, which may not return to normal. We know that patients can be affected for the rest of their lives and that their long-term heart health is similar to people who have survived a heart attack. [...] It shows that cognitive behavioural therapy or exercise could help patients along the road to recovery. Both are very cost-effective interventions, and we hope that further studies could lead to them being used to help this underserved group."

The study involved 76 patients with takotsubo syndrome, [...] who were randomly assigned to receive CBT, the exercise programme, or standard care. All received all other care and treatment recommended by their cardiologist.

The CBT group had 12 one-to-one weekly sessions, adapted specifically to their condition by the researchers, as well as daily support if needed. The exercise group went through a 12-week exercise course, which included cycling machines, treadmills, aerobics and swimming, gradually increasing in number of sessions and intensity each week. [...]

The average distance that patients that had CBT could walk in six minutes increased. [...] There was also an increase in patients' VO2 max – their body's maximum oxygen consumption at peak exercise in the CBT group and in the exercise group. Increases in walking distance and VO2 max are signs of improvement in health.

The findings suggest the treatments could produce long-term benefits such as reducing symptoms and the risk of dying for those with broken heart syndrome, experts said. [...]

"People may not be as surprised that an exercise programme helped heart patients, but it is intriguing that this study also showed that cognitive behavioural therapy improved heart function and patients' fitness. More research is needed to find out whether these approaches improve survival or symptoms over the long term."

Adapted from *The Guardian*
August 2025
(459 words)

FAST-FASHION RECYCLING IS MAKING INDIAN FACTORY WORKERS SICK

[...] Panipat, in north India, is known as the “waste capital of the world”. Shipments of discarded clothing from Europe, North America and east Asia are shredded here by thousands of workers [...] and woven into rugs [...] and cushions destined for international retailers.

Nearly six years ago, Devi [...] came to Panipat with her husband [...]. Today, she works six days a week, often with her young sons by her side due to the lack of on-site childcare facilities. But the clothes she recycles each day are making her sick. She coughs [...] long after she leaves the factory, and visits to the doctor have become routine. “The doctor tells me it’s because of all this dust I breathe every day,” she says. “He gives me medicine, but it only works while I take it. Once I stop, the coughing comes back. He says I should leave this work. But I can’t afford to.”

The city of Panipat recycles approximately 1 million tonnes of textile waste annually through its 20,000 industrial units and a workforce of at least 300,000, diverting large volumes of discarded textiles that might otherwise end up in landfill worldwide. Shipments arriving through ports [...] are transported here, where the clothes are first sorted: garments that are wearable are diverted to markets. [...]

International studies have shown that long-term exposure to microfibres – especially nylon – [...] poses serious risks to lung tissue. [...] Devi’s father-in-law, the first in the family to move to Panipat nearly two decades ago, spent years working in one of the city’s mills. [...] His lung damage is so severe that even swallowing food triggers choking or pain as he struggles to breathe. Doctors at the local government hospital have told the family the damage is irreversible. [...]

A government doctor [...] says lung disease [...] is alarmingly common. “Most of the patients we see have spent years in the textile factories,” he says. “They breathe in dust, fibres and chemicals every day. Microfibres settle in their lungs with continuous exposure, and many are never properly diagnosed. That makes them far more vulnerable – not just to infections like tuberculosis, but also to long-term chronic lung diseases.”

[...] Conditions inside many factories are terrible. “The working environment is insufferable,” he says. “We routinely come across cases of breathing issues, migraine, skin infections, even cancer.” [...]

The damage to human health is also not limited to those working within the factories. On the outskirts of Panipat, there are about [...] 400 registered dyeing units and at least 200 more that operate illegally. An estimated 80% of wastewater from these units is released directly into the environment, contaminating surface and groundwater.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(443 words)

FINANCIAL STRESS CAN DAMAGE YOUR MENTAL HEALTH

[...] With people afraid to look at their retirement accounts and others fretting about a possible recession and layoffs – fear around our individual and collective financial future can feel overwhelming.

There's no denying having financial reserves helps people get through financial instability, but some research suggests there are other factors that matter as much – or more – when it comes to people's physical and mental health.

The way people think about their financial circumstances makes a significant difference in how well they weather the situation, says [...] a professor of social work at the University of North Dakota who studies the way financial instability impacts people.

A study he published in 2023 showed that how a person felt about a decline in income mattered to their emotional well-being 20 times more than the actual financial change itself.

"It was the perception that – was it a catastrophe or was it a minor thing?" the professor says, describing the way that people in his research approached the problem of financial insecurity. He says the narratives people told themselves about money "played a much bigger role in determining how a person was feeling about their financial health," than their actual financial reserves.

People who can experience a financial setback as temporary, he says, may be able to remain relatively calm and move through it, while some might experience the same setback as a disaster – one that triggers intense stress that can spiral into serious health problems, like depression, substance abuse, high-blood pressure and heart problems.

This is not to suggest that money doesn't matter, says the professor. If people can't pay the mortgage or get food on the table, that's a crisis. But he says his research shows that how people deal with that crisis can make things better – or worse. [...]

One of the factors that keeps people from moving on after a job loss is the grief that they can feel for the identity they built around the job. Recognizing and processing this grief is important, he says.

"People who didn't know how to handle that loss of identity," struggled to move on after job loss, he says. "That's what made it perhaps an even bigger catastrophe than just simply having a reduction in income." That said, it's not necessarily an easy process. [...]

One thing that can help ameliorate job loss specifically is finding new ways to use existing skills through things like side hustles or volunteering, he says. Even if the jobs don't pay, these kinds of activities can help people find new paths forward, he says. They help give people purpose, and allow people to eventually reinvent themselves.

Adapted from *NPR*
April 2025
(444 words)

FORGET ELECTRIC VEHICLES. CYCLING IS REVOLUTIONISING TRANSPORT

To understand why urban planners like bicycles, stand on a street in Montreal and count the vehicles going by. Over a ten-minute period at rush hour, correspondents counted around one hundred bicycles flowing one way. In the adjacent lane eighty cars and one city bus moved by at a crawl. Any more cars would jam it. Yet there is still plenty of space in the bike lane, which on a single day in June was used by more than fourteen thousand cyclists. Over the past decade or so, Montreal has become North America's leading cycling city. [...]

Though robotaxis have notched up impressive growth, they seem lacking compared with far zippier pedal-powered rivals. Waymo, a self-driving taxi firm, claims that its cars do around two hundred and fifty thousand trips a week. Yet in New York alone that number of trips is made every three days using the city's bike-share scheme. [...]

One reason for this cycling renaissance was the advance in e-bike technologies, which made them cheaper and more fun to ride. By helping cyclists pedal, these open up riding to a much wider range of people. They are especially useful for transporting goods, which is hard going if done by pedal power alone. The second reason is the spread of bike-friendly infrastructure. Bicycles mostly died out as a form of transport in the mid 20th century not only because cars were faster and more comfortable, but also because cars made cycling catastrophically dangerous. In 1950 at least eight hundred cyclists were killed on the roads in Britain – ten times the number killed last year. Bike lanes create cyclists because they largely eliminate the risk of being crushed by careless drivers. Surveys show that rates of cycling are higher in countries where cyclists feel safest. [...]

E-bikes do raise some problems. Because they are heavier and go faster, accidents can be worse than on traditional bikes. E-bikes in London have been blamed by doctors for a surge in broken legs. In the Netherlands cyclist deaths hit a record high in 2022. E-bike riders face death rates that are sharply higher than for riders of normal bikes. Worries about teenagers getting injured have led neighbourhoods in America to ban electric bikes. These challenges will slow the readoption of the bicycle. Still, in cities that have made them mainstream, the idea of going back is considered ridiculous. In the Netherlands a former prime minister made a point of riding to work. In Denmark last year King Frederik arrived at a charity event with his two sons in the front box of an electric cargo bike.

Adapted from *The Economist*
October 2025
(442 words)

FRENCH STUDENTS ARE CHOOSING CANADA OVER THE US

The number of French students in Canada has increased fivefold in 20 years, climbing from around 5,000 in 2000 to 24,000 in 2023. [...]

What's driving this increase? What motivates French citizens to pursue their studies in Canada? [...] These are some of the questions we sought to answer in a research project carried out in 2023 and 2024 in collaboration with the French Embassy in Canada. Our research was based on an online survey of 220 French students and graduates in Canada, as well as 30 qualitative interviews.

One factor driving the increase of French students coming to Canada is the way Canada is presented to them. Canada is perceived as a "kind and peaceful" country, in contrast to the United States, which is associated with "gun culture" and inequality. [...]

Some aspects of student life in France are perceived as restrictive. This encourages students to leave and study in Canada. The French education system, often described as rigid and top down, is frequently compared to the Canadian model, which is considered less hierarchical and more vocational. [...]

Beyond academic and professional ambitions, French students often describe studying in Canada as an opportunity for personal transformation and a way to see the world.

Bilingualism also motivates them. Many share the goal of learning or perfecting their English. Some institutions with a bilingual curriculum, such as the University of Ottawa, are seen as environments where they can achieve this. [...]

Career opportunities are another major asset. Internships, specialized courses and student jobs are all ways for students to familiarize themselves with the local working world and start building a professional network. [...]

For many French students, their Canadian adventure starts out as a temporary project. However, among the graduates, 60 per cent end up choosing to stay in Canada, compared with 40 per cent who return to France. [...]

Canadian officials have been encouraging higher education institutions to accept more French students for many years. Global Affairs Canada ranks France as one of its "priority" countries. Encouraging French-speaking immigration is also part of a language policy strategy, with the particular objective of reaching eight per cent of French-speaking newcomers outside Québec by 2027.

In France, meanwhile, the increasing number of students in Canada and the prospect of their long-term settlement are prompting fears of a brain drain. But it's overly simplistic to view students "voting with their feet" in favor of Canada or against France. Instead, this movement of students and graduates is evidence that transnational pathways and mobile study experiences are becoming the norm.

Adapted from *The Conversation*
May 2025
(441 words)

FROM GRASSROOTS TO STATES, LET WOMEN LEAD

This year, as the United Nations convenes for its 80th general assembly and the world watches, we believe there is no issue more urgent than the rise of female African leaders. From peace and education to health and climate, women are not just affected by crises, they are leading the solutions.

It is time for funders, policymakers, multilateral institutions and development agencies to step up, boldly invest and ensure that African women are empowered to lead.

Sub-Saharan Africa is poised to be the fastest-growing region in the world. It has a burgeoning youth population, with millions of young people entering adulthood each year.

Africa's destiny will be shaped by those who lead it. And women and girls account for a large and growing share of this demographic rise. Across Sub-Saharan Africa there are about 145 million adolescent girls, and Africa's population of girls under the age of 18 is predicted to increase to approximately 465 million by the middle of this century.

These numbers are not abstract. They mean that for good or ill, the kind of leadership we support today, including that of women, will determine whether Africa's youth become a source of stability, hope and innovation – or fuel for instability, exclusion and crisis.

Around the world, we have seen what happens when young people feel left behind and not fully represented. This is where female leaders come in.

Across peacekeeping, education, hunger, health and climate, African women play integral roles. In conflict settings, female peacekeepers, mediators and negotiators are indispensable. African countries such as Ethiopia, Ghana and Rwanda are among some of the largest contributors of female peacekeepers worldwide. These women restore trust, build bridges with communities, protect women and children during conflict and bring gender-sensitive perspectives to negotiations. Security is never gender neutral.

In education, millions more girls are attending school across eastern and southern Africa than just a decade ago. Sustaining and expanding that progress requires leadership with a clear eye on equity. Female leaders have consistently pushed for safe schools, invested in teachers and championed girls' access to science and technology.

In health, the story is the same. Where women lead, maternal mortality falls, child health improves and services reach those most in need. During the Covid-19 pandemic, many of the most effective responses came from female African leaders who mobilised health workers, ensured that vaccines reached communities and demanded global fairness in distribution.

While women's rights worldwide are under attack, Africa continues to show examples of pioneering progress. Rwanda's parliament, of which more than 60% of MPs are female, stands as a global leader.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
September 2025
(454 words)

GEN Z CONFRONTS FAMILIAR WORKPLACE CRITICISM AGAIN

Gen Z is undisciplined, apparently; entitled, some critics claim; and purportedly hates work. One viral column in the Wall Street Journal went so far as to suggest this entire generation was potentially “unemployable”.

As younger employees establishing themselves at work continue to face relentless criticism from the higher rungs of corporate America, those old enough to remember the arrival of the last generation could be forgiven for experiencing a sense of déjà vu.

Millennials were once derided as lazy, entitled, delusional, narcissistic and unreliable, too: many of the same accusations now leveled at gen Z. “Every generation tends to complain about the one next to us,” said Adam Grant, an organizational psychologist at Wharton Business School. “Everyone used to hate millennials, and now it’s gen Z.

“We tend to compare the younger generation to our current selves, which is a mistake because most people are more narcissistic and self-centered at age 20 than they are at age 40. That’s part of development and maturity.” [...]

Older generations also tend to directly compare their strengths with younger generations’ weaknesses, according to Grant – exaggerating the divide and often painting the younger generation in an unfairly negative light. [...]

Gen Z grew up watching institutions, both financial and political, fail to deliver on promises of stability and wealth, planting a deep lack of faith, said Grant – and, for many younger workers, any implicit trust between employee and employer is no more.

“Gone are the times when you took a job with one employer, and you stayed there for 35 years, and you plan to retire there, and you expected them to take care of you,” said Grant. “If you look at the number of downsizing and mass layoffs that have happened, those are major betrayals to the employees.”

This generation is different to its predecessors, in some respects. Flexibility, purpose and employees’ wellbeing matter more than overtime and promotions, according to Madeline Miller, a leadership and culture strategist. “Gen Z are starting to say: ‘I’m tired and I’m going to get nothing out of this,’” she said.

Gen Z does not see the value in overtime and focuses on “smart work”, optimizing artificial intelligence tools to complete a 10-hour task in just five hours instead, according to Shah, a tech worker. A Deloitte survey published earlier this year found that over half of gen Z employees reported using AI regularly in their work. [...]

Companies that dismiss or write off gen Z staff ultimately put their overall performance at risk, according to Grant, who said both older managers and their younger staff can benefit from ditching stereotypes and learning from each other.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(447 words)

GEN Z VALUE 'POWER, ACHIEVEMENT, HEDONISM AND STIMULATION MORE THAN OTHER GENERATIONS'

Baby boomers are all conservative and selfish and unable to send an email unassisted; millennials are all lazy and entitled and obsessed with avocados. These are just a few of the totalising, reductive stereotypes that are often thrown about in the media, even if it's clear that these sweeping generalisations simply aren't true. A new landmark global study from strategic communications consultancy, BCW, has even found that talk about gaping generational divides are usually overblown, and that "regardless of age, we are all primarily social, caring, safety-seekers".

That said, the same study found Gen Z – born between 1997 and 2012 – stand out as valuing "power, achievement, hedonism and stimulation" more than other age groups. So, basically, we're all power-hungry thrill-seekers.

The study found that 44 per cent of Gen Z thought it was important to be very successful and have people recognise their achievements. 32 per cent of Gen Z believe it is important to be rich, compared with just 26 per cent of millennials and 16 per cent of Gen X.

Social media, the researchers claim, has a lot to do with this. "Younger generations have grown up in highly digitised societies in which peers' achievements are broadcast on social media, affording a window into the highlights of other people's lives," strategy director at BCW wrote in the report. "As a result, it's no wonder that younger generations focus so much on realising, and being seen to be realising, their highest potential."

The report also acknowledged that "young people have always been motivated by ambition, to progress and achieve personal success as well as social standing and power," and noted that this trend may be more pronounced among Gen Z given the economic challenges they are facing. This makes sense: in the UK, for example, Gen Z have grown up in the era of austerity and even the oldest members of the cohort will struggle to remember a time when the state adequately supported people. They've grown up thinking that inadequate welfare is 'normal', and that the only way to progress in life – or even just to stay afloat, given that the cost of living crisis is still very much raging on – is to focus on yourself and hustle.

43 per cent of Gen Z also said it was important "to do things that can give them pleasure" and that they "seek every chance they can to have fun", falling to 38 per cent of millennials and 27 per cent of Gen X.

Essentially, though, no generation is homogenous, and Gen Z is no exception.

Adapted from *Dazed digital magazine*
June 2023
(447 words)

GEN Z-ERS DON'T LOVE EMAIL. IT'S DRIVING THEIR COWORKERS CRAZY.

Tech worker Sam, 26, checks his work email once per day at most. “I think you are *supposed* to check your email three times a day, like once in the morning, mid-day and before you log off,” he tells Yahoo. But that’s not always true for him — and yes, it has landed him in a few sticky situations. (...)

There has been a lot of conversation around Gen Z in the workplace over the past few years, particularly regarding what seems to be a vast dissonance between traditional expectations of office etiquette and how younger workers approach their jobs. From the discourse around (...) what’s really appropriate to wear to work, new terms like “quiet quitting” and “soft life” that have gone viral online and statistical generational trends like their preference for working alone, it’s clear that Gen Z is ushering in a new era of workplace manners that’s distinct from the generations before them.

One of those things is the difference in email etiquette. (...) “I think Boomers and Gen X definitely rely on emails a lot more,” Sam says. “I noticed that when I was previously working in a team with older people, they like to have full-on conversations on email sometimes for more important communication, whether it is formal or informal. Whereas my current team is a lot younger, most of the communication, regardless of urgency, happens on Slack (*a cloud-based team communication platform*), with emails being a secondary communication tool.”

Sam thinks that the preference of prioritizing work messaging platforms is in part due to the shifting landscape of emailing as a whole. He currently has over 10,000 unread emails in his work inbox, which he says are mostly automated notifications and random reports.

“At least in my office, Slack communication replaces a lot of office day-to-day communication, so that email becomes almost like a tool only for important memos,” he says. (...) “Otherwise important memos get buried in an inbox full of fairly unimportant information.” (...)

At 29, Anna is technically a *zillennial* but says she has experienced the shift in email culture between a millennial-dominated workplace and a Gen Z prevalent one. (...) She believes that factors like more frequent automated newsletters, a strong anti-work culture among young people and the rise in remote work have all played a part in this change. (...) “I grew up job hunting and corresponding with people professionally. (...) It might feel different for people who feel as though they are always, to some degree, online. But I do think that the shift in email etiquette is a part of Gen Z’s larger mentality of, ‘I’m not doing more than I asked for.’ Honestly, I think that’s the right thing.”

Adapted from *uk.yahoo.com*
November 2025
(457 words)

GERMANY DRAWS UP LAW TO ALLOW POLICE TO SHOOT DOWN DRONES

German police will be allowed to shoot down drones under new legislation aimed at increasing safety after a spate of sightings across Europe.

Rogue drones, which have not been attributed to a specific owner, have disrupted air traffic across the continent in recent weeks. Some have been spotted over hospitals, canals, armaments factories and other sites of critical infrastructure in Germany.

Leaders from Germany and elsewhere say they are wrestling with how to deal with the relatively new challenge and believe the drones originated from Russian controllers, who are using them as part of the Kremlin's hybrid war on the continent.

On Wednesday, the German cabinet agreed on a draft law authorising police to down drones that pose an immediate threat. The legislation now needs parliamentary approval.

In a post on social media, the chancellor, Friedrich Merz, said the legislation was meant to increase security in Germany. "Drone incidents threaten our safety," he said. "We will not allow that. We are strengthening the powers of the federal police so that drones can be detected and intercepted more quickly in future." A sign near the Reichstag says drones are illegal in the city centre.

The law has been written swiftly in response to recent incidents including drone sightings over Munich airport last Thursday, which caused the cancellation of dozens of flights, stranding thousands of passengers.

The origin of the drones has yet to be identified. Authorities said they were not armed and were being used for surveillance. Merz has said he believes Russia was behind that and other similar incidents.

Once passed, the legislation would bring Germany in line with other countries such as France, Britain, Romania and Lithuania, which have extended the powers of their security forces to take out drones that are unlawfully in their airspace.

The interior minister, Alexander Dobrindt, announced the creation of a dedicated counter-drone unit within the federal police. It will hold regular consultations with Ukraine and Israel, given their extensive experiences in using the latest drone technology.

Dobrindt said the new legislation would help to clarify which authorities had the power to carry out which action against the drones. Police would be authorised to deal with smaller drones flying at about tree level, whereas the military would be expected to deal with larger and more powerful machines, he said.

This year up to the end of September, Germany has recorded one hundred seventy two drone-related interruptions to air traffic, compared with one hundred twenty nine in the same period last year and one hundred twenty one in 2023, according to the German Aviation Security organisation (DFS).

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(444 words)

GERMANY'S CONSERVATIVES EYE RETURN TO COMPULSORY MILITARY SERVICE

BERLIN – Germany may need to turn to compulsory measures to get more soldiers into the ranks of its depleted military, say senior lawmakers from Chancellor Friedrich Merz's conservatives. The government is drafting legislation to revitalize a shrinking Bundeswehr, but so far efforts to recruit more troops have relied on voluntary measures. Now, senior conservative lawmakers are warning that they may have to be backed up by a return to the draft.

"If it turns out that the significant personnel needs for a Bundeswehr capable of defense and deterrence, especially in light of the new NATO plans, cannot be met through a purely voluntary model, compulsory elements will have to be introduced," said Thomas Erndl, who represents the Christian Democrats on the parliamentary defense committee.

The new model of military service is expected to include a limited registration process aimed at identifying young people who show interest or potential for service. But that is not conscription; rather, the goal is to encourage them to sign short-term military contracts on a voluntary basis. [...] The revived military service will "initially" be voluntary [...].

During his address to the German parliament in May, Defense Minister Boris Pistorius [...] also underlined that the emphasis on voluntarism was "initial." "We still have too few people for what our armed forces must accomplish," he said.

However, Pistorius has ruled out any prospect of a return to mandatory service in the immediate future. "Conscription doesn't help us at all right now, because we simply don't have the capacity – not in the barracks, and not in training," he said [...]

Falko Droßmann, the SPD's defense policy spokesperson in parliament, argued that the current debate is "completely missing the real problems we're facing."

Rather than a return to the draft, "I firmly believe that the new military service will be designed in such an attractive way that more than enough young people will choose to sign up voluntarily," he said.

Droßmann also warned that Germany doesn't have the barracks, equipment or infrastructure to handle a massive influx of conscripts. "To train thousands of young people, we also need the necessary accommodations, equipment and instructors," he said. [...]

Germany suspended compulsory military service in 2011, ending a system that had shaped both the armed forces and civilian society. Since then, troop numbers [...] have fallen well short of targets. Military union leaders now warn that up to 260,000 soldiers may be needed for Germany to meet its military obligations.

"We don't believe that relying on volunteers alone will be enough," said Patrick Sensburg, president of the Bundeswehr Reservist Association. "Without conscription, the Bundeswehr won't be able to recruit enough soldiers, and we also won't have a resilient civilian population."

Adapted from *Político*
June 2025
(455 words)

HARVARD STUDENTS SKIP CLASS AND STILL GET HIGH GRADES

Harvard University is one of the most difficult schools to gain admission to, with the school turning away some 97 percent of applicants every year. But once they get in, many of its students skip class and fail to do the reading, according to a report on Harvard's classroom culture. [...]

When they do show up for class, they are focused on their devices, and are reluctant to speak out. Sometimes it is because they are afraid of sharing ideas that others will disagree with. But often, they have not read enough of the homework to make a meaningful contribution, the report continued. Rampant grade inflation allows them to succeed anyway. [...]

That means many students graduate without having benefited from talking very much with their teachers and peers, and they stay stuck in ideological bubbles, unwilling or unable to engage with challenging ideas. [...] The report added that, by not attending class, "students are missing opportunities to hear the perspectives of other students with different viewpoints."

In response, Harvard and its professors have been trying to shift the undergraduate experience this fall, to turn its students into more open-minded and academically engaged people. Some instructors now take attendance. Students are being encouraged to take notes by hand, rather than on their phones or laptops, to avoid digital distractions. And to help students overcome fears about speaking up, professors are adopting rules that bar students from sharing what people say inside. [...]

Classrooms are supposed to be places where there can be a free exchange of ideas [...]. Yet in the spring of 2024, only a third of Harvard seniors said they felt completely free to "express personal feelings and beliefs about controversial topics." [...] They were embarrassed about possibly sounding stupid. They felt that they had to align their viewpoints with their professor's in order to get a good grade. And they chose their classes based on the likelihood of getting a good grade, rather than out of intellectual curiosity. [...]

At Harvard, some students are pushing back against the notion that they are the problem. The competition for internships and, eventually, jobs in fields like law and finance can be ferocious, they say. So they have no choice but to invest significant amounts of time in clubs that will show off their interests and skills, and differentiate them from all the other Harvard students who are getting A's. [...]

Harvard may be partly to blame for encouraging student absences, with a policy that allows students to enroll in two classes that meet at the same time. Dr. Laibson tells his students that in-person learning is better than learning by video. But he also defends the double-scheduling practice because so many classes at Harvard meet at overlapping times.

Adapted from *The New York Times*,
October 2025
(463 words)

HAS AIRBNB REACHED ITS PEAK?

Airbnb began in 2007 with Mr Chesky and two friends renting out an airbed in their living room in San Francisco. The idea of a platform to help people open up their homes to paying guests proved a hit, and soon the trio were peddling properties on behalf of hosts across the world. [...] The booking platform, which boasts more than 8m listings across nearly every country, is “now a grown-up company”, insists Mr Chesky [...].

As bookings ground to a halt with the Covid pandemic, Mr Chesky saw an opportunity to rebuild the company. He fired a quarter of its staff, merged divisions, removed management layers and paused the expansion into experiences. Despite lockdowns, Airbnb’s stockmarket debut in December 2020 was a hit, with its shares more than doubling on the day. When travel resumed, the company roared back to growth as it set about fixing users’ various gripes, including a lack of transparency in fees, too many poor-quality listings and disappointing customer service.

Lately, however, Airbnb’s growth has cooled. The uncertainty wrought by President Donald Trump’s on-and-off tariffs has led consumers to delay booking trips. Policymakers in cities from Paris to New York have implemented restrictions on the platform, which they think contributes to surging house prices. Competition from travel sites such as Booking.com and Expedia is heating up for short-term lets. Web traffic to Airbnb is slowing.

In response, the company is looking for new growth opportunities. It is endeavouring to expand its accommodation business beyond its five core markets of America, Australia, Britain, Canada and France, which represent around half of nights booked through the platform. Airbnb is also moving into hotel bookings [...]. At the same time, Airbnb is branching out from accommodation once again. In May it launched an updated app that offers not just a refreshed set of experiences, including baking with a grandmother in Paris, but also services, such as personal training from a champion bodybuilder in Los Angeles. And in October it introduced social features that allow users who meet through an Airbnb experience to stay in touch. Analysts expect car rentals and a loyalty programme to follow.

There are reasons to be sceptical. Plenty of other sites help people book activities when they travel; [...] Then there is artificial intelligence (AI), which could upend travel. According to a survey this year by McKinsey, a consultancy, 55% of Americans have used OpenAI’s ChatGPT or a similar tool when planning a trip, up from 38% in 2024. Some may start to book rooms directly through these services once it becomes easy to do so.

Adapted from *The Economist*
November 2025
(443 words)

HERE'S WHAT WILL REALLY AFFECT JOBS IN THE AGE OF AI

Is artificial intelligence going to destroy jobs, as some [...] research warns?

[...] Labor market disruption is a real possibility. But the true challenge for governments and businesses is ensuring that workers have the skills and adaptability needed to use the technology. [...]

In one important way, we can take comfort from history. The arc of technological change [...] is one of constant adaptation and growth. The labor market has experienced many transformations, including the dramatic change in the share of employment in agriculture in the United States [...] and the incorporation of women into the workforce in the second half of the 20th century. There have been multiple waves of automation since the [...] Industrial Revolution. Yet the share of Americans who are employed has risen.

Technology typically affects tasks, not entire jobs. A job is, essentially, a bundle of tasks, and eliminating an entire job requires the automation of a significant portion of its duties. In fact, this rarely happens. The 1950 Census listed 271 occupations, but only one – elevator operator – has since disappeared as a result of automation. We think the lessons from history are likely to apply to AI.

That seems to be the case so far. In 2016, it was predicted that AI would replace radiologists within five years. Yet demand for radiologists has surged, because their job is not just to study images but also to analyze medical records, advise doctors, talk to patients and interpret findings. Instead of going extinct, radiologists are thriving by incorporating AI into their workflow. [...]

However, technology's impacts are distributed unevenly, so certain groups will bear more of the transition costs. For example, when [...] [the telephone company] introduced automated switching in the 1920s, it was a major shock for telephone operators. [...]

This is where the key challenge lies now — and here the lessons of history are less encouraging. In many prior waves of technological disruption, [...] support for workers needing to change how they worked or to find other occupations was inadequate. Many who were laid off were unable to find new jobs, and their communities still bear the scars. Policymakers should be thinking [...] about how to manage the transition better this time.

The key is training workers [...]. Since most of our 2030 workforce is already employed, we should meet people where they are and provide opportunities to acquire new skills mid-career. [...]

AI represents an extraordinary economic opportunity, and most signs point to labor markets continuing to thrive, especially in the face of the demographic reality that advanced economies are running out of workers rather than running out of work. [...]

The future is not a forecasting exercise – it's a design challenge.

Adapted from *The Washington Post*
October 2025
(459 words)

HIGHER EDUCATION CHOICES FOR MEN AND WOMEN

How can higher education attract more women in science and technology? For several years, public authorities have been supporting initiatives aimed at promoting gender diversity in these fields of study. There are two main reasons behind these initiatives. On the one hand, the aim is to reduce gender inequalities in the labour market, particularly the pay gap. On the other hand, the objective is to support economic growth in promising fields by training more people who can contribute to innovation in strategic sectors of activity.

The differences in orientation between women and men remain very marked at the start of higher education. This is evident in France, for example, from the choices made by high school seniors on the French platform for accessing post-baccalaureate programmes. Men account for approximately 70% of applicants to science and technology programmes. In order to better understand the current reasons for the differences between women and men in higher education choices, a survey was conducted among a representative sample of the student population in France. One of the striking findings of the survey concerns the differences between women and men in the importance they attach to passion as a determining factor in their higher education choices.

Significantly more female students choose courses related to their passions, and they seem to do so fully aware that these choices may penalise them later on in the job market. In fact, two thirds of women (compared to about half of men) say they prefer to study a subject they are passionate about, even if it does not guarantee a well-paid job, while a third of women (compared to almost half of all men) say they prefer to get a well-paid job, even if it doesn't guarantee that they will study a subject they are passionate about. Women who prioritise passion are more likely to enroll in arts and humanities programmes, while those who prefer a well-paid job are more likely to enroll in science and technology programmes. [...] Also, women appear to have more diverse tastes, this partly explains why women tend to shy away from science and technology courses of study, which may be perceived as requiring them to give up other subjects they enjoy.

If the economy needs more women with degrees in science and technology, how can we attract them to these fields? The main challenge lies in conveying a passion for science and technology to women. This can be achieved by science programmes adapting their educational offerings to make teaching more attractive to female students and by highlighting how science and technology can contribute to the common good and address the challenges of contemporary issues that are important to them.

Adapted from *The Conversation*
October 2025
(455 words)

HOW CAN YOU TELL IF YOUR NEW FAVOURITE ARTIST IS A REAL PERSON?

Do streaming sites have an obligation to label music as AI-generated? And does it even matter, if you like what you hear? A survey published last week suggested 97% of respondents could not spot an AI-generated song. But there are some telltale signs [...]

A song with a formulaic feel - sweet but without much substance or emotional weight - can be a sign of AI, says a musician and technology speaker, as well as vocals that feel breathless. [...] Another tell-tale sign is unrealistic levels of productivity.

A professor from the Minderoo Centre for Technology and Democracy at the University of Cambridge, describes how one artist was recently believed to be AI after dropping multiple soundlike albums simultaneously [...].

“Sometimes, what might stand out is a song that sounds almost too perfect, lacking minor flaws and variances. As well as being used to generate full songs, AI is also becoming a tool some established artists are using to support their creativity. There currently isn't any obligation – or consistent way – for artists to let fans know if and how they are using AI [...]. Some are very open: the Beatles for example, used machine learning to extract the voice of John Lennon from a 1970s cassette recording to release what they called their "last song", *Now and Then*, in 2023” [...]

In January, the streaming platform Deezer launched an AI detection tool, followed this summer by a system which tags AI-generated music. Deezer says its detection system can flag tracks made with the most prolific AI music creation tools, and is working on expanding its ability to detect music made by others.

This week, the company said a third (34%) of content uploaded to its platform was fully AI-generated – about 50,000 tracks a day [...] The tool quickly flagged up the music by The Velvet Sundown – the band who went viral over the summer – as being "100% AI-generated". Other platforms have recently announced steps toward more transparency [...]

And if you've fallen hard for a new artist, does it matter if they or their songs are made by AI? Indeed, some believe the presence of AI is irrelevant – engagement is driven by enjoyment, and music people love is already serving its primary purpose. Others say music fans should be able to make informed choices about what they listen to.

But artists have shared deep concerns around the impact of AI, and hundreds of musicians including Dua Lipa and Elton John have protested about the use of their songs in the training of AI tools.

Adapted from *BBC.com*
November 2025
(446 words)

HOW DOES THE WORLD MEASURE HAPPINESS?

People conceive “living well” and “doing well” to be the same as “being happy,” Aristotle said, [...] “but about the nature of this happiness, men dispute ...”

Contemporary pollsters and policymakers have taken up the matter.

For more than a decade, researchers behind the World Happiness Report have sought to codify a comparative scale for well-being and highlight the places where it flourishes, with the goal of orienting global public policy around human happiness.

Key factors they examine include material well-being, sharing meals, giving to others and helping strangers. “We are very social creatures and actions that help foster connections with others are very likely to offer us happiness,” said Lara Aknin, a professor of social psychology [...] and an editor of this year’s World Happiness Report.

On the flip side: poverty, inequality and a lack of interconnectedness often appear to hamper happiness. In the United States, as families gather for Thanksgiving, the national moment of togetherness comes in stark contrast to a growing trend in everyday life: More than 1 in 4 Americans reported eating all their meals alone on a typical day in 2023, up from 1 in 6 in 2003. [...]

Those who share more meals with others report significantly higher levels of life satisfaction across ages, genders, countries, cultures and regions, according to the World Happiness Report.

In Senegal, for example, people do not make light of lunchtime. Children rush home from school. Office workers head home, too. Teachers and bosses don’t mind – they need to be home for lunch with their families as well, said [...] a teacher and nonprofit worker from Senegal. On average, people eat meals with family or friends almost 12 times a week, more than anywhere else. [...]

In the United States, on the other hand, Thanksgiving – when families gather, sometimes from far corners of the country – is an exception. In general, Americans are spending less and less time eating meals with others. For Americans, dining alone has increased in every age group, but especially among younger people.

“Eating food together, from the same platter, is a tradition that is older than Senegal itself,” [...] said the Senegalese teacher. “It is one of the most important values in our culture and it makes us feel close together and loved.”

The Senegalese custom of multiple families eating together ensures that no one goes hungry, no matter their financial status. Children are taught how to eat from the communal platters without disturbing those sitting beside them from a young age.

“You can scoop the protein and vegetables from the middle, but you have to be sure not to take someone else’s share,” [...]. “It’s a way of showing that you respect the food as well as those sitting beside you.”

Adapted from *The Washington Post*
November 2025
(460 words)

HOW JANE GOODALL CHANGED THE WAY WE SEE ANIMALS & THE WORLD

Jane Goodall, who has died aged 91, changed the world through the way she saw animals. In 1960, when she was 26, she observed a chimp she had named David Greybeard fishing for termites with a twig he had stripped of leaves. [...] She then realized, at a time when human beings were defined as tool-makers, she had just watched a chimp tool-maker in action! When she reported her finding to her mentor, the palaeoanthropologist Louis Leakey, he sent this famous telegram in reply: "Now we must redefine 'tool' and 'man', or accept chimpanzees as humans." [...]

Even though French philosopher René Descartes said animals have no soul and can be considered machines for us to use, Goodall showed that chimps had the intelligence and foresight to design and build tools and she also ascribed them emotions and personalities. In this, her work echoed that of another world-changing scientist with similarly brilliant observational powers, Charles Darwin, who attempted to explain the evolution of facial expressions in animals as well as humans, ascribing them to emotional states. But the establishment rejected it.

Goodall's work in the 1960s was also dismissed and even scorned. It didn't help that she was a young woman with no degree. But now, [...] indeed, we understand that both Darwin and Goodall were right... many animals have feelings, emotions and inner lives. Goodall was chosen by Leakey to study chimpanzees [...] which no one had ever done. He wanted someone who was unbiased by established scientific thinking, and he believed a woman would make a more patient, empathetic field biologist.

At first, her observations of chimps were distant glimpses, through binoculars. But gradually she won their acceptance. Taking a PhD at Cambridge, she would then be reprimanded for giving the animals names instead of numbers, but to her it was natural to name them. [...]

She was also the first scientist to make descriptions of chimp courtship and mating rituals, of their reproductive cycles, and of how experienced mothers introduce their babies to the troop.

In the 1970s, she established the Jane Goodall Institute, a non-profit conservation organisation, to fight against the threat facing the animals and their forests. She also learned about the problems facing people who live near the chimps' habitats.

In 1991 she started an organization aimed at teaching young people about conservation. [...] She wrote 32 books. In her final one, entitled "*The Book of Hope*", she wrote: "I realised that if we couldn't help people find a way of making a living without destroying the environment, there was no way we could try to save the chimpanzees." [...]

Adapted from *New Scientist*
October 2025
(449 words)

HOW LONDON'S SKYSCRAPERS DEPRIVE MARGINALISED PEOPLE OF LIGHT

When you look at the promotional materials advertising luxury high-rise developments in London, it is obvious that the fantasy of living in the sky is fused by a desire for sunlight and “unobstructed” views of the city. Phrases such as “the brightest addition to London’s skyline” or apartments being “flooded with natural light” and offering “expansive sky views” are common. It is a dream with a dark side, however, which plays out below in the shadows of London’s mushrooming cityscape. In a recent paper, the researcher shows how daylight and shadow are unevenly distributed across the urban population. Vulnerable and marginalised residents are disproportionately affected by overshadowing, a lack of privacy and the overbearing nature of new high-rise developments. [...]

When you build tall buildings, it is no surprise that they cast shadows in the surrounding environment. In northern climates, where sunlight is scarce, especially during long, overcast winter days, the compounding effect of living in shadows can be potentially harmful. Scientific studies show that depriving people of daylight can lead to increased stress, sleep disruption and early onset of myopia or short-sightedness. Sudden changes in daylight are also linked to an increased risk of cardiovascular diseases.

To protect the health and wellbeing of residents, the UK’s Building Research Establishment (BRE) issue national planning guidance that sets out minimum daylight levels. Yet, in practice, the guidance is advisory. And in cases where a proposed development breaches the BRE guidelines, they are easily dismissed and breaches often deemed legally acceptable. [...]

Goldpence Apartments, a seven-storey housing block comprising social and affordable homes, was the worst affected block. [...] Research draws attention to the legal process through which the harm resulting from a drop in daylight is both neutralised in the planning inquiry and normalised through the planning process. Levels breaching the BRE regulations would be expected, because neighbouring flats already had poor living conditions. [...]

For the author, this kind of race to the bottom amounts to a form of soft or light violence. It is a legally accepted and politically encouraged erosion of living conditions that disproportionately affects vulnerable and marginalised residents. [...]

The architects who design the towers of tomorrow should be able to uphold standards and produce healthy living environments rather than detract from them. More sensitive daylight design would include considering the orientation of buildings, the size and placement of windows and in some cases using reflective materials or diffusers.

Yet, to ensure healthy living environments for all the residents in the city – both those living on upper floors flooded in natural light, and those living below – city-builders must acknowledge the deeper challenge of addressing the socioeconomic divisions that are created as part of new developments.

Adapted from *The Conversation*
November 2025
(451 words)

HOW NARCISSISM RUINS TEAMWORK

Teamwork can bring out both the best and the worst in people. Working together means sharing ideas and coordinating actions. But sometimes, it can also involve swallowing pride, particularly when people with strong personalities, such as those with narcissism, take charge. [...]

Personality psychologists distinguish between two sides of grandiose narcissism. Narcissistic admiration is the charming, confident, magnetic side that wins people over. Narcissistic rivalry, by contrast, is the defensive, combative side – quick to take offence when its status feels threatened. [...]

In the escape-room experiment, participants were split into small teams of four or five, most meeting for the first time. After a quick ice-breaker, they entered a jungle-themed escape room with 60 minutes to find clues and escape. Success depended on communication, trust and problem-solving: exactly what makes real-world teams thrive.

Before and after the escape-room challenge, players rated themselves and one another on traits like likeability, empathy and confidence. This let us see how first impressions held up when the pressure kicked in. We also measured the two sides of narcissism – admiration [...] and rivalry [...]. Finally, we tracked how well the teams gelled together, how much conflict emerged and how successful they were [...].

The findings were striking. Teams high in narcissistic rivalry performed worse than others, making around one-third less progress in the escape challenge. They solved fewer puzzles, reported less unity and generally found the experience more frustrating.

Why? Rivalry undermined team cohesion: the sense of unity that keeps people working towards a shared goal. Under pressure, rivalrous people tended to withdraw, dismiss others' suggestions or hold back information. [...]. The takeaway is simple: ego doesn't just make teammates annoying; it breaks the collective bond that gets the job done.

The admiration side of narcissism told a more seductive story. Those high in admiration looked confident, likeable and [...] seemed to boost morale. But by the end of the task, teammates saw them as more arrogant and less empathic. In other words, the charisma that first impressed others soon wore thin once teamwork required genuine give and take. It's the office classic: [...] confidence and self-promotion are still too often mistaken for competence.

Our research shows that the wrong kind of confidence can quietly undermine trust, creativity and performance. As organisations rethink leadership and teamwork in the wake of the pandemic and remote work, [...] the fix isn't to sideline confident people. But it's to value good listeners as much as good talkers. [...]

Escape rooms, often sold as fun bonding exercises, also expose who dominates, who supports and who quietly gives up when they're not centre stage. [...] What we saw was clear: [...] the most successful teams weren't the loudest, but the ones that stayed cohesive, communicative and generous – even when the clock was ticking.

Adapted from *theconversation.com*

November 2025

(454 words)

HOW REAL-TIME TRANSLATION COULD TRANSFORM TRAVEL – AND WHAT WE MIGHT LOSE

Apple's new live translation feature is a boon for travellers, but over-reliance on AI translation could make us rethink how, and why, we learn languages. [...] According to the company, users can listen to conversations in a variety of foreign languages and hear translated words in their ears, while transcripts appear on their phone screen [...].

Experts have been suitably impressed. "This is profound," said a review in the New York Times, calling Apple's innovation "one of the strongest examples yet of how artificial intelligence can be used in a seamless, practical way to improve peoples' lives". [...]

Live translation in your pocket could encourage millions of people to travel more often, and more widely. A 2025 poll by Preply, a language course provider, found that one-third of Americans surveyed intentionally choose destinations where they won't be troubled by a foreign language. [...]

But instant translation could do more than help individuals by immersing them in new cultures and kickstarting conversations. It could rewire whole sectors of economies by pushing people beyond familiar chains and tourist traps, funnelling income to small local vendors whose English is imperfect. [...]

Real-time translation could be a huge asset for transport workers, too. New York's JFK Airport alone employs tens of thousands of customer-facing workers, who deal with travellers speaking dozens of tongues. A single interaction derailed because of language barriers can cause a bottleneck that cripples passenger throughput elsewhere. This phenomenon is so common there's a term for it: delay propagation. Studies have found that a one-hour hold-up in one airline's single flight in the morning can quickly spiral into a seven-hour delay across the entire airline fleet, thanks to a domino effect of late connections. [...]

Just as calculators reshaped our approach to maths, AI translation could dent our motivation to speak other tongues. As such, challenging times may lie ahead for companies who offer language courses. [...]

Ying Okuse, the founder of Lingoinn, which arranges Mandarin-language homestays in China, Taiwan and Singapore, says that AI tutors are already popular among her customers. But she sees this as a positive trend that could actually boost demand: "There's a significant difference between what AI can offer and the immersive, real-world experience of a homestay abroad."

After all, apps can't yet decode non-verbal cues. Your average Italian can speak volumes with a contemptuous flick of their chin [...] or a kiss of their fingertips. Brits and Australians, meanwhile, often use their strongest insults as a kind of "social glue" to bond with close friends. All this, you need on-the-ground experience to appreciate. "That kind of learning goes beyond screens," says Okuse. "Language is ultimately about connection, about understanding people, culture and emotions." [...]

Adapted from *BBC*
October 2025
(458 words)

HOW SOUTH AMERICA BECAME THE UP- AND- COMING OIL CAPITAL OF THE WORLD

Off Brazil's northeastern coast, [...] are two very different types of treasure. The first is an ecological gem: a [...] deepwater coral reef discovered less than a decade ago. The second treasure puts the first in immediate danger. Billions of barrels of oil may lie in the ancient sediments beneath the seabed, and licenses have just been approved to drill there. [...]

Brazil, Guyana and Argentina are at the forefront among the top five drivers of global oil growth. [...] Yet they are united in their quest to expand oil production, arguing it's vital to their economic and social development.

This new fossil fuel boom is happening just as the impacts of the climate crisis [...] are beginning to bite in ever more alarming ways. People in South America are dying in fires, floods, storms and droughts made longer and more catastrophic by climate change.

Brazil's role as host of the COP30 climate conference, [...] adds a particular dissonance to this oil surge. [...] Huge oil companies including Exxon and Chevron have ploughed in, seeing dollar signs in South America's deep oceans and shale fields just as the US shale boom starts to plateau. Brazil is a superstar: the region's largest oil and gas producer. [...]

Perhaps the most controversial project is the one at the mouth of the Amazon River, the Foz do Amazonas basin [...] a stretch of ocean along the northern coast of Brazil. [...] Environmental advocates are strongly opposed, arguing drilling here [...] could bring catastrophic consequences. [...] Approving drilling mere weeks before the start of COP30 in the city of Belém [...] presents tricky optics for Brazil, which is trying to walk a tightrope between environmental champion and fossil fuel power. [...]

Brazil's president, [...] Lula da Silva, [...] has always been pro-oil [...]. He has firmly rejected claims of hypocrisy. "I don't want to be an environmental leader. I never claimed to be," he said at a COP30 meeting last week, adding it would be "irresponsible," to quit oil.

He argues oil wealth can help fund Brazil's clean energy transition, although some fear the quest to become a major oil power will only delay it. [...] Perhaps Lula's main narrative is that oil revenues will provide a route to development and a pathway out of poverty. [...]

Oil demand is also predicted to peak at the start of the next decade, which could mean countries that go hard on fossil fuels will find themselves locked into an unprofitable industry. [...]

What's happening in South America is reflective of something bigger. [...] The region's love affair with fossil fuels is part of a global movement, [...] an implicit [...] consensus that oil exploitation can and should continue for decades to come even in the face of a barrelling climate crisis. [...]

Adapted from *cnn.com*
November 2025
(456 words)

HOW THE THREAT OF EXTREME HEAT IS STARTING TO CHANGE OUR HOLIDAY PLANS

Two years ago, Katie from Suffolk travelled to Rhodes with her family for a holiday. They intended to spend the time relaxing in the swimming pool and sightseeing – but this wasn't possible because of the searing heat. [...] Then came the wildfires, which swept across the island. [...] The experience has, she says, changed the way she and her family have holidayed for good. [...]

While last year's season in Europe wasn't as extreme, scientists are clear that human-induced climate change is leading to more frequent and intense heatwaves around the world.

But along with this change in summer weather comes other changes too. 81% of Europeans say they have tweaked their holiday plans because of factors related to climate change, according to a report. [...] Simon Calder, a journalist for the BBC, says that many travel agents have observed some families choosing to take their main holiday over Easter, rather than during the summer.

So, could this all become a growing trend? Indeed, a recent survey found that three in four British adults think some European holiday destinations will be too hot to visit within the next five years. [...] Which all begs the question, what does that mean for holiday resorts across the Mediterranean, in particular those that have come to rely on summer tourism trade? And if the idea of "high season" changes, what does that mean for the tradition of a seaside summer holiday?

It's not just heatwaves - climate change is affecting tourism in other ways too. Sea level rises are projected to increase by almost 1m by 2100. This could lead to a long-term threat to some beachside resorts, including a number in the Caribbean. [...] Pacific islands, meanwhile, are vulnerable to storm surges. [...] It is Europe, though, that will most affect British holidaymakers. Currently it is their top destination - and it is also the fastest-warming continent on Earth. [...]

All of this could lead to some new patterns in the way people spend their vacations - and where they go. Staycations, for example, could become even more popular. More than half of UK holidaymakers say they are likely to choose to holiday at home rather than abroad for climate-related reasons, according to research. [...]

Industry experts have also noticed a growing trend of holidaymakers choosing different, less traditional destinations. "There is an increased emphasis on travel to northern destinations, with more routes to Iceland, Norway and Finland than ever [...]", according to Mr Calder. [...]

However, there are limits to these shifts. While certain groups can be more flexible about when they holiday, such as retirees or those without young children, this may not be possible for those with children of school age. [...]

Adapted from *BBC News*
June 2025
(456 words)

HOW TO LOWER AMERICA'S SOARING HEALTH-CARE COSTS?

Health-care debates, particularly about subsidies for insurance coverage, were one reason for the government shutdown. But since it ended on November 12th, the debates have not quieted. [...] Republicans in Congress [...] might consider some small [...] scale reforms to curb health-care spending growth, which exceeds the rate of inflation. The savings could be impactful, and there are three places to start.

The first would be to even out how much Medicare, the government insurance plan for the elderly, pays doctors for procedures. Currently, if a patient has a procedure at an outpatient facility, the hospital gets more than if the same treatment took place at a doctor's office. [...] The Congressional Budget Office, a non-partisan scorekeeper, has previously estimated that equalising payments by location could save anywhere from \$5bn to \$156bn over ten years, depending on what was covered. In comparison, keeping the expanded Affordable Care Act subsidies, as Democrats would like to do, would cost \$350bn over the next decade. This change would not just benefit Medicare. "There would actually be even larger savings for commercial payers", like employers who provide insurance, says [...] a health-policy researcher at Brown University. Most insurers use Medicare's pricing to set their own and so plans would have a mandate to [negotiate much lower prices with hospitals].

A second area ripe for reform is Medicare Advantage, privately provided Medicare plans. These plans have been growing in popularity: more than half of Medicare beneficiaries now use them, compared with a quarter in 2010. They often provide appealing vision, hearing and dental benefits. But they end up costing the government more, despite typically having [healthier people than average] enrolled. [...] Covering someone under Medicare Advantage costs 20% more than covering the same person under traditional Medicare, which resulted in \$84bn in additional government spending in 2025. [...] How much changes could save would depend on the ambition of the reforms: a recent CBO report estimated potential savings at anywhere from \$124bn over the next ten years to over \$1trn. [...]

A third opportunity involves pharmacy benefit managers (PBMs), middle-men between chemists and drugmakers. They are supposed to help wrangle discounts for insurance plans and steer people towards cheaper medicines. But PBMs' opaque pricing and business model has led critics to argue that they are [keeping part of the savings instead of passing them on to patients]. [...] By increasing transparency, policymakers hope employers would be able to wrestle better prices out of PBMs, says Nicholas Bath at Manatt, a consulting firm. The savings are unlikely to be huge, but they would benefit many Americans. [...]

Adapted from *The Economist*
November 2025
(450 words)

HUMAN SKIN DNA FERTILISED TO MAKE EMBRYO FOR FIRST TIME

US scientists have, for the first time, made early-stage human embryos by manipulating DNA taken from people's skin cells and then fertilising it with sperm. The technique could overcome infertility due to old age or disease, by using almost any cell in the body as the starting point for life. It could even allow same-sex couples to have a genetically related child.

The method requires significant refinement – which could take a decade – before a fertility clinic could even consider using it. Experts said it was an impressive breakthrough, but there needed to be an open discussion with the public about what science was making possible.

Reproduction used to be a simple story of man's sperm meets woman's egg. They fuse to make an embryo, and nine months later a baby is born. Now scientists are changing the rules. This latest experiment starts with human skin.

The Oregon Health and Science University research team's technique takes the nucleus – which houses a copy of the entire genetic code needed to build the body – out of a skin cell. This is then placed inside a donor egg that has been stripped of its genetic instructions. So far, the technique is like the one used to create Dolly the Sheep – the world's first cloned mammal – born back in 1996.

However, this egg is not ready to be fertilised by sperm as it already contains a full suite of chromosomes. You inherit 23 of these bundles of DNA from each of your parents for a total of 46, which the egg already has. So the next stage is to persuade the egg to discard half of its chromosomes [...]

The technique is far from polished as the egg randomly chooses which chromosomes to discard. There is a poor success rate (around 9%) and the chromosomes miss an important process where they rearrange their DNA, called crossing over. [...] This technology is part of a growing field aiming to make sperm and eggs outside of the body. The approach is still at the level of scientific discovery rather than clinical use, but the vision is to help couples who cannot benefit from IVF (in vitro fertilisation) because they don't have the sperm or eggs to use.

It could help older women who no longer have viable eggs, men who don't produce enough sperm or people whose cancer treatment has left them infertile.

The field also re-writes the rules of parenthood. The technique described today does not have to use a woman's skin cells - it could also use a man's.

That opens the door to same-sex couples having children that are genetically related to both partners. [...]

Adapted from *BBC*
November 2025
(453 words)

I STOPPED SHOPPING COMPULSIVELY

One day at work two years ago, a notification hit my phone: my paycheck had come through. It was a fair amount for someone still at university, so I did what I always did when payday arrived: I opened every shopping app on my phone. Amazon, Vinted, Etsy, Depop, Zara, you name it. Within the space of an hour, I had spent £90 on clothes, decorative items and a completely useless weighted blanket I never touched.

A few days later, I went online again and bought a hairdryer. I already owned one, but thought another couldn't hurt. [...] This wasn't new behaviour. [...] Whenever I felt stressed, tired or bored, I would doomscroll until it inevitably ended in an impulsive shopping binge. My justification was always: "Oh well, it's just £5." But £5 became £10, then £20, and so on.

I was never entirely sure why I did this. Maybe it was because I grew up in a poor family, where we'd go months without buying new clothes or anything to brighten up the house. [...] Or maybe, and definitely more likely, I was just financially irresponsible and gave in easily to capitalism's demands.

Eventually, I decided to try something new. Before buying anything, I'd put it in my basket, wait 24 hours, then decide whether to check out. The best part of this method was that it gave me space to think – something I'd never done before. For the first time since I turned 18, I began asking myself: "Do I actually need this? Can I afford it?" More often than not, the answer was no.

[...] Using this method, I stopped buying things that I knew deep down I would never use. I once wanted to buy three board games, but after waiting before going to the shop, I realised I never actually play board games.

[...] It also means I am more discerning about the things I do buy, and I can finally look at my bank statements without feeling shame or embarrassment.

Of course, there have been times I've slipped back into old habits – it's only natural. The difference now is that I can recognise the signs early, especially when I'm rushing into a purchase. I've realised boredom is a powerful trigger. It's perhaps the biggest driver of my impulsive spending.

Consumer culture preys on this boredom and our need for instant gratification. That's why, in hindsight, forcing myself to pause before buying has felt strangely liberating. To be able to have control over my impulses and remind myself that I don't need to spend my hard-earned money on unnecessary products feels as radical as it is simple.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
December 2025
(447 words)

IF YOU TELL CHATGPT YOUR SECRETS, WILL THEY BE KEPT SAFE?

On New Year's Day, a man purportedly asked ChatGPT: "Are you at fault if a fire is lit because of your cigarettes," misspelling the word "lit." "Yes," ChatGPT replied. Ten months later, he is now being accused of having started a small blaze that authorities say reignited a week later to start the devastating Palisades fire.

This man, who has pleaded not guilty, had previously told the chatbot how "amazing" it had felt to burn a Bible months prior, according to a federal complaint, and had also asked it to create a "dystopian" painting of a crowd of poor people fleeing a forest fire while a crowd of rich people mocked them behind a gate.

For federal authorities, these interactions with artificial intelligence indicated this person's pyrotechnic state of mind and motive and intent to start the fire. Along with GPS data that they say puts him at the scene of the initial blaze, it was enough to arrest and charge him with several counts, including destruction of property by means of fire.

This disturbing development is a warning for our legal system. As people increasingly turn to A.I. chat tools as confidants, therapists and advisers, we urgently need a new form of legal protection that would safeguard most private communications between people and A.I. chatbots. I call it A.I. interaction privilege.

All legal privileges rest on the idea that certain relationships – lawyer and client, doctor and patient, priest and penitent – serve a social good that depends on candour. Without assurance of privacy, people self-censor and society loses the benefits of honesty. Courts have historically been reluctant to create new privileges, except where "confidentiality has to be absolutely essential to the functioning of the relationship," says a law professor at the University of Virginia. Many users' engagements with A.I. now reach this threshold.

People speak increasingly freely to A.I. systems, not as diaries but as partners in conversation. That's because these systems hold conversations that are often indistinguishable from human dialogue. The machine seemingly listens, reasons and provides responses – in some cases not just reflecting but *shaping* how users think and feel. A.I. systems can draw users out, just as a good lawyer or therapist does. Many people turn to A.I. precisely because they lack a safe and affordable human outlet for taboo or vulnerable thoughts. [...]

Allowing the government to access such unfiltered exchanges and treat them as legal confessions would have a massive chilling effect. If every private thought experiment can later be weaponized in court, users of A.I. will censor themselves, undermining some of the most valuable uses of these systems.

Adapted from *The New York Times*
November 2025
(444 words)

IMMIGRATION RAIDS OUTRAGE MOST AMERICANS

Six months into Donald Trump's second term, the president is solidifying his law enforcement powers to create something most Americans didn't vote for and don't want: A police state increasingly robbing residents of their rights and due process. Unaccountable, masked immigration agents, many in plainclothes, are arresting farm workers in fields, raiding Home Depots and car washes, hunting unauthorized workers "like animals", and grabbing immigrants in courthouses, mothers and children in their homes, high school soccer stars and kids at baseball practice. Even U.S. citizens have been rounded up by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents, including children, [...] some of them sick, along with their parents in the country without legal permission. Many people snatched are quickly deported without due process. Some are "disappeared" into detention facilities or shipped abroad before they can get legal representation.

This hellscape of fear and chaos does not match up with Trump's campaign promise to mass-deport criminals and arrest "the worst of the worst." Residents here without legal authorization with no criminal records pleading their cases dutifully in court have been abducted by agents at courthouses. It is a shameful showcase for the cameras, an authoritarian regime running roughshod over constitutional rights, immigrant rights and human rights. Trump is improperly using the military on U.S. streets, defying court orders, caging detainees in deplorable gulags and dispatching ICE agents to grab-anyone-they-can to meet arbitrary White Houser quotas of 3,000 a day. He makes a mockery of the rule of law by arresting *Americans*. Trump is escalating his war on immigrants as poll numbers on his immigration policies hit a record low. Six months in, the executive orders, court challenges, crypto corruption, firings and budget cuts seem bottomless, as well, and now he is grappling with the Jeffrey Epstein scandal. And he's just getting started. Brace yourselves. It's going to get worse before it gets better. [...]

Trump and his top White House anti-immigration adviser, Stephen Miller, deliberately appeal to white nationalists and white grievance, leaving the feeling among immigrants that they are targeted in a deportation war aimed mainly against people of color. His administration has attacked diversity, equity and inclusion programs, and ICE agents have been accused of racially profiling immigrant communities. ICE denies this, but how many white European immigrants do you see in their detention centers. [...]

Trump's lawlessness and authoritarian conduct goes way beyond immigration, and it has provoked sustained nationwide protests since he took office. He has threatened a number of law firms into submission, tried to quell free speech and dissent at universities, attacked the media with frivolous lawsuits to try to bend them to his will and silence his critics in the entertainment world. [...]

Adapted from *Midland Daily News*
August 2025
(454 words)

IN GROK WEDON'T TRUST: ACADEMICS ASSESS ELON MUSK'S AI-POWERED ENCYCLOPEDIA

The British historian Sir Richard Evans, noted for his work on the Third Reich and as a Cambridge professor, was astonished to find that his Grokipedia entry contained several falsehoods – from his supposed doctorate supervisor to fabricated publications. [...] His discovery highlighted the troubled launch of Grokipedia, Elon Musk's new AI-powered encyclopedia, unveiled as a "better than Wikipedia" project aiming to deliver "the whole truth and nothing but the truth."

However, users quickly found that Grokipedia [...] contained major factual errors, and reflected Musk's far-right sympathies. While Musk praised his platform as an antidote to "Wokepedia," he was simultaneously posting inflammatory messages on X, predicting "civil war in Britain" and endorsing figures such as Tommy Robinson. [...]

Evans criticised Grokipedia's reliance on AI aggregation, where "chatroom contributions are given equal status with serious academic work." He pointed out errors in entries on Albert Speer and Eric Hobsbawm that ignored scholarly corrections. [...] According to David Larsson Heidenblad of the Lund Centre for the History of Knowledge, the project represents a clash between Silicon Valley's iterative mindset and academia's slow, trust-based approach to building reliable knowledge.

[...] The experiment fits within a centuries-old tradition of encyclopedias – from China's Yongle scrolls to the Encyclopédie of the Enlightenment, to Britannica and Wikipedia – but raises the question: *who defines truth when AI systems, guided by powerful individuals, take over authorship?*

Cultural historian Peter Burke warned of "political manipulation," noting that the anonymity of entries can lend them unwarranted authority. [...] Andrew Dudfield of Full Fact, a UK fact-checking organisation, questioned whether an AI-generated encyclopedia could ever inspire trust: "It doesn't display the same transparency but asks for the same trust."

Musk's hostility toward Wikipedia is relatively recent. Once an admirer, by 2023 he derided it as biased and mockingly offered \$1 billion if it changed its name to "Dickipedia." Yet many of Grokipedia's 885,000 early entries were copied almost verbatim from Wikipedia. [...] Those that differed often revealed ideological slants: The Ukraine war entry cited Kremlin sources and echoed claims about "denazifying" Ukraine, Britain First was described as a "patriotic political party" rather than a "neo-fascist hate group, the 6 January 2021 Capitol attack was called a "riot," with references to "demographic erasure" theories, the Donald Trump entry downplayed his criminal conviction and omitted conflicts of interest.

Wikipedia responded calmly, emphasising its transparency and volunteer oversight. [...] The Wikimedia Foundation noted that it remains committed to neutrality and continuous improvement.

xAI, Musk's company behind Grokipedia, offered no comment. But as academics warn, the platform's blend of ideology, opacity, and technological authority makes it less a "compendium of truth" than a mirror of one billionaire's worldview.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(452 words)

INDIA COULD BE A DIFFERENT KIND OF AI SUPERPOWER

Artificial intelligence (AI) is taking off in India. The country is now the second-largest market for OpenAI, whose ChatGPT service has 700m active users worldwide. Anthropic, another AI startup, also counts India as its second-largest market by usage. That reflects not just India's huge population but also its appetite for new technology. According to BCG, a consultancy, 92% of Indian office workers regularly use AI tools, compared with 64% in America. In contrast to rich countries, a large majority of Indians believe AI's benefits outweigh its risks.

The enthusiasm has been boosted by the "blitzscaling" tactics of Silicon Valley firms. OpenAI is selling access to a chatbot in India for a fifth of the price of its cheapest American plan. Grok, from Elon Musk's startup, xAI, is priced at a quarter of its American rate. Perplexity, a generative-AI upstart, has made its service free for a year to all 360m users of Airtel, a big Indian mobile operator.

Even in India, however, the boom in AI causes anxiety. The country's youth-unemployment rate stands at 16%. Jobs in manufacturing have grown far less than had been hoped, in part because of rising automation—a trend that AI threatens to accelerate. White-collar work is starting to look wobbly, too. Tata Consultancy Services, India's biggest IT-services firm, recently said that it would cut 12,000 staff in order to become "future ready". Jefferies, an investment bank, predicts that more IT firms will follow.

A second fear is foreign domination. Some Indian policymakers and investors fret that their country will come to rely on AI products and services that are controlled by firms from abroad. Keen not to be left out of the model race, the government has tapped Sarvam AI, a local startup, to build India's first home-grown foundational model.

Such worries are understandable. Yet India stands to gain far more by embracing AI than it will lose. [...]

Already, Indian users are shaping how the most popular AI models develop. Voice, not text, has quickly emerged as the dominant way of interacting with AI tools in India, in part because some users struggle to read. Indian firms are especially adept at designing services for a varied audience.

The "India Stack"—India's digital platform for biometric identification and payments—has already become a model for other countries. Products infused with AI could be the next export of this kind: frugal, scalable innovation that is pioneered in India but adopted across the developing world. India's path will not mirror America's or China's. But it could prove no less consequential. For billions in poorer countries, the shape AI takes could depend on what happens in India.

Adapted from *The Economist*
September 2025
(460 words)

INDIA'S DATA CENTRE BOOM CONFRONTS A LOOMING WATER CHALLENGE

The extraordinary rise of artificial intelligence has turbocharged data centre growth in India, Asia's third largest economy.

Data centres – the centralised physical facilities that enable our growing digital existence by hosting computer servers, IT infrastructure and network equipment – power everything from ChatGPT queries to electric vehicles and streaming services. [...]

Demand for such infrastructure is soaring, with India expected to consume the most data in the world by 2028 – higher than developed markets like the US, Europe and even China. This consumption is being driven by massive growth in internet and mobile use, the government's regulatory thrust on hosting user data locally and rapid adoption of AI, which has greater computing needs. [...] The country also has world-class tech talent suited for the industry's growth. [...] This boom has, however, presented policymakers with difficult trade-offs. [...] Serious concerns have been raised around data centres guzzling excess water for their cooling systems and consuming vast amounts of energy at the cost of local communities. In an energy starved, water-scarce India, these challenges are even more accentuated.

[...] India has 18% of the world's population, but only 4% of its water resources, making it among the most water-stressed countries in the world. [...] A potential pushback from locals or a loss of licences to build and operate such centres as a result of growing water stress could hit the industry hard over the long term, experts say. [...]

This, in turn, could have a cascading impact on other industries. "Imagine shutdowns of data centres in peak summer due to lack of water for cooling – how might this impact banking services, medical systems in hospitals using cloud services, transit system operations and more," an Indian expert says [...].

Companies need to bring greater innovation and explore mechanisms to use treated domestic and industrial waste water instead of fighting for this limited resource, experts say. [...] "Non-potable or treated water must be made mandatory for cooling needs," a water recycling expert told the BBC. [...] He also advocates for the use of zero-water cooling technologies that are advancing globally, but "inconsistently deployed across Indian and legacy facilities".

A lesser, but significant concern apart from water, is energy use. [...] While many data centres in India have signed contracts with renewable energy companies to mitigate their carbon footprint, formally "mandating the use of clean energy" will make this growth more sustainable, adds Vibhuti Garg, director at the Institute for Energy Economics [...]. Delhi will clearly have to strike a delicate policy balance as it supercharges its futuristic digital aspirations while also ensuring there's least damage to the environment.

"In the end, we need to ensure that one good is not sacrificed for another," she says.

Adapted from *bbc.com*
November 2025
(455 words)

INDIAN WOMEN AND 'THE GENTLEMEN'S GAME'

It has been the highest, hardest glass ceiling in Indian sports. Cricket is watched or played in almost every household in this country of 1.4 billion people. It generates hundreds of millions of dollars in business every year. But until recently, the spotlight and the wealth were mostly reserved for men. Then, on Sunday, India's national women's cricket team won the World Cup. The Mumbai stadium, packed with 40,000 fans, erupted in cheers. People poured onto the streets across the country in celebration.

A World Cup victory four decades ago helped transform the men's game, turning it from a casual pastime into a national obsession. If this weekend's win is similarly transformative for the women's game, it could have real impact on the lives of women and girls across the country. Today, male cricketers are among India's most revered celebrities. Some are even more popular than Bollywood stars. The Indian Premier League is now valued at over \$8 billion. The top player makes about \$3 million for a season that lasts about two months.

Until only a few years ago, the women's game was semiprofessional. Early in her career, India's captain, Harmanpreet Kaur, juggled a day job as a railway clerk with practices for the national team. But things began to change with \$500 million in private investment to set up a women's premier league three years ago. Suddenly women's cricket was on television, and teams were scouring the country for talent. Today, the pay on the national team has improved, though the highest female player's salary is still less than one-tenth of the highest male player's. The private franchises are where the pay is really life-changing: Smriti Mandhana, one of cricket's most recognizable faces, now makes just short of half a million dollars for a month's play.

Women are also seeing endorsement deals. The players, many of whom have large online followings, are the faces of products in sectors as varied as banking, sports apparel and house paint. On the day of the team's World Cup victory, brands like Nike and Puma were already pushing out ads featuring the team's stars.

Despite India's longstanding matriarchal traditions, women still remain largely confined to traditional gender roles here. Their participation rate in the formal labor force is among the lowest in the world. Cricket can only do so much about this, of course. But this sudden change in fortunes for a sport that's so embedded in daily life here, has the capacity to boost women's roles in a new way. [...] But the bigger impact might be psychological — seeing female hometown heroes on billboards and celebrated on TV could start to influence families' conceptions of girls [...]

Adapted from *The New York Times*
November 2025
(459 words)

INDIGENOUS PEOPLE REFLECT ON THE MEANING OF THEIR PARTICIPATION IN COP30 CLIMATE TALKS

Indigenous people filled the streets, paddled the waterways and protested at the heart of the venue to make their voices heard during the United Nations climate talks that were supposed to give them a voice like never before at the annual conference. As the talks, called COP30, concluded Saturday in Belem, Brazil, Indigenous people reflected on what the conference meant to them and whether they were heard.

Brazilian leaders had high hopes that the summit, taking place in the Amazon, would empower the people who inhabit the land and protect the biodiversity of the world's largest rainforest, which helps stave off climate change as its trees absorb carbon pollution that heats the planet.

Many Indigenous people who attended the talks felt strengthened by the solidarity with tribes from other countries and some appreciated small wins in the final outcome. But for many, the talks fell short on representation, ambition and true action on climate issues affecting Indigenous people. "This was a COP where we were visible but not empowered," said a member of A Wisdom Keepers Delegation, a group of Indigenous people from around the world. [...] She says the first paragraph of the text mentions for the first time the rights of Indigenous Peoples, as well as their land rights and traditional knowledge but that countries should have pushed harder for agreements on how to phase out fuels like oil, gas and coal "and not to see nature as merchandise, but to see it as sacred."

Several nations pushed for a road map to curtail use of fossil fuels, which when burned release greenhouse gases that warm the planet. Saturday's final decision left out any mention of fossil fuels, leaving many countries disappointed. "They hand corporations a license to keep drilling, keep burning, keep destroying, so long as they can point to an offset written on paper. It's the same colonial logic dressed up as climate policy," said an Indigenous leader.

From the beginning of the conference, some Indigenous attendees were concerned visibility isn't the same as true power. At the end, that sentiment lingered. [...] "What we have seen at this COP is a focus on symbolic presence rather than enabling the full and effective participation of Indigenous Peoples," said the chair of the Inuit Council.

However, while the decisions by delegates left some Indigenous attendees feeling dismissed, many said they felt empowered by participating in demonstrations outside the venue. Indeed, some said that act helped Indigenous people amplify their voices. An Amazonian Indigenous leader says: "After breaking the barrier, we were able to enter COP, and express our needs, we got closer to the negotiations, got more visibility." [...]

Adapted from *Associated Press*
November 2025
(453 words)

INHERITING IS BECOMING NEARLY AS IMPORTANT AS WORKING

People in advanced economies stand to inherit about 10% of GDP, up from around 5% on average in rich countries in the 20th century. As a share of output, annual inheritance flows have doubled in France since the 1960s, and nearly tripled in Germany since the 1970s. Whether a young person can afford to buy a house and live in relative comfort is determined by inherited wealth nearly as much as it is by their own success at work. This shift has alarming economic and social consequences, because it imperils not just the meritocratic ideal, but capitalism itself.

In part, the inheritance boom is a reflection of a wealthier and ageing society. As economies have become richer, they have accumulated capital per worker, capital that someone has to own. But because the pace of economic growth has slackened and housing markets have boomed, the scale of this wealth relative to incomes has ballooned [...]

More wealth means more inheritance for baby boomers to pass on. And because wealth is far more unequally distributed than income, a new inheritocracy is being born. You can see this in the shifting fortunes of the super-rich. For much of the 20th century, vast estates were often broken up by bad investing, or by war and inflation [...]

These trends are being overturned, however, perhaps because billionaires are both amassing wealth and are better at preserving their riches. [...] That may be because it is now easy to park wealth in an index fund, and the principles of wealth management are better understood. Moreover, many governments have obligingly cut inheritance taxes.

The most striking thing about the inheritocracy, though, is that it is not just about the uber-rich. The typical heir is someone inheriting a normal house, or the proceeds from its sale, not a superyacht or a country pile. And housing wealth has rocketed in recent decades, especially in apex cities like London, New York and Paris. [...]

For supporters of free markets, the rise of the new inheritocracy should be deeply disturbing. For a start, it creates a rentier class that faces a series of bad incentives. [...] To protect their assets, homeowners become nimbys, blocking building and making housing unaffordable for those without inherited wealth. Knowing they can rely on their inheritance, moreover, the new rentiers may face little incentive to work or innovate.

More worrying still is how an underclass of non-beneficiaries is becoming increasingly left behind and increasingly disaffected. If property becomes ever harder to buy, and a comfortable life harder to achieve, the incentive of young, aspirational workers to strive will be blunted[...] And when they believe that the system is stacked against them, their support for mainstream political parties withers.

Adapted from *The Economist*
February 2025
(457 words)

INSIDE THE WORLD OF KENYA'S "SHADOW SCHOLARS"

There is a secret industry that generates billions of dollars a year. Its workers are bright, industrious and completely anonymous. Their job is writing essays to order for students – in the UK and elsewhere – to help them get good degrees.

These are "shadow scholars", highly educated Kenyans who earn a living by working for essay mills. They are contracted to ghostwrite essays, PhD dissertations and other academic papers for students across the world, who pay a fee then pass off the work as their own.

The role is not unique to Kenya. There are similar writers in India, Pakistan and any other number of countries, including the UK, but Kenya has been identified as a hotspot, with an estimated 40,000 ghostwriters working in Nairobi alone.

They are the subject of a new film that talks for the first time to the young Kenyans who may be writing an essay or dissertation on any topic from mechanical engineering, nursing or quantum physics to Jane Austen, linguistics or Ho Chi Minh.

Smart, ambitious, well-educated and tech savvy, they worked hard to get to university, graduated with good degrees, but there are no jobs. Instead, they spend their days - and - nights logging on to essay-writing platforms, scrolling down the list of assignments and making bids to win the work.

The cameras follow the sociologist and Oxford professor Patricia Kingori as she travels to Nairobi to interview the writers and explore the power dynamics that enable students in countries such as the UK to secure degrees and begin lucrative careers without doing their own work. [...]

Kingori, who is Kenyan-born, meets Mercy, a graduate and mother of Angel, who works through the night, sometimes having to master two different subjects for two different assignments in the space of 12 hours. She has had only three hours' sleep, but she needs the money.

With the money he has made, Chege, who describes himself as one of Kenya's academic writing pioneers, paid for his own education, supported his sister through her degree, built his parents a house and bought himself a car.

The writers create fake IDs using white profiles and names, because they say it helps convince clients they are up to the task. "If you go online now and try to find help with an essay, invariably they sell you the service as if it's coming from somebody that's in the UK or the US," said Kingori. "Nothing that I've seen will tell you that this is somebody in Nairobi. There is this idea that this could not be coming from an African country."

Adapted from *The Guardian*
September 2025
(440 words)

INSTAGRAM TO MAKE BIG CHANGE TO STOP TEENS SEEING ADULT CONTENT SUCH AS ONLYFANS

Teenagers on Instagram will soon be restricted to seeing PG-13 content by default and won't be able to change their settings without a parent's permission. The update, described by Meta as the most significant since it introduced teen accounts last year, means those using teen-specific accounts will only see photos and videos on Instagram that are similar to what they would see in a PG-13 movie – no sex, drugs or dangerous stunts.

“This includes hiding or not recommending posts with strong language, certain risky stunts, and additional content that could encourage potentially harmful behaviours, such as posts showing marijuana paraphernalia,” Meta said in a blog post on Tuesday.

The company is also adding an even stricter setting that parents can set up for their children. The changes come as the social media giant faces relentless criticism over harms to children.

As it seeks to add safeguards for teens, Meta has already promised it wouldn't show inappropriate content to teens, such as posts about self-harm, eating disorders or suicide. But this does not always work. A recent report, for instance, found that teen accounts researchers created were recommended age-inappropriate sexual content, including “graphic sexual descriptions, the use of cartoons to describe demeaning sexual acts, and brief displays of nudity.”

In addition, Instagram also recommended a “range of self-harm, self-injury, and body image content” on teen accounts that the report says “would be reasonably likely to result in adverse impacts for young people, including teenagers experiencing poor mental health, or self-harm and suicidal ideation and behaviours.”

Meta says the new restrictions go further than its previous safeguards. Teens will no longer be able to follow accounts that regularly share “age-inappropriate content” or if their name or bio contains something that isn't appropriate for teens, such as a link to an OnlyFans account. If teens already follow these accounts, they'll no longer be able to see or interact with their content, send them messages, or see their comments under anyone's posts, the company said. The accounts also won't be able to follow teens, send them private messages or comment on their posts.

Meta said it already blocks certain search terms related to sensitive topics such as suicide and eating disorders, but the latest update will expand this to a broader range of terms, such as “alcohol” or “gore”, even if they are misspelt.

For parents who want an even stricter setting for their kids, Meta is also launching a “limited content” restriction that will block more content and remove teens' ability to see, leave, or receive comments under posts.

Adapted from *The Independent*
October 2025
(442 words)

IS SLEEPING A LOT ACTUALLY BAD FOR YOUR HEALTH?

We're constantly being reminded by news articles and social media posts that we should be getting more sleep. You probably don't need to hear it again – not sleeping enough is bad for your brain, heart and overall health, not to mention your skin and sex drive. [...] Along with nutrition and physical activity, sleep is an essential pillar of health. During sleep, physiological processes occur that allow our bodies to function effectively when we are awake. These include processes involved in muscle recovery, memory consolidation and emotional regulation.

The Sleep Health Foundation – Australia's leading not-for-profit organisation that provides evidence-based information on sleep health – recommends adults get seven to nine hours of sleep per night. Some people are naturally short sleepers and can function well with less than seven hours. However, for most of us, sleeping less than seven hours will have negative effects. These may be short term; for example, the day after a poor night's sleep you might have less energy, worse mood, feel more stressed and find it harder to concentrate at work. In the long term, not getting enough good quality sleep is a major risk factor for health problems like cardiovascular disease, metabolic disorders, poor mental health, such as depression and anxiety, cancer and death. [...]

However, in a recent study, researchers also found those who slept a lot – which they defined as more than nine hours a night – had a greater risk of dying: 34% higher than people who slept seven to eight hours. [...] The study has also shown sleeping too long (meaning more than required for your age) is linked to health problems such as depression, chronic pain, weight gain and metabolic disorders. This may sound alarming. But it's crucial to remember these studies have only found a link between sleeping too long and poor health – this doesn't mean sleeping too long is the *cause* of health problems or death. Multiple factors like chronic health problems may indeed influence the relationship between sleeping a lot and having poor health. [...]

It's not just about how much sleep you get. Good quality sleep and a consistent bed time and wake time are just as important – if not more so – for your overall health. [...] We should thus focus on how to make sure we get enough sleep, rather than worrying we are getting too much. To give yourself the best chance of a good night's sleep, get sunlight and stay active during the day, and try to keep a regular sleep and wake time. In the hour before bed, avoid screens, do something relaxing, and make sure your sleep space is quiet, dark, and comfortable. [...]

Adapted from from *The Conversation*
July 2025
(448 words)

IS TELEHEALTH A GOOD IDEA, OR SHOULD I SEE MY REGULAR DOCTOR?

[...] Lots of my friends have been asking me lately: *Is telehealth sketchy?* I'm a primary care doctor – one who practices in a "regular" brick-and-mortar office – and people in my life have *lots* of questions about the ads they see for online doctors offering everything from mental health care to Viagra.

The services seem so easy to use, my friends say, but they're not sure that they're safe.

Nobody can deny the ease of telehealth. You can schedule appointments within hours – sometimes minutes – of realizing you need care and see a doctor from your couch, in your pajamas. [...]

The field has been rapidly evolving in the U.S. since Medicare started paying doctors for virtual visits during the COVID-19 pandemic, and many other health insurers followed suit. [...]

Answer a few questions through a form, type in your credit card information, and the medications are in the mail. Companies that offer these treatments often deal with only one condition at a time and follow simple algorithms to make a diagnosis and offer a treatment plan.

If you have a mystery rash, on the other hand, you might try a video visit so your doctor can get eyes on it. Video visits are also helpful for evaluating sick kids and skin and nail infections.

Logging in to the right app for a video visit can be tricky for folks who have a hard time navigating technology, however, which is why I offer phone call appointments for my patients. [...]

Telehealth simply doesn't work for conditions that require a physical exam (like gynecologic exams or joint pain) or for procedures like vaccines, steroid injections or biopsies.

And if your condition is complicated or you don't have a clear diagnosis – say, you're having abdominal pain but don't know why – it's often worth your while to meet a provider in person. [...]

There's some research to suggest that telehealth might be cheaper, overall, than in-person care. That makes sense: A quick virtual visit might prevent a costly and time-consuming emergency room visit, and that can decrease unnecessary testing. You also save on travel costs.

But again, it depends on whether you're seeing a doctor you already know. Online appointments with a provider who has to start from square one might end up costing you more, both in emergency department costs if you get sent for further testing and in fees associated with the platform. [...]

So rather than asking, "Should I use telehealth or see my regular doctor?" a better question might be, "How can I use telehealth with my regular doctor?" Lots of primary care doctors are happy to use telehealth as a supplement to in-person care. [...]

Adapted from *NPR News*
September 2025
(453 words)

IS TODAY'S SELF-HELP TEACHING EVERYONE TO BE AN IDIOT?

There's a certain flavor of advice that is dominating the self-help best-seller list. These books have titles like "The Courage to Be Disliked" and "Set Boundaries, Find Peace." They tell readers not to worry so much about letting people down, not to answer those calls from aggravating friends, not to be afraid of being the villain. This all becomes more alarming when you think of the best-seller list as a mirror of the social moment, which some historians say it may be.

Take Dale Carnegie's popular "How to Win Friends and Influence People," which came out in 1936, meeting readers haunted by memories of bread lines. [...] The unemployment rate was at 16.9 percent. Jobs were scarce and financial security was elusive. [...] Mr. Carnegie promised that some of history's great men, say Benjamin Franklin and Abraham Lincoln, had achieved success with a formula so simple that it was within anybody's reach. Pacify people. Hand out compliments. "Don't feel like smiling?" wrote Mr. Carnegie, [...] "Force yourself to smile. If you are alone, force yourself to whistle or hum a tune." [...] The book was an instant success, reaching an audience that felt hard on its luck and appreciated a formula for riches that seemed both secret and utterly replicable. [...]

Every era molds a different version of self-realization. With each chapter in American history, people find a self-help guru who answers some spiritually unsettling questions of the moment. Maybe it's no surprise, then, that in a time of hyper-visible conflict — social media filled with memes of crying migrants shared by the official White House account, insults hurled in public between the country's highest leaders — the self-help message of the day tells its readers that it's perfectly OK to turn inward, even if that means ignoring the apparent struggles of others. [...]

The subtext of these new self-help books — to go easier on yourself, even embrace being the bad guy — travels quickly. TikTok influencers accumulate millions of views urging followers to "protect your peace." "Your inner peace is the most sacred thing you have," goes the common refrain. [...]

Self-help has always been a sneakily political genre. Today, the tone of some self-help books often crops up on right-leaning podcasts, in which hosts put an obsessive focus on self-improvement, turning inward by fixating on the foods we eat and the way we sleep. Influencers in the "manosphere" court listeners by urging them to make their beds, lift weights and take creatine supplements. Hosts in the "womanosphere" tell their fans to eat more protein and let go of stress so they can improve their fertility. The messaging slips between advice and politics, fitness tips giving way to presidential endorsements and nutritional advice turning to monologues against feminism.

Adapted from *The New York Times*
August 2025
(461 words)

“IT OPENED UP SOMETHING IN ME”: WHY PEOPLE ARE TURNING TO BIBLIOTHERAPY

In the summer of 2017, Elizabeth Russell was going through a rough patch. It was during a difficult divorce, involving her two young teenagers, while she was still in the throes of a long-term depression. "It was just a really, really stressful time," recalls Russell, a teacher and librarian at an elementary school in Connecticut, US. But then on the internet she came across something called "creative bibliotherapy", where a tailored recommendation of fiction is offered with the aim of improving mental health. The name Ella Berthoud, a bibliotherapist based in Sussex, UK [...] kept popping up. Russell – an avid reader – immediately wanted to try it out.

After quizzing Russell on her reading habits and interviewing her about her challenges, Berthoud sent her a list of book recommendations relevant to her life, many featuring characters navigating tough marital decisions [...]. Learning from the lessons and mistakes of fictional characters helped her process what she was going through and made her feel less alone. "It opened up something in me that needed to be opened and needed to heal," she says.

In the UK and elsewhere, bibliotherapy [...] has been soaring in popularity as a means of improving people's wellbeing, help navigate tough life decisions, and even treating specific mental health conditions.

While the benefits of self-help literature are well documented, advocates of fiction-based or "creative bibliotherapy" claim similar advantages. They argue that immersing oneself in rich, simulated worlds – often reflective of real-life experiences – can help readers process emotions, discover coping strategies, or simply provide momentary escape from their everyday woes. [...]

As anyone who has ever read and loved a work of drama, poetry or fiction can attest, stories have powerful effects on our minds and emotions. But that doesn't mean that any kind of fiction boosts mental health for everyone. Several experts interviewed for this article worry about what they see as an overhyped promise of creative bibliotherapy in treating specific mental health conditions, where they say the scientific evidence is still rather thin. In fact, research suggests that certain books can even be harmful.

Rather, the existing research paints a more nuanced picture, suggesting that fiction *can* help boost general wellbeing, but it depends a lot on the person, the book and how they engage with it, says James Carney, a computational cognitive scientist at the London Interdisciplinary School.

"There's this idea that books are this cultic object that are going to make everything better," Carney says. "I think for a certain number of conditions and for a certain type of personality, it can be the case, but the idea that they're a universal medicine is just simply false."

Adapted from *BBC News*
June 2025
(452 words)

JAPAN'S ELDERLY ARE LONELY AND STRUGGLING. SOME WOMEN CHOOSE TO GO TO JAIL INSTEAD

The rooms are filled with elderly residents, their hands wrinkled and backs bent. They shuffle slowly down the corridors, some using walkers. Workers help them bathe, eat, walk and take their medication. But this isn't a nursing home – it's Japan's largest women's prison. The population here reflects the aging society outside, and the pervasive problem of loneliness that guards say is so acute for some elderly prisoners that they'd prefer to stay incarcerated. "There are even people who say they will pay twenty or thirty thousand yen a month to live here forever," said Takayoshi Shiranaga, an officer at Tochigi Women's Prison located north of Tokyo. [...]

The women in Tochigi live behind bars and must work in the prison's factories, but that suits some just fine. Inside they get regular meals, free healthcare and eldercare – along with the companionship they lack on the outside. One inmate has been imprisoned on drug charges five times over the last twenty-five years. Each time she returns, the prison population seems to get older, she said. "Some people do bad things on purpose and get caught so that they can go to prison again, if they run out of money." [...]

Theft is by far the most common crime committed by elderly inmates, especially among women. In 2022, more than eighty percent of elderly female inmates nationwide were in jail for stealing, according to government figures. Some do it for survival – twenty percent of people aged over sixty-five in Japan live in poverty, according to the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, compared to an average of fourteen percent across the organization's thirty-eight member countries. Others do it because they have so little left on the outside. [...]

Authorities have acknowledged the issue, with the welfare ministry saying in 2021 that elderly inmates who received support after leaving prison were far less likely to re-offend than those who didn't. The ministry has since ramped up its early intervention efforts and community support centers to better support vulnerable elderly, it said. [...]

The government is now considering proposals to make housing benefits accessible to more elders, with ten municipalities across Japan already testing initiatives to support elderly people with no close relatives. But it's not clear whether that will be enough, in a country with one of the world's longest lifespans and lowest birthrates. The elderly population is ballooning so fast that Japan will require two million care workers by 2040, according to the government – which is now scrambling to encourage more people to enter the industry, and to import foreign workers to fill the gaps.

Adapted from CNN
January 2025
(455 words)

JIMMY KIMMEL LIVE! SUSPENDED INDEFINITELY AFTER HOST'S CHARLIE KIRK COMMENTS

ABC, which Disney owns, announced on Wednesday night that it would remove Jimmy Kimmel's late-night show from its schedule for the foreseeable future after the US government put pressure on broadcasters to crack down on the comedian, who had accused Donald Trump's political movement of exploiting the killing of Charlie Kirk.

The move to remove one of the US's most influential late-night shows has been criticised as part of a government attack on the free speech of critical voices in media, academia and business. This has gathered pace in recent days after the Trump administration and its supporters launched a campaign to target anyone deemed not to have properly mourned Kirk, a prominent conservative commentator.

Kimmel is the second prominent US comedian in a few months to lose his position: in July, CBS announced it would scrap Stephen Colbert, who has also been critical of Trump. Trump, who is sensitive to mockery from comedians, celebrated the suspension and called for other shows to be cancelled. "Great News for America," Trump wrote on Truth Social. "Congratulations to ABC for finally having the courage to do what had to be done."

The president has said he also wants Jimmy Fallon and Seth Meyers, who work for NBC, to be removed. The free speech advocacy group Foundation for Individual Rights and Expression said the suspension was an example of a media outlet "withering under government pressure, ensuring the administration will continue to extort and exact retribution on broadcasters who criticize it. We cannot be a country where late night talk show hosts serve at the pleasure of the president."

Before ABC pulled Kimmel, Brendan Carr, chair of the Federal Communications Commission and a Trump appointee, urged local broadcasters to stop airing the show, saying they were "running the possibility of fines or license revocation from the FCC." On Wednesday night, Carr thanked ABC "for doing the right thing," stating broadcasters must serve the public interest.

During his Monday monologue, less than a week after Kirk was shot dead, Kimmel said: "We hit some new lows over the weekend with the Maga gang trying to characterize this kid who killed Charlie Kirk as anything other than one of them and doing everything they can to score political points from it." The suspect, Tyler Robinson, has been charged with aggravated murder.

Kimmel added: "Many in Maga-land are working very hard to capitalize on the murder of Charlie Kirk." He accused JD Vance of blaming the left without evidence. Kimmel cited a study showing far-right groups were the greatest source of domestic terrorism. [...]

Andrew Alford, president of ABC's broadcasting division, called Kimmel's comments "offensive and insensitive at a critical time." [...]

Adapted from *The Guardian*
September 2025
(454 words)

MAKE TRAINS GREAT AGAIN – FOR THE SAKE OF PEOPLE AND THE PLANET

What if there were a technology that could help to reduce greenhouse-gas emissions, air pollution and environmental degradation, while improving health, reducing social inequality and boosting economic growth? There is, and this month it turns two hundred. The opening of the Stockton and Darlington Railway in northeast England in 1825 is generally considered to be the birth of the modern railway. Initially, the railways enjoyed quick expansion, but since the mid-twentieth century, railway development in most countries has slowed, and been overtaken by growth in road and air travel. In the European Union in 2022, just eight percent of passenger kilometres were travelled by rail, compared with nine percent by air and seventy three percent by car. [...]

It's time to turn the tables, and acknowledge the vast benefits of railways as a cornerstone of a sustainable transport system that can support human development and economic growth. Research from across disciplines can inform policy in preparation for a much-needed renaissance, as railways travel into their third century.

According to the International Energy Agency, transport currently accounts for around one-quarter of global carbon emissions. Between 1990 and 2022, those emissions grew by two percent a year [...] as more people in more parts of the world became more mobile. Over ninety percent of the energy used to power transport comes from fossil fuels. Those figures alone justify a renewed focus on rail transport. Per passenger kilometre, it produces one-fifth of the emissions of car transport, and less than one-quarter of those of flying. Direct emissions can be cut to zero if trains are powered by fully renewable electricity. [...]

One way research can help to get things back on track is by broadening the criteria governments use to assess railway investment. All too often, these are based on narrow metrics of profitability or 'time saved' by potential users, with insufficient consideration of the wider social and environmental impacts. Economists and sustainability researchers can all contribute to developing more-robust assessments of these lesser-known benefits. Such initiatives can feed into broader regulatory and policy frameworks. Only one-third of countries have fully incorporated the transport sector into their ongoing commitments to reduce emissions. [...]

At its zenith, immediately before the First World War, the US rail network extended to more than four hundred thousand kilometres – greater than the distance from Earth to the Moon. Today, it covers little more than half of that. The extent of this decline underscores the need to turn around the neglect of a technology that has not only changed the world, but could also save the planet.

Adapted from *Nature*
September 2025
(447 words)

MEXICAN WOMEN OUTRAGED BY PUBLIC SEXUAL ASSAULT ON THEIR PRESIDENT

The groping of Mexico's [President] Claudia Sheinbaum by a drunken man has sparked outrage among women, many of whom saw their own fears and experiences reflected in her plight.

"If the president suffered assault with that level of protection and those guards it means that all of us women can be assaulted at any moment," said a 20-year-old student. The incident took place on Tuesday while Sheinbaum was walking through a crowd in Mexico City. The man tried to kiss her on the neck and embrace her from behind.

The man was later arrested and Sheinbaum said on Wednesday that she would press for charges. "This is something I experienced as a woman, but it is something that all women in our country experience," she said in her daily press conference. "If I don't file a complaint, where does that leave all Mexican women? [...]"

For some women, watching the country's first female president being groped in public was a personal affront. "It was really humiliating," said a feminist activist and artist. "I felt angry, enraged and impotent."

The incident provoked great anger given the high levels of violence faced by women in Mexico, where an average of 10 are killed every day. In the first six months of this year, more than 500 women were murdered because of their gender in a crime known as femicide. [...] The high rates of violence have fuelled the feminist movement, with tens of thousands of women taking to the streets every year on International Women's Day.

The groping incident prompted indignation across the political spectrum. "The president lived what thousands of women experience on the street, out in public, at work," said a congresswoman with the opposition. "This assault, this touching that is so invasive of our bodies as women."

Senators from various parties held a press conference on Wednesday condemning the assault against Sheinbaum. "If this happens to the head of state, [...], it also happens silently every day to thousands of women in our country," said a senator. A 40-year-old nurse told *The Guardian* she is keenly aware of the dangers facing women on public transport. [...] "I try not to get on public transport that's too full, or always sit next to a woman," she said.

When asked about what happened to Sheinbaum, Gutiérrez was indignant. "If being president she was touched in that way, what hope is there for us common folk?" [...] Not everyone in politics showed support. Mr. Moreno, the head of the opposition party, suggested the incident may have been staged to distract the public from cartel violence.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(443 words)

MICROPLASTICS: THE INVISIBLE THREAT

Every breath people take in their homes or cars probably contains microplastics small enough to reach deep into the lungs, new peer-reviewed research warns. The study, published in PLOS One, estimates that humans may inhale up to 68,000 tiny plastic particles a day. Earlier studies found larger airborne pieces, but these pose less danger since they settle faster and do not penetrate as deeply into the respiratory system.

The smaller fragments, measuring between 1 and 10 micrometres – around one-seventh the thickness of a human hair – can more easily circulate through the body. “We were quite surprised about the levels we found – much higher than previously estimated,” said Nadiia Yakovenko, microplastics researcher at France’s University of Toulouse. The small size of these particles means they can readily enter tissues, including the bloodstream and the deepest, most sensitive parts of the respiratory system, or lungs.

Microplastics originate either as intentionally added components in consumer goods or as fragments of larger plastics breaking down. These particles can contain thousands of different plastic chemicals, including well-known endocrine disruptors like BPA, phthalates and PFAS, many of which are widely known to be toxic or harmful to health. The particles have been detected throughout the human body and can cross both the placental and brain barriers. While food and water have long been considered the main exposure routes, this research highlights inhalation as a major and underestimated threat. Chronic exposure has been linked to inflammation that can contribute to lung cancer.

Indoor air concentrations were found to be far higher than outdoor levels. This is worrying because people spend about 90 percent of their time indoors, where plastics abound and ventilation is poor. The research team meticulously sampled air quality in several different residential apartments as well as inside car cabins while the authors drove. Indoors, sources included degrading materials in clothing, carpets and kitchen goods. Even ordinary movements – walking, sitting, or opening a window – can resuspend particles because they are so light.

An apartment occupied by two people had notably higher levels due to increased activity. Air inside cars contained about four times more microplastics than apartments, the researchers found. Car interiors are smaller enclosed spaces filled with plastic components, and poor ventilation compounds the problem. The microplastics detected matched materials used in dashboards, door handles and steering wheels.

Complete avoidance of airborne microplastics is impossible, but exposure can be reduced. Replacing plastic objects with wood, metal or natural fibres helps limit sources. HEPA air-filtration systems and regular vacuuming or dusting with HEPA-equipped devices are effective at removing particles indoors. Reducing concentrations in cars is more difficult; opening windows may ventilate the cabin but can also introduce microplastics from tyre pollution outside.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
August 2025
(454 mots)

MILLENNIAL DADS ARE EXPERIENCING SOMETHING MUMS HAVE KNOWN FOR A LONG TIME

Can men really have it all? It's a ridiculous question, obviously; a loaded assumption that women spent years clambering out from under. Mothers have worked long and hard to dispel the myth that anyone should be able to single-handedly juggle a job, children, a happy relationship and a meaningful life without ever breaking sweat or [...] needing help. And to some extent we have succeeded, judging by a survey of 5,000 UK fathers [...] which found three-quarters now say they genuinely want to share the parenting load equally with their partners. Except, it seems, the outside world has yet to catch up.

One in five men said they had been asked, when requesting time off work for family reasons, where their wife or partner was. Translation: isn't that *her* job? And perhaps [...]: if in your house it's not her job, what kind of man does that make you? Most of the other hurdles men reported – such as being challenged on whether the family crisis was really so urgent, or worrying that their boss would think less of them for asking – will be wearily familiar to most working mothers. But I've never been asked why I can't just get my husband to do it all, in a way that implies there must be something wrong with me if not.

Working fathers' battles are both the same and also subtly different from those of working mothers, and therein lies the faint air of suspicion lingering between two camps essentially fighting the same war. [...] Yet it can be hard to see the similarities at work when you're fighting each other at home, locked in competition over who is most exhausted, or whose turn it is to trudge off to soft play. Where were you when we were doing the hard yards?, women think grimly to themselves, when they hear a certain kind of man talking loudly about how he prides himself on being really present for the kids. Oh *now* men are interested in flexible working: [...], and it's just a matter of actually using the legal rights that women once fought like tigers for? [...]

But someone has to show men it can be done. The lesson from the introduction of shared parental leave [...] is that many fathers don't feel comfortable taking up new rights they're given because they still feel pressure to be the main breadwinner. [...] One solution offered at a conference in London was a campaign for men to "parent out loud" by taking their full whack of leave and openly putting nursery pickups in their office calendars, instead of pretending to be leaving early for some mysteriously important meeting.

Adapted from www.theguardian.com
October 2025
(450 words)

MORE THAN 90% OF SCHOOLS IN ENGLAND BAN MOBILE PHONE USE

Almost all schools in England have already banned mobile phone use by pupils but Daniel Kebede, general secretary of the National Education Union (NEU), the UK's largest education union, has called for a statutory ban owing to the "damaging impact" on young people [...] since the average 12-year-old has access to the most hardcore pornography on their mobile phone, which is incredibly damaging to the well being of young boys and their perceptions of women and girls, sex and relationships.

This is why [...] NEU will soon debate motions calling for greater regulation of social media companies to remove harmful content, including sexual violence or threats against women. Kebede also said "a complete social media ban for under-16s" was also in order. "These organisations, TikTok, Snapchat, Instagram and so on, you can really track the crisis in young people's mental health as they have grown". And, he added, "I think they should be viewed as [similar to] tobacco companies and regulated as such".

The education secretary, said phones had "absolutely no place in classrooms" because of the potential disruption. [...] "As part of our plan for change, she added, we will continue to ramp up monitoring and make sure every school, and every classroom, is phone-free, giving our children the best education."

The Conservatives promoted an amendment to the government's schools bill that required all schools in England to ban the use of phones but Prime Minister Keir Starmer rejected it as "completely unnecessary".

The survey of school policies found some variation in the type of ban. The vast majority of primary schools require pupils to hand their phones to staff, or bar them from bringing the devices to school. But 79% of secondary schools allow students to keep their phones while banning their use or display, while 8% require phones to be handed in, and just 3% stop pupils from bringing them to school. Of the remaining secondary schools, nearly 6% let pupils use their phones during lessons when approved by a teacher.

The children's commissioner surveyed how long children aged 8 to 15 spent on their phones, tablets, computers or consoles, finding that 43% spent between three and four hours a day on average, while half of them spent more than four hours a day. Of course, they are not doing that while at school but still, these figures are stunning.

This is why the authorities need to get serious about regulating what children can see, where they see it and curbing the damage currently being wreaked on their health, attention span and safety by tech companies.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
April 2025
(447 words)

MOST OF GEN Z WATCH TV WITH THE SUBTITLES ON

I used to think people displayed subtitles only when necessary since I think they distract from the purity of the audiovisual experience such as the glimpse of a tear in an actor's eye, the punchline of an expertly timed joke, and so on.

But a survey has found that 80% of 18-25-year-old people used subtitles most of the time. [...] Meanwhile, a previous survey found that less than a quarter of boomers used subtitles, despite the latter generation experiencing more hearing difficulties overall.

Why is this practice so common among young people? If you aren't hearing-impaired and are fluent in the language of the dialogue, what is it about subtitles that makes them more appealing?

An easy assumption is that this is the result of a short attention span, passivity and a lazy nature, a failure of generation Zombie. But in fact, the new status quo of "subtitles on" among the young reflects both a values shift and cultural conditioning as a result of big tech's ever-encroaching impact on entertainment experience.

For example, the small screen in their living room has to share its importance with the micro screen in their lap. Indeed, 80% of gen Z and millennials "double-screen" when they watch a film. With subtitles on, it is easier to quickly gather what one character has said. [...]

Social media itself has encouraged the use of subtitles across the board. It is now a given that most creators add text captions to their videos – without the option to turn them off. This cultural shift may explain the generational gap between boomers and younger viewers, the latter only appeased by rapid-fire content and videos with faster cuts, absorbing lightweight content at a higher speed, which text captions allow them to do.

This isn't simply a trend but a feature anchored in the algorithm itself. Text captions, rather than dialogue, encourage the video to crop up in search engines, increasing reach and visibility as well as viewer retention and viewing time. It began as an accessibility improvement, but the rapidity with which it has caught on suggests it's business-oriented. The fact that 85% of social media visual content is now watched on mute, while commuting, cooking or at the gym, coupled with the ease with which AI can generate subtitles without the need for human transcription, means we're living in a subtitled world – one that is often poorly translated. [...]

So, the questions are: "Are people now watching shows just to find out what happens, and to prove they've seen it? TV is supposed to be fun. [...] Shouldn't we be focused on enjoying it?"

Adapted from *The Guardian*
September 2025
(449 words)

MUST WE CHOOSE BETWEEN CULTURAL HERITAGE AND ECOLOGICAL RECOVERY?

As someone who has dedicated their career to protecting nature [...], I sometimes feel a quiet guilt during my walk to work. Every morning, I find myself in awe of the colleges of Oxford University, which take me back to centuries of history and cultural heritage. And yet, spread across the shire are endless expanses of neatly kept grass meadows, low in biodiversity [...] offering little in terms of ecological restoration. I thus ask myself: are cultural heritage and ecological recovery compatible?

During a university field trip in the Scottish Highlands, my ecology professor described the region not as pristine wilderness, but as a degraded landscape, an “ecological disaster.” A result of centuries of overgrazing, encouraged by aristocratic landowners, keen on preserving their weekend hunting grounds. [...] To me, however, there is still something charming about these lands, the set of countless Celtic legends. [...]

This tension plays out across the world with the case of farming [...]. The rolling vineyards in the renowned Italian region of Tuscany, now synonymous with romance and identity, are the result of centuries of deforestation and monoculture. [...]

Small-scale farming often has a lower environmental impact, benefiting from local distribution and less intensive practices. By targeting certain actors over others, we risk penalizing those with smaller footprints and overlooking larger polluters. [...] We miss the chance to learn from and improve sustainable food practices rooted in tradition. [...]

Part of the problem lies in how we view nature [...]. Wild spaces are often pictured as dangerous, chaotic, or inaccessible. After all, the human species is celebrated for its ability to work against the forces of nature, to master the soil, the crops, to fight off predators and diseases. [...]

This comes to a philosophical question: are humans part of nature, or have they evolved out of it? For Francis Bacon, an English philosopher and early advocate of the scientific method, humans used science as a tool to “conquer nature.” [...]

We are entirely dependent on the natural world. [...] Indigenous communities in the Amazon, whose way of living is grounded in respect for the Earth and its resources, are a prime example of how culture can be linked with a care for and a collective behaviour towards protecting and restoring nature. [...]

Working with local communities, respecting the history and values of the land, and building trust are all essential for long-term success of conservation efforts. [...]

Whilst today’s ideologies tend to divide us, [...] I support the recovery of our world’s ecosystems and biodiversity, and yet I do appreciate the reflection of our culture and history within our landscapes. Not recognizing the importance of both will only build a stronger divide between environmentalists and the rest of our society.

Conservation must be guided by our cultures, values, histories.

Adapted from *earth.org*
August 2025
(450 words)

NATIONAL PARKS FACING 'NIGHTMARE' UNDER TRUMP

Americans should act to protect US national parks through the “nightmare” of Donald Trump’s presidency, according to a former National Park Service director, amid alarm over the impact of the federal government shutdown. Jonathan Jarvis claimed the agency is now in the hands of a “bunch of ideologues” who would have no issue watching parks from Yellowstone to Yosemite [...] “go down in flames.”

Jarvis, who led the NPS from 2009 to 2017, faced intense criticism after closing all national park sites during a previous shutdown. He was certain that it was the right thing to do: keeping them open with a skeleton staff would have put parks and their visitors at risk. Over the past month, hundreds of NPS veterans including Jarvis, 72, have disapproved Trump’s decision to keep all national parks open during the longest shutdown in US history. There have been consequences. A fire at Joshua Tree national park burnt through some 72 acres. Yosemite faced a wave of illegal BASE jumping. Yellowstone grappled with bear jams. Vandalism included graffiti in Arches national park. A stone wall at Gettysburg national military park was damaged. Trash started to gather at various sites.

Thousands of NPS workers are typically around to guide visitors safely through parks, rescue them from danger, keep traffic moving, monitor wildlife and protect the landscape. “If you take all of those employees, you basically are creating unsafe conditions for the visitor [...] and putting these irreplaceable resources at risk.” [...] Now that the shutdown is over, after 42 days, Jarvis said service staff will have to work hard to clean up US national parks. He also remains concerned about the lasting impacts. [...] Under Trump, its workforce has shrunk by as much as 24% amid hundreds of layoffs. Thousands more staff have resigned or retired, either out of choice or due to pressure, and the agency remains without a permanent director. [...]

“I don’t get it,” said Jarvis. “I don’t get why you would mess up something that is highly popular with the American people. It’s important to preserve the jobs of staff in visible roles, like rangers, but why cut everything else behind the scenes?” From scientists and paleontologists to historians and landscape architects, backroom staff are critical at the NPS; “All of that activity that goes on behind the scenes is what raises the quality of the experience.” [...] “I’ve been to Disneyland,” Jarvis continued. “They’ll have a fake geyser. They’ll have all kinds of entertaining kinds of things. But it’s not real. The value proposition here for the parks is that this is real. Those are real wildlife. That’s a real bison. And it’s not behind a fence.”

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(454 words)

NEW YORK POST'S ANTI-MAMDANI FRONT PAGE IS A HIT – WITH HIS SUPPORTERS

The New York Post's "On your Marx, get set, Go!" front page published just hours after democratic socialist Zohran Mamdani's win in the New York mayor's race is proving a viral hit, with one seller on eBay selling a print copy for \$355 soon after it was listed for auction.

The Post's 5th November front page, with "The Red Apple" headline featuring Mamdani holding up a Soviet-style hammer and sickle, is also being sold by the newspaper as a \$75 metal print.

Ironically, given the rightwing Rupert Murdoch-owned publication's staunch opposition to the mayor-elect, it's proving a hit with Mamdani supporters.

The paper reported that left-leaning voters have been scouring newsstands for copies, with the edition quickly selling out. "The artwork is genius. It's a shock factor," a Mamdani supporter told the outlet. He said he and a friend had been to about a dozen delis in Brooklyn to search for a copy but they had already sold out.

"We love Zohran," he said. "I think it's a very important moment in our lives. It would have been amazing to have the paper to capture this moment in time."

The deli owner, Aaron Saleh, told the outlet that copies had sold out within an hour of opening at 6am and his phone had been "ringing off the hook" with callers asking for copies. "There were like 100 people in here today asking for it. About 30 people called asking if we had it," said Saleh, who also admired the issue, calling it "amazing".

At least one store in the gentrifying Bedford section of Brooklyn where Mamdani is hugely popular, put up a "No New York Post" sign indicating it had sold out, according to a photo posted to X.

"I've looked all over [the neighborhood] for a copy, and the last place I looked had put up this sign because so many people have been asking!" the X user posted.

The decidedly pro-capitalism Post appeared happy to profit from its Mamdani cover while still violently criticizing Mamdani's plans for the city, including higher taxes on the super-wealthy to fund free city services like public buses and childcare.

In a critique of the mayor-elect's sharp victory speech, a rightwing Post editorial writer said on Thursday that it "should serve as a belated alarm to business and political leaders who played footsie with him in the belief that under his radical rhetoric, there existed a reasonable man who could be charmed into cooperation".

The column signed off: "Good luck, New York. You'll need it."

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(443 words)

NOBEL PRIZE IN CHEMISTRY AWARDED [...] FOR WORK ON 'HERMIONE'S HANDBAG'

The Nobel prize in chemistry has been awarded to three scientists who created revolutionary porous materials that can harvest water from desert air, capture carbon dioxide from industrial facilities and remove toxins from water.

Susumu Kitagawa, of Kyoto University, Richard Robson, of the University of Melbourne, and Omar Yaghi, of the University of California, Berkeley, shared the [...] prize awarded by the Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences [...]

The trio found ways to combine metal ions and organic molecules into highly porous structures through which liquids and gases could flow. Tens of thousands of such materials have since been made for applications ranging from storing hydrogen to removing forever chemicals from water and recovering valuable rare earth metals from waste.

The scientists were honoured "for the development of metal-organic frameworks", or MOFs [...], the material of the 21st century.

Speaking at the prize announcement, Prof Heiner Linke, the chair of the Nobel committee for chemistry, said: "They have found ways to create materials, entirely novel materials with large cavities on the inside, which can be seen almost like rooms in a hotel, so that guest molecules can enter and also exit again from the same material."

"A small amount of such material can be almost like Hermione's handbag in Harry Potter. It can store huge amounts of gas in a tiny volume."

The research began in 1989 with Robson, a chemist [...] inspired by the structure of diamonds, he combined copper ions with a four-armed molecule to make pyramid-shaped molecules. These bonded together to form crystals strewn with cavities [...]

Kitagawa showed that similar structures based on cobalt, nickel and zinc were not only stable but could be used to store and release methane, nitrogen and oxygen. He went on to show that MOFs could be tailored to different tasks and even made from flexible materials [...]

Yaghi became fascinated with chemistry at the age of 10 after sneaking into the school library, which was usually locked, and plucking a book at random from the shelves. He was brought up with his siblings in a single room in Amman, Jordan, with no running water or electricity. At his father's insistence he went to study in the US.

Frustrated with the traditional way of building new molecular structures, Yaghi developed a more precise approach that was more like assembling pieces of Lego into large crystals. In the 1990s, he revealed MOFs that resembled nets held together with copper or cobalt. Later, he created an extraordinary zinc-based MOF. A couple of grams held an area as large as a football pitch, meaning it could absorb a vast amount of gas for its size [...]

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(450 words)

OBESITY REMAINS HIGH IN THE US, BUT MORE STATES ARE SHOWING PROGRESS, A NEW REPORT FINDS

For the first time in more than a decade, the number of states with rates of obesity of 35% or more has dropped, an encouraging sign that America's epidemic of excess weight might be improving. But cuts to federal staff and programs that address chronic disease could endanger that progress, according to a new report released Thursday.

Nineteen states had obesity rates of 35% or higher in 2024, down from 23 states the year before, according to an analysis of the latest data collected by the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. The CDC data was analyzed by the nonprofit group Trust for America's Health. [...]

While the decline is positive, "it's too soon to call it a trend," said Dr. J. Nadine Gracia [...]. And with recent federal funding cuts, staff layoffs and eliminated programs, "this potential progress is also at risk," Gracia said. A U.S. Health and Human Services Department spokesman said in an email that the administration is "encouraged by the new data showing progress in the fight against obesity." "We are restructuring public health programs to eliminate waste, reduce bureaucracy, and redirect resources toward real prevention," said spokesman Andrew Nixon.

[...] Between 2023 and 2024, no state had statistically significant increases or decreases in their obesity rates, after 18 states saw significant increases in the previous five years, the report found. Before 2013, no state had an adult obesity prevalence at or above 35%. By 2019, a dozen states had rates that high – and the number continued to climb. [...]

Obesity is a chronic disease linked to a host of serious health problems including diabetes, stroke, cancer and heart disease. It's not clear exactly what may be driving the apparent improvements in obesity. Wider use of drugs such as Wegovy and Zepbound – which target appetite and slow digestion – could be starting to show up in reported data, said Aviva Musicus, a science director for the Center for Science in the Public Interest, an advocacy group. Increased support for nutrition assistance programs during the COVID-19 pandemic might also be a factor, she suggested.

The report also details a broad range of federal, state and local efforts that focus on improving nutrition and boosting physical activity, said Solveig Cunningham, a [...] University expert who specializes in obesity.

"I think the report would argue that some of these interventions may actually be successful," said Cunningham, who was not involved with the research. "That would suggest that there are possibly ways in which we could prevent obesity at the population level, which would be a really, really big deal."

Adapted from *AP News*
October 2025
(458 words)

ONLINE AGE CHECKING IS CREATING A TREASURE TROVE OF DATA FOR HACKERS

A variety of websites now have processes designed to verify the ages of their users. These checks are carried out in several ways. For instance, AI can be used to analyse whether a photo of the person looks old enough for the age threshold on a website. Asking for photo ID, such as a scan of a person's driving licence or passport, is another method, along with asking for a verified credit card.

However, the amount of personal data involved in completing age verification comprises a veritable treasure trove for hackers. Recent incidents have further highlighted the privacy and security concerns around age verification. In October 2025, Discord, a social media and chat platform popular among gamers, was hacked with an unspecified amount of data extracted.

However, the company said it had identified 70,000 users globally who potentially had their photo IDs exposed to the hackers. Discord said the data was accessed through a third-party service provider, although it remains unclear exactly how the breach occurred.

Age verification checks for the UK were brought in by Discord in order to comply with the Online Safety Act. The act required that websites allowing pornography and harmful content introduce age checks by July 2025. [...]

The consequences of such breaches can be grave. Leaked images of selfies and photo IDs can lead to users facing a range of harms, such as identity theft and fraud. The kind of data that's hacked also lends itself to particularly sophisticated forms of these crimes, particularly when you consider the availability of deepfake technology and generative AI tools.

In fact, third-party providers have represented a consistent vulnerability to be relentlessly exploited by cybercriminals, as seen in recent breaches of the UK Ministry of Defence, and the Co-op supermarket [...] to name but a few.

The proliferation of age verification checks in recent years is partly a response to new legislation, such as [...] the European Commission's Digital Services Act and the Online Safety Acts in the UK and Australia. These all deem checks where users self-declare their age as unfit for purpose. Instead, they require websites to use more effective methods, such as photo ID matching, or credit card checks.

In a recent press release, the UK's Department of Science, Innovation and Technology [...] said that any measures implemented by platforms to confirm a user's age must be done "without collecting or storing personal data, unless absolutely necessary". [...]

The incidents show that the implementation and use of age verification require genuine review; further regulation of data handling with enforcement powers – beyond mere guidance. This is a necessity to safeguard privacy, especially when third-party companies are involved.

Adapted from *theconversation.com*
November 2025
(453 words)

ORGAN TRANSPLANTS FOR IMMORTALITY: MIGHT XI AND PUTIN BE ONTO SOMETHING?

Is it possible to become immortal with the help of organ transplants? That was the unexpected topic of discussion this week between Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin when they met at a military parade in Beijing. A translator, speaking in Mandarin on behalf of Putin, told Xi how human organs can be repeatedly transplanted "so that one can get younger and younger" in spite of age, and might even be able to stave off old age "indefinitely". [...]

Organ transplants certainly save lives - in the UK, over 100,000 people have been saved in the last 30 years, says NHS Blood and Transplant. And continued advancements in medicine and technology mean transplanted organs are lasting far longer once in people. Some patients have had a kidney transplant that has kept working for more than 50 years. The lifespan of an organ depends on how healthy the donor and recipient is - plus how well they look after it.

Putin and Xi may be talking about having multiple organs transplanted and perhaps repeatedly.

Currently, people who get a new organ also have to take strong anti-rejection drugs called immunosuppressants for life. These can have side-effects, such as high blood pressure, and increase the risk of infections. Rejection - when your immune system starts to attack the transplanted organ because it recognises it as coming from a different person - can sometimes still happen even if you are taking your medication. Scientists are working on making rejection-free organs, using genetically-altered pigs as the donors. [...]

Another avenue being explored is growing brand new organs using our own human cells. Stem cells have the ability to grow into any type of cell or tissue found in the body. No research group has yet been able to make fully functional, transplantable human organs, but scientists are getting closer. [...]

Tech entrepreneur Bryan Johnson, meanwhile, is spending millions a year trying to reduce his biological age. He's not tried getting new organs yet - as far as we know - but has infused himself with his 17-year-old son's plasma. Dr Julian Mutz from King's College London said beyond organ transplantation, approaches like plasma replacement are being explored, but these remain experimental. Prof Neil Mabbott, an expert in immunopathology at the Roslin Institute, University of Edinburgh, speculates that living to 125 years old might be the upper limit. And while damaged and diseased organs may be replaceable by transplants, as we age our bodies become much less resilient or able to cope with physical stressors. He says rather than focussing on extending life-span, we should instead strive for healthy years lived.

Adapted from *BBC News*
September 2025
(456 words)

PARENTS ON E-BIKES ARE TRANSFORMING THE SCHOOL RUN

After a pandemic boom, the sale of bicycles in general has slowed in America. But sales of the sort that carry children seem to be defying the trend. The owner of The New Wheel, a small chain of bike stores in the San Francisco Bay area, says that over the past decade sales of family e-bikes have gone from nothing to a majority of his business, and continue to rise [...].

Convenience, more than, say, environmentalism, is driving the boom. Speak to the growing number of e-bike parents (a large majority, it seems, fathers) and they universally mention skipping car traffic, wasting less time coaxing recalcitrant children into car seats and never worrying about parking. Car drivers, they say, are suckers. “We have friends who won’t go to the beach because of parking,” says a 42-year-old father in Seattle. That is not a problem on a bike. The fanciest sorts of e-bikes can transport plenty of beach gear, as well as children.

What e-bikes are replacing is generally not the family car but the second runaround. Few parents are giving up driving completely, but a lot of shuttling children around comprises journeys of 2 to 5 km – too far for a toddler to walk, fiddly by public transport, but efficient on a bike. “We bike him to soccer practice, to swim lessons, to his paediatrician; we bike to birthday parties and to the park,” says a lawyer in Chicago, of her five-year-old.

Rising car traffic is one of the reasons why e-bikes are becoming popular. The share of children driven to school by their parents has risen continuously since the 1960s, according to data from the National Household Travel Survey. This is now true of the majority. Driver shortages and budget constraints mean traditional yellow school buses are less common than they were. The result is punishing traffic – in parts of the country, snaking drop-off queues can take hours to clear. One survey of parents found that a majority think their careers have suffered because of having to drive children to school.

The biggest note of concern is safety—bike infrastructure in American cities often leaves much to be desired. In places without protected bike lanes, not many parents are likely to replace the car with a bike. But e-bike parents do not consider that a permanent problem. “They say home ownership makes you much more invested in municipal government,” remarks a 32-year-old father in Denver, Colorado, who cycles his daughter to kindergarten. “I haven’t found that. Biking has.” He recently called up the city engineer to praise a plan to narrow an arterial road near his house. Revolutions begin with a push of the pedal.

Adapted from *The Economist*
November 2025
(463 words)

PAUL MCCARTNEY JOINS MUSIC INDUSTRY PROTEST AGAINST AI

Former Beatle and artists including Sam Fender, Kate Bush and Hans Zimmer have recorded a silent album “Is This What We Want?” At two minutes 45 seconds it’s about the same length as “With a Little Help From My Friends”. But Paul McCartney’s new recording lacks the sing-along tune and jaunty guitar chops because there’s barely anything there.

The former Beatle, arguably Britain’s greatest living songwriter, is releasing a track of an almost completely silent recording studio as part of a music industry protest against copyright theft by artificial intelligence companies. In place of catchy melodies and evocative lyrics there is only quiet hiss and the odd clatter. It suggests that if AI companies unfairly exploit musicians’ intellectual property to train their generative AI models, the creative ecosystem will be wrecked and original music silenced.

McCartney’s contribution comes as musicians and artists step up their campaign to persuade the UK government to stop technology companies from training AI models on their creative output without approval or paying royalties. Meanwhile, Britain faces anti-regulation pressure from Donald Trump’s White House. Trump has said: “We have to allow AI to use that copyrighted pool of knowledge without going through the complexity of contract negotiations” and warned international governments not to “make rules and regulations that make it impossible” for AI companies to do business.

The album track listing spells out “the British government must not legalise music theft to benefit AI companies”.

Ed Newton-Rex, a composer and campaigner for copyright fairness behind the protest album, said: “I am very concerned the government is paying more attention to US tech companies’ interests rather than British creatives’ interests.” The composer Max Richter added: “The government’s proposals would impoverish creators, favouring those automating creativity over the people who compose our music, write our literature, paint our art.” [...]

McCartney has been among leading voices in British music voicing concern as the ministers’ plans forge a new deal between creatives and AI companies such as Open AI, Google, Anthropic and Elon Musk’s X-AI, which demand access to huge volumes of training information including text, images and music. “We’ve got to be careful about it because it could just take over and we don’t want that to happen, particularly for the young composers and writers for who it may be the only way they’re gonna make a career,” McCartney has said of AI.

A new legal system for AI and copyright is not expected to be debated in parliament before 2026. In the meantime, the government has signed deals with AI companies including Open AI, Google and Anthropic to boost AI adoption across government and the wider economy [...].

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(448 words)

PROSPECT OF LIFE ON SATURN'S MOONS RISES AFTER DISCOVERY OF ORGANIC SUBSTANCES

The likelihood that one of Saturn's moons may harbour life has risen, experts say, after finding an array of carbon-based substances being spewed out of Enceladus.

The sixth largest of Saturn's moons, Enceladus has become one of the leading contenders in the search for bodies that could harbour extraterrestrial life, with the Cassini mission – which ended in 2017 – revealing the moon has a plume of water ice grains and vapours erupting from beneath the surface at its south pole.

The phenomenon has since been captured by the James Webb space telescope, with the cloud reaching nearly 6,000 miles into space. The source of this material is thought to be a saltwater ocean that lies beneath the moon's icy crust.

Now researchers studying data from the Cassini mission say they have discovered organic substances within the plume, with some types of molecule detected there for the first time.

Dr Nozair Khawaja, a planetary scientist at Freie University Berlin and lead author of the work, said the results increased the known complexity of the chemistry that is happening below the surface of Enceladus. "When there is complexity happening, that means that the habitable potential of Enceladus is increasing right now," he said.

Writing in the journal *Nature Astronomy*, Khawaja and colleagues reported how their previous work had revealed the presence of organic substances and salts within ice grains found in a ring of Saturn, known as the "E-ring", that is composed of material ejected from Enceladus. [...]

The results, based on data from an instrument called the Cosmic Dust Analyzer, not only confirm the presence of the organic substances previously found in the E-ring of Saturn – indicating they originated from within Enceladus – but reveal the presence of other types, too.

While the new findings do not show that there is life on Enceladus, Khawaja said they indicate there are complex chemical pathways at play that could lead to the formation of substances that could be biologically relevant. The results, he added, support plans by the European Space Agency to investigate the moon for signs of life. "I think all the signals are green here for Enceladus," Khawaja said.

Dr Jörn Helbert, the head of the solar system section at the ESA and who was not part of the study, told the *Guardian* the plan for the new mission – which he hopes would launch around 2042 – consists of an orbiter around Enceladus that will also fly through the cloud, as well as a lander that will touch down in the south pole region of the moon. [...]

"That means we now have all elements required for Enceladus to harbour life – liquid water, energy and complex prebiotic molecules," Helbert said. [...]

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(460 words)

PUSHY PARENTS ARE 'THE BIGGEST PROBLEM IN SPORTS PERFORMANCE'

In recent years, a number of British schools have banned parents from attending sports days over bad behaviour, while growing levels of abuse from parents on the sidelines of grassroots football is discouraging people from refereeing. "It's the biggest problem in sports performance and it has been going on for years," said [...] the chair of the British Psychological Society's sport and exercise psychology division.

"The level of abuse has only got worse. Behaviour has got worse. But it has been ignored and now we're trying to put the genie back in the bottle, both in terms of the way that parents are putting pressure on their children, and the impact of poor behaviour and abuse that's coming from the sidelines." [...] Intrusion from parents can make children "freeze up because of the pressure" and watching their parents shout abuse can have a hugely negative impact on a child.

Children with 'consistent, responsive, warm and reliable' parents are more likely to develop a secure attachment style that will give them confidence in sport, say experts. There are signs in the park on a Saturday morning saying: 'Remember, it's supposed to be fun. Treat the referees with respect. Try not to shout abuse at the other team.'

A sport psychologist said banning parents from events wasn't the answer and allowing them to support their children in healthy competition was an important part of childhood. "You're depriving parents of that time where they're seeing their children either struggle or succeed, watching them grow up and those are developmental milestones," he added. "Also as a child, your parents are who you look to in times of stress, they provide a lot of emotional support."

Most of the well-established successful athletes that we have in this country, and worldwide, have had reasonably strong parental networks. Many of the world's biggest sports stars have talked of how pressure from their parents helped push them towards success or, in some cases, pushed them too far.

[...] David Beckham has spoken about how his father's strict training regime involved spending hours in the park practising every night, and being reduced to tears when he was shouted at for poor performances. But he also said this had helped prepare him for the pressures of an international football career, reflecting that "all those moments where my dad was hard on me as a kid, there was a reason for it".

[...] There is an urgent need to address the role parents play in their children's training when pursuing a career in sports, but despite people repeatedly raising the issue, no organisation has stepped forward to help.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(440 words)

RIDE IN A ROBOTAXI? WHO DO YOU BLAME IF IT GOES WRONG?

Why would anyone ever get into a “robotaxi”? In London, it’s soon going to be a live question, because Waymo, owned by Alphabet, parent of Google, has been allowed to trial driverless taxis in the capital.

If things go smoothly, the experiment will spread nationwide and the profession of taxi driving may become a thing of the past. The change might seem gradual at first, but once it starts, it will be impossible to reverse.

I have qualms about being propelled in a metal box with no human in charge. [...] Who do you blame if it goes wrong, assuming you’re still around to ask questions? Even if statistics show the robotaxi has fewer accidents than humans, it’s still a considerable act of faith [...]

Have you ever been in a car that thinks for itself? I’m still recovering from driving a “smart” Chinese SUV that slammed on the brakes whenever I passed an articulated lorry because it thought I was about to hit it. [...] I might well have ended up under the wheels of a Royal Mail truck. Positively dangerous, and deeply unsettling for the person behind the wheel.

They also misread speed limits, thinking a fast road beside a suburban street should be twenty miles per hour instead of seventy. [...] The technology is impressive but far from flawless, and the smallest error could have serious consequences [...]

You probably already use bits of it: advanced driver assistance systems and sat navs. Link them all up and your vehicle can take you where you need to go, fairly safely on current evidence. (Probably the only thing not yet solved is refuelling or recharging.)

Even now, if you own a smart model, the car can accelerate, brake, stay in lane, and obey limits automatically. A Chinese vehicle with LiDAR – “light detection and ranging” – learns to drive rather like a toddler learns to move around a room. On the dashboard you can see how it “sees” the world, trying to tell parked cars from moving ones or pedestrians from trees. Fascinating stuff, and slightly eerie when you realise how much the machine already understands.

But trust one to drive me around? Not likely. Then again, humans aren’t flawless either, and I’ve had enough points on my licence to know humility. The robotaxi feels inevitable, and the autonomous vehicle will likely make professional driving – and perhaps personal motoring – a thing of the past.

For me, someone who has just spent a day driving new and classic Bentleys around Cheshire, that would be the real loss. Even if the latest models almost drive themselves, who truly wants to give up control, or the pure joy of being at the wheel?

Adapted from *The Independent*
October 2025
(457 words)

SCARY TIMES CALL FOR EVEN SCARIER FILMS

It should surprise no one to learn that 2025 is being hailed as a golden year for horror films. All horror movies are a reflection of their time, and ours are pretty scary.

Tech dystopianism means that Frankenstein's monster has become synonymous with AI, while Bram Stoker's Dracula has always drawn on a dark kind of English xenophobia. So it is no coincidence that these 19th-century gothic villains, stars of the earliest horror films in the 1920s and 30s, are back in cinemas with new adaptations from directors Guillermo del Toro and Luc Besson. [...]

Blood-sucking vampires and dead-eyed zombies have long been cast as the monsters of capitalism, coming out in times of economic gloom. This may explain why Sinners, a [...] southern gothic vampire mashup [...], has caused such an emotional reaction. As a [...] philosopher has observed: "It's much easier to imagine the end of all life on Earth than a much more modest radical change in capitalism."

Horror movies tap into our most primal fears, but they are also uniquely able to embody each new era's anxieties. Emerging out of German expressionism after the first world war, the genre flourished against the backdrop of the Vietnam war in the late 1960s and 70s; the Aids epidemic and rampant consumerism led to a vampire reawakening in the 80s.

The superhero seemingly reigned supreme over 21st-century multiplexes. But in dark times the rise of "elevated horror" – scary films with a social commentary – has finally ended their sovereignty. Horror films are much cheaper to make, drawing in younger film-makers and encouraging experimentation. It has become an unlikely medium through which to explore issues such as race, class and gender. [...]

Horror is also attracting more women, both as film-makers and audiences. Last year's Oscar-winning *The Substance* by Coralie Fargeat [...] took on themes of misogyny, celebrity and gender dysphoria. [...]

Catharsis and the perverse comfort of the worst-case scenario go some way to explain "the horror paradox": why we enjoy being made to feel scared. Steven Soderbergh's [...] pandemic thriller, *Contagion*, was one of the most downloaded films of 2020. Horror helped get fans back into the cinemas after Covid. While we binge-watch the latest dramas from our sofas, there is a communality, and safety, in being frightened together.

In the face of the all-too-real horror of war, the existential implications of the climate emergency and fears over where AI may lead us, it is no wonder we sometimes want to go into a dark room and scream. [...] As an English writer put it: "The ultimate dystopia is the inside of one's own head."

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(443 words)

SCHOOL SMARTPHONE BANS - ARE THEY EFFECTIVE?

Banning smart phones in schools has become an increasingly popular move for teachers looking to improve children's education, concentration and wellbeing.

While some health and education professionals and campaigners argue the bans help improve young people's mental health, there are arguments that sanctions can make little difference, do not go far enough, or could have a negative impact.

The head teacher of one of the first schools to ban mobiles, Rebecca Mahony, said many parents had accepted the move. But she said she had been told by some parents that their children were becoming anxious because they felt they were missing out. Ms Mahony said the prohibition was "now very much part of the DNA" after its introduction in 2017 due to concerns over disruption, lower attention spans and cyber-bullying. But she added: "There have been some really sad tales from parents actually saying my child needs their phone because they are anxious." (...)

A recent study found that banning phones in schools was not linked to pupils getting higher grades or having better mental health. Sleep, classroom behaviour, exercise, and how long was spent on phones overall were found to be no different for pupils at schools with phone bans and those without, the academics found. However, University of Birmingham academics did find that spending longer on smartphones and social media in general was linked with worse results across all those areas.

(...) Ms Mahony said her main concern was mobile phones' "impact on mental health". "The anxiety levels are through the roof, we're seeing an addiction to phones," she said. "I'm seeing children that can't communicate with one another. They can't look each other in the eye when they communicate. They're not learning the social norms. They're not learning about body language."

About 145,000 children and 14,000 schools in the UK have signed a pact to increase the age at which smartphones should be used, according to the organisers Smartphone Free Childhood. Campaign spokeswoman Victoria Kazi, a GP, said they recommended no smartphones for under-14s, and no social media for under-16s, after which age "they're more mature and able to cope with the complexity". (...) Dr Goodyear, the lead author of the study, said its findings were not "against" smartphone bans in schools. "What we're suggesting is that those bans in isolation are not enough to tackle the negative impacts," she added. "We need to do more than just ban phones in schools."

Writer Jack Thorne, who created the recent drama *Adolescence* about a fictional killing spurred by a boy's use of social media, has also called for the government to take "radical action" similar to Australia's recent ban on under-16s from using social media.

Adapted from *BBC News*
June 2025
(461 words)

SCHOOL UNIFORMS WERE MEANT TO BE THE GREAT LEVELLER – HOW DOES A £400 BILL DO THAT?

[...] The British obsession with forcing children into business attire from an age when they can't yet read or write is surely a form of national delirium. School uniform undoubtedly has worthy roots. It has prevailed in most schools since the 19th century, when it was introduced as a means to reduce the appearance of socioeconomic disparities and create a sense of community and cohesion. [...]

At the small, south London state primary my daughter attends, the blazer alone costs £38. The branded cardigan, made of 50% acrylic, is £23. These, alongside the other compulsory items on the school's list, must be bought from one specialist uniform supplier. Delivery is another £8. [...]

Government messaging says schools should make uniforms affordable and work with families who struggle to afford them. But there is no benchmark to say how they should be priced, nor any set rules that schools have to abide by. Indeed, some schools ask for as many as 10 branded items, pushing the cost of a child's uniform with PE kit up to £400. The government recognises the problem – it has plans to limit branded student kit to three articles, plus a tie, from September 2026 in England, and the education secretary, Bridget Phillipson, has urged schools to bring in reasonable measures beforehand. "You don't need a posh blazer to learn your times tables, and Shakespeare is just as inspiring in a supermarket sweater," she wrote on X. I couldn't agree more – especially when said blazer will probably be lost in the first week of term. [...]

There is an argument that uniforms help to drive up standards, that being smartly dressed encourages a level of engagement with education. Or, for schools in big cities struggling to attract pupils, maybe it's a way for them to stand out – a form of advertising their high standards. Private school-inspired uniform must appeal to some socially ambitious parents. But research on the impact of uniforms is mixed. "There is little robust evidence that introducing a school uniform will, by itself, improve academic performance, behaviour, or attendance," says the Education Endowment Foundation. And however much uniforms have been modernised, they remain heavily gendered. New research from the University of Cambridge found school uniform policies could even be restricting young people from being active, particularly primary school-age girls. [...]

As our climate becomes more unpredictable and our school buildings suddenly feel woefully unfit to cope with the changing temperatures, it feels more important than ever that our children are dressed comfortably and that the fabrics they wear are not just breathable but also sustainable. [...]

Adapted from *The Guardian*
August 2025
(454 words)

SCIENTISTS CREATE HUMAN EGGS IN THE LAB, USING SKIN CELLS

Scientists have created human eggs containing genes from adult skin cells, a step that someday could help women who are infertile or gay couples have babies with their own genes but would also raise difficult ethical, social and legal issues. "It's a significant step forward," says Mr Mitalipov of [...] Portland University, who led the research published in the journal *Nature*. Millions of women can't have children using their own eggs because of their age or other reasons. So scientists have been trying to create human eggs in the lab that carry the genes of people struggling to have children. The field is known as in vitro gametogenesis, and involves researchers around the world, including in Japan, as well as at U.S. biotech companies. [...]

Mitalipov's team used the technique that was used to clone Dolly the sheep: The scientists removed most of the DNA from a healthy donor egg and replaced it with most of the DNA from another woman's skin cell. Next, the researchers essentially tricked the reconstituted egg to skip normal forms of cell division [...] and produced functional eggs. The scientists then fertilized the eggs with sperm to see if they could develop into embryos. And it appears to have worked, at least in a small number of tries. [...]

However, none of the embryos would have been suitable to actually implant into a womb to develop further. That's because all the embryos still had genetic abnormalities that would prevent healthy development. [...]

If IVG is ever perfected, the technology could have applications beyond helping infertile women. IVG could, for example, also allow gay couples to have babies genetically related to both partners. [...] But some scientists warn that the genetic abnormalities in Mitalipov's embryos raise questions of whether this approach could ever work. [...]

And even if it did work, the technology would create lots of tricky issues. Some worry this could help create "designer babies," where parents can pick and choose the traits of their children. [...] Another concern is that this could enable people to steal a skin cell from another person, such as a celebrity, and make a baby with their DNA without their knowledge or permission. [...]

Another possibility is using this technology to create a "uni-baby," a child containing only one person's genetic material. "That's a very weird possibility," Mr Greely, a Stanford University bioethicist, says. "Would anyone want to do that? Well, there are 8 billion people in the world and some of them have very strong egos and some are very rich. So I wouldn't guarantee that no one would want to do that."

While all those possibilities need to be debated, Greely and others argue that the technology is worth pursuing with proper oversight.

Adapted from *NPR*
September 2025
(458 words)

SCIENTISTS IDENTIFY KEY REASON PEOPLE MAY USE OR GET ADDICTED TO CANNABIS

The tendency to use cannabis is associated with genes linked to impulsive behavior, obesity, schizophrenia and bipolar disorder, among other traits, according to a study released Monday by researchers at the University of California at San Diego.

The research, published in the journal *Molecular Psychiatry*, explored the genetic traits of casual and frequent cannabis users in hopes of eventually identifying medications and other therapies to treat or prevent problematic marijuana use.

The study adds to a growing body of genetics research into cannabis use as policymakers and researchers weigh how to balance the benefits and consequences of the drug's growing popularity. One of the lead authors [...] stressed that only a small percentage of people who try marijuana develop a cannabis use disorder but said the risk factors remain unclear. The study is one of the few genome-wide association studies to explore traits of those who become addicted [...].

"Studying the biological underpinnings of why someone's use of cannabis may then lead to disorder will reveal something fundamental and can lead to new therapeutics," [...] a researcher at the Institute for Genomic Medicine said [...]. For example, genomic data could identify existing drugs that might be useful to treat cannabis use disorder [...].

A cannabis use disorder is not deadly as an addiction to opioids or alcohol can be. But it can still disrupt people's daily lives, interfering with a person's work, education and relationships, and some struggle to quit because of nausea and mood swings. There is no Food and Drug Administration-approved medication specifically to treat cannabis use disorder.

Scientists have long known that genetics alongside environmental factors play a substantial role in addiction to substances but caution that more studies are needed. Thousands of genetic traits may affect a person's vulnerability to addiction – and even then, the risk of getting hooked may only be slightly higher, said [...] an addiction researcher at Stanford University [...]. He said studies are unlikely to find a single gene – or even a cluster of genes – that causes addiction. "The brain is too complex, and addiction is not just biological or neurochemical," he said. "It's deeply influenced by context, stress and social environment."

Real-world payoff from genome and addiction research remains far off, researchers cautioned, and developing tests to figure out who is predisposed to addiction has proved a thorny issue. Genetics researchers have criticized the FDA's 2023 decision to approve a test that purports to assess the genetic risk of opioid addiction, asserting the test relied on unsound science.

Twenty-four states have legalized recreational marijuana [...] raising concern from public health advocates, addiction experts and lawmakers about stronger, poorly regulated cannabis products with harmful effects.

Adapted from *The Washington Post*
October 2025
(449 words)

SECRETS OF THE DEEP, DEEP TUNNELS WHERE NUCLEAR WASTE IS BURIED

The lift is accelerating into the earth, the scientists and engineers on board holding back groans as their bodies move faster than their stomachs. "This is the fastest passenger elevator in Europe," says Tuohimaa, a spokesman for Posiva, the nuclear disposal company that runs this facility. The lift drops four hundred metres in sixty seconds before the passengers step into a vast network of tunnels excavated below the island of Olkiluoto off Finland's west coast. [...]

This is the world's first deep geological disposal facility for nuclear fuel, a concept that has been discussed by engineers and politicians for half a century. More than twenty other countries including the United Kingdom, the USA, France and Sweden have plans to follow suit. But Finland got there first. [...]

Burying nuclear waste deep in the earth is considered a "final disposal", a solution that has been calculated to enable it to remain undisturbed for at least five hundred thousand years, surviving ice ages, earthquakes and sea level rise. A safe disposal option fills in the "missing link" in the pro-nuclear argument. Nuclear power is consistent, secure and free of emissions. While wind and solar power are cheap and green, when the wind doesn't blow and the sun doesn't shine, consistent power is essential to stop the lights going out. Without it, zero emissions would be impossible. [...]

Every week, for the next one hundred years, one can of spent nuclear fuel will be transported four hundred meters down into the earth. Here, a robotic vehicle will carry it down one of the many disposal tunnels and carefully place it into an eight-meter-deep hole that has been bored down into the rock. [...]

Once the can is in place the hole will be packed with bentonite, a special clay that will swell when wet, sealing the can in place. Then, the deposit made, the robots will fill up the access tunnels over them with more clay. Finally in the year 2120, the entire facility – the underground access roads, lift shafts and ventilation systems – will be filled up and sealed. Sanna Mustonen, has been working here for twenty years, seeing the first excavations in 2003. "Being here from the beginning and seeing it now finally happening, it's marvellous, wonderful."

When we started the US was well ahead, so were the Swedes and maybe the French." She believes her team overtook them because they set a plan and simply followed it, but she admits that the support of the local population has helped. "Acceptance for the final disposal proposal was high here in Finland."

Adapted from *The Times*
September 2025
(442 words)

SHOULD FACIAL ANALYSIS HELP DETERMINE WHOM COMPANIES HIRE?

A new paper suggests a photo can tell a recruiter much about an applicant's personality. Imagine appearing for a job interview and, without saying a single word, being told that you are not getting the role because your face didn't fit. You would assume discrimination, and might even contemplate litigation.

But what if bias was not the reason? What if your face gave genuinely useful clues about your probable performance at work? That question is at the heart of a recent research paper from Marius Guenzel of the University of Pennsylvania and his co-authors. The possibility that it does raises larger questions about algorithmic decision-making and how humans perceive fairness.

Personality assessments are an accepted part of recruitment processes. They normally involve candidates taking surveys and guessing what counts as a good answer. Yet previous research suggests that personality types can be encoded in facial features, and that artificial intelligence (AI) can spot them. So Mr Guenzel and his co-authors used an algorithm to analyse the pictures of 96,000 MBA graduates, and extract what they call the "Photo Big Five"—as they rename the Big Five personality traits of agreeableness, conscientiousness, extraversion, neuroticism and openness. (Before you head to the mirror, it's not obvious what the AI is seeing.)

They then used data on these individuals' labour-market outcomes to see whether the Photo Big Five had any predictive power. The answer, they conclude, is yes: facial analysis has useful things to say about a person's post-MBA earnings and propensity to move jobs, among other things.

There are plenty of caveats. The predictive power of the Photo Big Five shouldn't be exaggerated; the authors say it is only an incremental source of information on candidates. The field of AI facial analysis is young, and has been at the centre of methodological firestorms in the past. And even if techniques were flawless, adoption is likely to be slow. Anti-discrimination laws mean that there are obvious legal risks associated with making any decisions based on facial characteristics. Manish Raghavan of the MIT Sloan School of Management notes that companies are wary of using AI for facial analysis (though he worries more about bias infecting chatbot summaries of candidates' CVs or LinkedIn profiles.)

But suppose that all these objections were surmountable. If your face could tell a prospective employer something useful, without discriminating on grounds of protected characteristics, then firms would have a strong incentive to analyse it. There would still be questions, though. The authors give an example: "Among white male job candidates, is it ethical to screen out individuals whose faces predict less desirable personalities?" [...]

Adapted from *The Economist*
November 2025
(444 words)

SLEEP TRAINING IS NO LONGER JUST FOR BABIES. SOME SCHOOLS ARE TEACHING TEENS HOW TO SLEEP

The topic of a new course at Mansfield Senior High School is one that teenagers across the country are having trouble with: How to Get to Sleep.

One ninth grader in the class says his method is to scroll through TikTok until he nods off. Another teen says she often falls asleep while on a late-night group chat with friends. Not everyone takes part in class discussions on a recent Friday; some students are slumped over their desks napping.

Sleep training is no longer just for newborns. Some schools are taking it upon themselves to teach teenagers how to get a good night's sleep.

Adolescents burning the midnight oil is nothing new; teens are biologically programmed to stay up later as their circadian rhythms shift with puberty. But studies show teenagers are more sleep deprived than ever, and experts believe it could be playing a role in the youth mental health crisis and other problems plaguing schools, including behavioral and attendance issues. [...]

Research increasingly shows how tightly sleep is linked to mood, mental health and selfharm. Depression, anxiety and suicidal thoughts and behavior go up as sleep goes down. Multiple studies also show links between insufficient sleep and sports injuries and athletic performance, teen driving accidents, and risky sexual behavior and substance use, due in part to impaired judgment when the brain is sleepy. [...]

The district's high school is piloting the new curriculum, "Sleep to Be a Better You," hoping to improve academic success and reduce chronic absences, when a student misses more than 10% of the school year. The rate of students missing that much class has decreased from 44% in 2021 but is still high at 32%, says Kari Cawrse, the district's attendance coordinator. Surveys of parents and students highlighted widespread problems with sleep, and an intractable cycle of kids going to bed late, oversleeping, missing the school bus and staying home. [...]

Over 50% go to sleep while looking at their phones. Experts have urged parents for years to get phones out of the bedroom at night, but national surveys show most teens keep their mobile phones within reach — and many fall asleep holding their devices. During the six-part course, students are asked to keep daily sleep logs for six weeks and rate their mood and energy levels.

There are scientific reasons for that. Studies with MRI scans show the brain is under stress when sleep-deprived and functions differently. There is less activity in the pre-frontal cortex, which regulates emotions, decision making, focus and impulse control and more activity in the emotional center of the brain, the amygdala, which processes fear, anger and anxiety.

Adapted from *The Seattle Times*

April 2025
(460 words)

SMOKING AVATARS AND ONLINE GAMES: HOW BIG TOBACCO TARGETS YOUNG PEOPLE IN THE METAVERSE

Virtual online spaces are becoming a new marketing battleground as tobacco and alcohol promoters target young people without any legislative consequences.

A report shared at the World Conference on Tobacco Control last month in Dublin set out multiple examples of new technologies being adopted to promote smoking and vaping, including tobacco companies launching digital tokens and vape companies sponsoring online games.

It comes from a monitoring project known as Canary – because it seeks to act as the canary in a coalmine – run by the global public health organisation Vital Strategies.

“Tobacco companies are no longer waiting for regulations to catch them up. They are way ahead of us. We are still trying to understand what we’re seeing in social media, but they’re already operating in unregulated spaces like the metaverse,” says Dr Melina Magsumbol, of Vital Strategies India. “They’re using NFTs [non-fungible tokens]. They’re using immersive events to get our kids to come and see what they’re offering.”

In India, one tobacco company made and promoted an NFT, which represents ownership of digital assets, to celebrate its 93rd anniversary.

Canary scans for and analyses tobacco marketing on social media platforms and news sites in India, Indonesia and Mexico. It is expanding to more countries, including Brazil and China, and to cover alcohol and ultra-processed food marketing.

It is not set up to scan the metaverse – a three-dimensional, immersive version of the internet that uses technology such as virtual reality headsets to enable people to interact in a digital space. But it has picked up references to what is going on there via links and information shared on older social media sites.

Researchers say that children are likely to be exposed to any tobacco marketing in the new digital spaces given the age profile of users – more than half of the metaverse’s active users are aged 13 and below.

Social media companies have deep knowledge of how to drive engagement and keep people coming back for more views, says [the] chief executive of Vital Strategies.

“When you combine that with the experience and the knowledge of the tobacco industry on how to hook and keep people hooked ... those two things together in a space that is unknown and opaque – that scares me.”

Mark Zuckerberg, metaverse’s prominent backer, says in future “you’ll be able to do almost anything you can imagine” there. Already, that includes shopping and attending virtual concerts.

But Magsumbol describes it as “a new battleground for all of us” that is “being taken over by corporate entities that actually push health-harming products.”

Adapted from *The Guardian*
July 2025
(439 words)

SOUTH AFRICA DECLARES GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE A NATIONAL DISASTER

Hundreds of women gathered in cities across South Africa on Friday to protest against gender-based violence in the country before the G20 summit in Johannesburg this weekend. Demonstrators turned out in 15 locations – including Johannesburg, Pretoria, Cape Town and Durban – wearing black as a sign of “mourning and resistance”. They staged a peaceful 15-minute silent lie-down protest, symbolising the 15 lives lost daily to gender-based violence in the country. South Africa has one of the world’s highest femicide rates, with UN Women estimating that it is five times higher than the global average.

Called the G20 Women’s Shutdown, it was organised by the NGO Women For Change, which urged women and LGBTQ+ communities to “refrain from all paid and unpaid work in workplaces, universities and homes, and to spend no money for the entire day to demonstrate the economic and social impact of their absence”. “Because until South Africa stops burying a woman every 2.5 hours, the G20 cannot speak of growth and progress.”

The lie-down protest was the culmination of a month-long campaign by the group, lobbying the South African government to declare gender-based violence a national disaster. An online petition garnered more than a million signatures, while many people – including the Grammy-award winning singer Tyla – changed their social media profiles to purple, a colour often associated with women’s rights.

In response to the campaign, the head of the National Disaster Management Centre (NDMC), Dr. Sithole, announced on Friday that it would classify gender-based violence and femicide as a national disaster. The NDMC had previously said that the categorisation did not meet the legal requirements defined in the Disaster Management Act; however, after evaluating “the persistent and immediate life-safety risks posed by ongoing acts of violence”, the centre concluded that it now met the threshold.

The minister of cooperative governance and traditional affairs [...] welcomed the decision, which will allow authorities to dedicate resources and strengthen their support of existing structures to combat gender-based violence. “The women of our country are crying out that they need much more focus on the issue of gender-based violence,” South African president Cyril Ramaphosa said at a G20 sideline summit for civil society on Thursday. During the event he said the government would classify gender-based violence and femicide as a “crisis”.

Women For Change celebrated the announcement on its Instagram account, posting a statement saying “we have won”. “We have written history together. We forced the country to finally confront the truth.” It added that next week it is planning to convene a follow-up meeting to discuss a “detailed action plan and timeline”.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(443 words)

STARBUCKS UNION WORKERS GO ON STRIKE

Starbucks workers at 65 unionised US stores have gone on strike in their latest bid to pressure the coffee chain for better pay and staffing after negotiations stalled.

The union, Starbucks Workers United, is also pushing the company to resolve hundreds of unfair labour practice charges.

Talks for a contract agreement broke down in the spring, and the two sides remain at odds over key economic issues.

Starbucks said the strike on Thursday will affect fewer than 1% of its thousands of shops.

[...] More than 1,000 union baristas in over 40 cities are participating in the unfair labour practice strike, the union said. The action was timed to coincide with Starbucks' Red Cup Day, a major holiday sales event.

The strike could expand to more locations if the two sides fail to reach an agreement, the union said.

[...] The brand has faced consumer boycotts, a wave of new competitors and a customer backlash over high prices, as well as turmoil in its leadership ranks.

The arrival last year of new chief executive, who led successful turnarounds at Chipotle and Taco Bell, raised hopes he could do the same for Starbucks. [...]

Baristas and their union say many of the new turnaround policies, like writing on cups and offering ceramic mugs, have only added to their workload, without an adequate increase in staffing.

Rami Saied, a union barista who has worked at Starbucks for two years, joined a picket line in front of her coffee shop in Brooklyn, New York, on Thursday morning. [...]

A fair contract, she said, would mean Starbucks negotiating over wages, scheduling and staffing.

"To me, the staffing really matters," said Ms Saied. She said she has worked hours-long shifts with just one other employee, resulting in 30-minute delays for drink orders.

"You're just really working back-breaking work. It just leaves you without any dignity," she said.

[...] New policies, like refusing to give water and bathroom access to non-paying customers, have at times fuelled hostility in the workplace, she added. [...]

Even after the two sides agreed to bring in a mediator in January, they remained at odds over pay, staffing and hundreds of unresolved charges of unfair labour practices.

A union spokesperson said Starbucks has offered no pay raises in the first year of a contract, then 2% in the years following, which he said fails to account for inflation and the cost of healthcare. Baristas overwhelmingly voted down the contract offer in April.

The company, on the other hand, blames the union for stalled talks. The union's demands for pay increases would "significantly affect store operations and customer experience", the company's chief partner officer, said in a statement last week

Adapted from *BBC*
November 2025
(452 words)

THE COST OF DONALD TRUMP'S BULLYING

You may think the place where national leaders gather to talk about the state of the world is Washington, or perhaps the UN Headquarters in New York. In fact, as President Xi Jinping showed when he hosted over 20 presidents and prime ministers in China this week, a new reality is taking hold.

Mr. Xi used a summit in Tianjin to advertise China as a source of stability and prosperity. He used a military parade in Beijing, marking the 80th anniversary of the end of the second world war, to remind everyone that China has become a mighty power. The source of trouble today, he suggests, is America.

Mr Xi's claim to lead a global coalition of America-sceptic powers is not as fantastic as you might think. He received autocrats like Vladimir Putin of Russia and Kim Jong Un of North Korea. But he also welcomed leaders of countries that have leant towards the West, including Turkey, Egypt and India.

China's boast to be an anchor of stability has weight. The country is already the largest goods-trading partner of most of this week's visitors, along with another 40-odd states around the world. As the Trump administration pursues a rolling campaign of economic warfare against its trading partners, China's sins of mercantilism and state capitalism look minor by comparison.

There is also a new-found unity opposing sanctions, including the extraterritorial threat America uses to sever individuals, firms and companies from the dollar-based financial system and tech platforms. More and more countries are interested in finding alternatives to the dollar. And fewer will be interested in enforcing America's sanctions on its behalf.

China's guests still have plenty to disagree about. India opposes its military build-up after skirmishes on the Himalayan border. China's neighbours must have watched its new missiles trundle through Tiananmen Square with mixed feelings. Yet among the autocrats, co-operation is deepening. Russia and North Korea are working on space and satellite systems. In return for China's support over Ukraine, Russia is thought to be offering it more of its most sensitive technology, including submarine-propulsion and missile-defence systems.

The weakest part of Mr Xi's campaign is over international institutions and rules. He has just declared that « global governance has reached a new crossroads. » State media propose that China should work with like-minded countries to uphold the UN charter and « build a more just and equitable global governance system. » Despite being cloaked in the language of multilateralism, these are code words for a China-friendly world order in which big powers dominate spheres of influence and enjoy more rights than small ones. Few countries want Asia to be run by China.

Adapted from *The Economist*
September 2025
(446 words)

THE CULTURAL IMPACT OF SCIENCE FICTION

Science fiction has always had a profound impact on popular culture. Indeed, in every era, science fiction films have addressed the social and cultural concerns of the day. In the 1950s, for example, they were often used to reflect on the dangers of nuclear war and totalitarian regimes, while the 1970s and 1980s focused on the isolation of the individual in the face of technologies.

Another major cultural impact of science fiction is the way it has shaped the collective imagination. Concepts such as space travel, artificial intelligence and robots entered popular culture thanks to films like *Star Wars* released in 1977 and *Terminator* released in 1984. These films not only revolutionized the film industry, but also fueled philosophical discussions about the future of humanity.

Science fiction has also had a considerable influence on other forms of media, particularly literature, television and, more recently, video games. [...] It has also been an important tool for education and raising awareness of important issues such as ecology, biotechnology, and artificial intelligence, allowing the public to think about these issues from a different perspective. [...]

One of the main driving forces behind the evolution of science fiction in cinema has been technological progress, particularly in the field of special effects. Advances in 3D modeling and other visual effects have made it possible to create incredibly realistic and immersive worlds. In 1993, the release of Steven Spielberg's *Jurassic Park* marked a turning point in the use of digital special effects.

The 2000s saw a new revolution with the introduction of motion capture and computer-generated imagery - CGI. James Cameron's 2009 *Avatar* is a perfect example of the use of these technologies to create an entire virtual world. [...]

As artificial intelligence and virtual reality have actually developed, they have also influenced the way science fiction is approached in films. For example, Spike Jonze's *Her*, released in 2013, explores the relationship between a human and an artificial intelligence system and shows how technology has become a central character in the story. These films are the fruit of a new generation of directors trained in the use of technology and digital tools.

To conclude, the science fiction genre has evolved dramatically in response to technological, cultural and social changes. From the primitive silent films of Georges Méliès to modern masterpieces such as *Avatar*, science fiction has constantly renewed itself and encouraged viewers to reflect on their place in the universe, the dangers of technology and the ethics of scientific progress. [...] In the years to come, it will surely continue to expand the boundaries of cinematic storytelling and to question our collective future.

Adapted from *Cinecreatis*
December 2024
(453 words)

THE DIVIDENDS OF CONSUMING ARTS

Now it is official: consuming culture is good for your health and wellbeing – and generates £8bn a year worth of improvements in people's quality of life and higher productivity. That is the conclusion of the first major UK research to quantify the impact the arts can have on physical and mental health and the monetary value of the advantages they bring. [...]

Going to an arts event or taking part in a cultural activity, even only occasionally confers an array of significant benefits that can include alleviating pain, frailty, depression and dependence on medication, the government-commissioned review has found. "Engagement with performance-based art such as plays, and particularly participation in music, is linked to reductions in pain and improved quality of life," said the co-author of the research. "We can value those impacts in terms of reduced costs to the NHS, increased productivity at work and improved quality of life." It may even help postpone the onset of dementia. Prof Fancourt, another co-author of the research, said it had shown that "arts engagement has diverse and tangible effects on health, from supporting cognitive development and protecting against cognitive decline, to reducing pain and stress, via the same neurological and physiological pathways activated by medication. [...] Arts engagement can help to reduce unnecessary pressure on health services, through helping individuals to manage their own health more proactively, such as staying physically active and socially engaged, and reducing the need for inpatient hospital and nursing home stays."

The report cites thirteen different groups of people – from the young to the old – whose health and wellbeing improved when they attended or participated in artistic pursuits, evidence showed. For example, over-65s who took drawing classes every week for three months at their local museum created a financial dividend of on average £1,300 each from going to see their GP less and feeling better about their lives. Similarly, a study of 3,000 young adults aged between eighteen and thirty found that those taking part in organised artistic, musical or theatrical activities felt happier and that their lives had more meaning and value as a result. Consuming culture and taking part in creative pursuits such as painting brings individuals' worth an average £1,000 a year. Most of the £8bn benefits to society comes from people's improved quality of life and the rest is from improved productivity at work. The findings suggest that not only could further arts investment be valuable for individuals and the health service as part of a preventative health agenda, but also any cuts to arts funding have to be considered a public health risk with individual and societal economic ramifications.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
December 2024
(455 words)

THE FRENCH SECRET TO HEALTHIER EATING

Just off a bustling street near her apartment in Paris, Mathilde Touvier, one of France's leading nutrition scientists, slips into Picard, the frozen-food grocery chain. She beelines for the back, where freezers brim with bags and boxes of prechopped raw vegetables.

She plucks out a bag of onions. "If you cut all these by yourself," she says, "you would cry. And it takes a lot of time." At home, she regularly melts Picard's onions, along with its frozen garlic and diced parsley, in olive oil for a fast tomato sauce to serve with whole wheat pasta or homemade pizza [...]. Ms. Touvier, a working mother of two, says it's all about "the gain of time."

Before there were MAHA moms and trad wives boasting homemade bread and feta on social media, there was a societal push to get Americans back into the kitchen. Cooking was framed as resistance to corporations peddling ultraprocessed food. [...]. By buying and preparing farm-fresh food, Americans could reclaim their health and repair the food system. Today, Make America Healthy Again leaders have, at least in rhetoric, picked up where that movement left off, railing against ultraprocessed foods and touting "MAHA boxes" of fresh produce to be shipped nationwide.

All of this overlooks a key fact: The burden of food procurement and cooking is still shouldered overwhelmingly by women, most of whom now also work outside the home. Asking people to cook more is usually asking women to cook more. Even in households that want to make every meal from scratch, the hours – planning, buying, cleaning, not to mention the actual cooking – simply aren't there.

Parisians like Ms. Touvier have come to embrace a middle path. As is the case in America, companies in France have been marketing convenience foods to women for decades as liberation from kitchen drudgery. Also as in America, France has been grappling with rising rates of chronic diseases, such as obesity. But in France, federal and local governments acted decisively. [...]

There's no shortage of calorie-dense culinary delights, patisseries and junk food here, including at Picard. But healthy convenience is also prominent. Ms. Touvier, a critic of ultraprocessed foods, says her lab employees are 70 percent women, many of them mothers, and that she views healthier prepared foods as "part of the solution" for busy families. [...]

To really change how people eat, the United States needs to pull every lever it can to dramatically improve the food environment. Healthy foods must be more available, accessible and convenient. With more adults, and especially women, working outside the home, food policy needs to make nutritious meals more appealing and easier to eat. That includes healthier prepared and frozen food, as well as making fresh produce more accessible. [...]

Adapted from *The New York Times*
November 2025
(457 words)

THE FUTURE OF WORK ISN'T REMOTE OR HYBRID - IT'S MICROSHIFTING

[...] The 9-to-5 workday is a relic of the Industrial Revolution, designed for factory floors whose productivity was measured by hours clocked and widgets produced. But knowledge work doesn't operate on an assembly line. Despite this, many companies are doubling down on return-to-office mandates. Owl Labs reports that 63 per cent of employees are now in the office full-time, and among hybrid workers, in-office days are climbing. A phenomenon called "hybrid creep" shows that 34 per cent of hybrid workers now go into the office four days a week, up from 23 per cent in 2023. While companies are pulling workers back into the office, employees are pushing back by refusing to let the clock dictate their productivity. [...]

Microshifting is the practice of breaking up the workday into short, flexible blocks rather than adhering to a continuous eight-hour stretch. Unlike traditional flexible hours, which might allow you to start at 10 a.m. instead of 9 a.m., microshifting gives employees the freedom to work in bursts throughout the day based on when they're most productive or when life demands their attention. A parent might work from 7 to 9 a.m., take a break for school drop-off and errands, return for a few hours in the afternoon, then log back on after bedtime to wrap up. In industries like hospitality and food service, this often means shifts of six hours or less. For knowledge workers, it's about autonomy over their schedule rather than simply where they sit. [...]

Employees aren't just asking for microshifting. They're willing to pay for it. Owl Labs found that employees would sacrifice 9 per cent of their annual salary for flexible working hours and 8 per cent for a 4-day work week. Flexibility has become as valuable as compensation, and for good reason. [...]

With 62 per cent of surveyed employees caring for children at home, the rigid 9-to-5 doesn't accommodate modern life. Parents have long practiced what's known as the "second shift," stepping away for school pickup, dinner and bedtime routines, then logging back on after the kids are asleep. But now, 68 per cent of parents worry that caregiving responsibilities might hurt their job performance. That anxiety is even higher among full-time in-office employees [...] compared to remote workers [...]. Microshifting offers a way to manage both without the guilt or the performance hit. [...]

And it's not just parents pushing for change. One in five employees is poly-employed, juggling side hustles alongside their main job. With 50 per cent of employees scheduling personal appointments during traditional working hours, the boundaries of the workday have already blurred. Shorter, more flexible shifts aren't just convenient. They're essential.

Adapted from *Forbes*
October 2025
(459 words)

THE GAME THEORY OF HOW ALGORITHMS CAN DRIVE UP PRICES

Imagine a town with two widget merchants. Customers prefer cheaper widgets, so the merchants must compete to set the lowest price. Unhappy with their meager profits, they meet one night in a smoke-filled tavern to discuss a secret plan: If they raise prices together instead of competing, they can both make more money. But that kind of intentional price-fixing, called collusion, has long been illegal. The widget merchants decide not to risk it, and everyone else gets to enjoy cheap widgets.

For well over a century, U.S. law has followed this basic template: Ban those backroom deals, and fair prices should be maintained. These days, it's not so simple. Across broad swaths of the economy, sellers increasingly rely on computer programs called learning algorithms, which repeatedly adjust prices in response to new data about the state of the market. These are often much simpler than the "deep learning" algorithms that power modern artificial intelligence, but they can still be prone to unexpected behavior.

So how can regulators ensure that algorithms set fair prices? Their traditional approach won't work, as it relies on finding explicit collusion. "The algorithms definitely are not having drinks with each other," said Aaron Roth, a computer scientist at the University of Pennsylvania.

Yet a widely cited 2019 paper showed that algorithms could learn to collude tacitly, even when they weren't programmed to do so. A team of researchers pitted two copies of a simple learning algorithm against each other in a simulated market, then let them explore different strategies for increasing their profits. Over time, each algorithm learned through trial and error to retaliate when the other cut prices — dropping its own price by some huge, disproportionate amount. The end result was high prices, backed up by mutual threat of a price war. [...]

A recent paper studies algorithmic pricing through the lens of game theory, an interdisciplinary field at the border of economics and computer science that analyzes the mathematics of strategic competitions. It's one way to explore the failures of pricing algorithms in a controlled setting.

"What we're trying to do is create collusion in the lab," said Joseph Harrington, a University of Pennsylvania economist who wrote an influential review paper on regulating algorithmic collusion and was not involved in the new research. "Once we do so, we want to figure out how to destroy collusion." [...]

Researchers have devised learning algorithms called "no-swap-regret" algorithms. These guarantee that whatever your opponent did, you couldn't have done better by swapping all instances of any move with any other move [...] The results implied that dueling no-swap-regret algorithms would always end up with competitive prices when they reached equilibrium. Collusion was impossible.

Adapted from *Quanta Magazine*
October 2025
(454 words)

THE HAPPINESS HACK ESPECIALLY FOR TIMES OF CHAOS AND ANXIOUSNESS

There's a simple hack to create happiness in your life, especially for times of chaos and anxiousness, and it starts with what you do in other people's lives.

In January, Americans feeling "very satisfied" with their personal lives hit a new 24-year low. According to a Gallup poll that was released at the time, 44 percent of Americans said they are "very satisfied" with the way things are going in their personal lives.

"After several challenging years that encompassed the Covid-19 pandemic and persistently high prices, Americans' extreme satisfaction with their personal life has fallen to the lowest level in a quarter century," Gallup wrote in an analysis. "Political discontent appears to have further depressed satisfaction, especially for Republicans."

So what can we do in these trying times? One psychologist turned to Gen Z, who are usually considered to be those born between 1997 and 2012, for the answer.

There's a simple hack to create happiness in your life, especially for times of chaos and anxiousness, and it starts with what you do in other people's lives.

Psychologist Anthony Burrow and researchers from Cornell University [...] have run a six-year project asking the question, "If someone gave you \$400 to make a difference in your community, what would you do with it?" Over the years, Burrow and his team have selected more than 1,000 high school and college students to receive \$400 and use it to add value to themselves and their communities through The Contribution Project.

The preliminary results of the project [...] show that at the start of the experiment, those who received the funds and those who didn't scored the same on psychological measures, including latent well-being, sense of purpose, sense of belonging, sense of feeling needed and useful, and affective balance, which is the balance between positive and negative emotions.

But eight weeks later, the time frame recipients have to make their contributions, those who received the funds scored significantly higher than the others.

Recipients used the funds to pay for hundreds of loads of laundry for community members, donate books to their former high school, plant a tree on campus and create a mental health resource website.

"I think a lot of people in my generation are like me," one recipient was quoted. "Inherently, everyone wants to love and be loved. And I think that that comes out so often."

"Invite people to think about a contribution they want to make and help them [to] make that contribution, and that person may walk around with greater purpose than if they hadn't done that," Burrow said [...].

Adapted from *The Independent*
October 2025
(450 words)

THE HIDDEN COST OF ULTRA-PROCESSED FOODS ON THE ENVIRONMENT

If you look at a package of M&Ms, one of the most popular candies in the US, you'll see some familiar ingredients: sugar, skimmed milk powder, cocoa butter. But you'll see many more that aren't so recognizable: gum arabic, dextrin, carnauba wax, soya lecithin and E100.

There are 34 ingredients in M&Ms, and, according to Mars, the company that produces the candy, at least 30 countries – from Ivory Coast to New Zealand – are involved in supplying them. Each has its own supply chain that transforms the raw materials into ingredients – cocoa into cocoa liquor, cane into sugar, petroleum into blue food dye.

These ingredients then travel across the world to a central processing facility where they are combined and transformed into tiny blue, red, yellow and green chocolate gems.

It's becoming better understood that food systems are a major driver of the climate crisis. Scientists can examine deforestation for agriculture, or the methane emissions from livestock. But the environmental impact of ultra-processed foods – like M&Ms – is less clear and is only now starting to come into focus. One reason they have been so difficult to assess is the very nature of UPFs: these industrially made foods include a huge number of ingredients and processes to put them together, making it nearly impossible to track.

But it doesn't mean it's not important. As UPFs take over US grocery store shelves and diets – they now comprise 70% of food sold in grocery stores, and more than half of calories consumed – experts say that understanding their environmental toll is critical to build a more climate-friendly food system. [...]

While ultra-processed chocolate products are some of the worst offenders, other kinds of UPFs are taxing on the environment as well. Take for instance Doritos, which have 39 ingredients. Corn is the main ingredient, and for every acre grown, 1,000kg of carbon dioxide is emitted to the atmosphere. Like Mars, Pepsico, which makes Doritos, has developed its own sustainability promises, but many of these promises are underpinned by practices that are considered greenwashing, like "regenerative agriculture". [...]

As a result, some experts have started to calculate the environmental toll of UPFs.

CarbonCloud, a Sweden-based software company that calculates the emissions of food products, analyzed carbon disclosures from Mars, and estimated that M&Ms generate at least 13.2kg of carbon equivalents per kilogram of M&Ms produced. Mars produces more than 664m kg of M&Ms in the US each year, which would mean that if CarbonCloud's calculations are accurate, the candies emit at least 3.8m tons of carbon dioxide – making up 0.1% of annual emissions in the US.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(459 words)

THE NEW TOURIST FINES SWEEPING EUROPE

This summer, Europe is cracking down on unruly holidaymakers. From wearing flip flops while driving to smoking on beaches, a new wave of tourist fines is sweeping the continent. In Portugal's popular seaside town of Albufeira, wearing swimwear off the beach could cost you up to €1,500. In Spain's Balearic Islands [...] public drinking fines can reach €3,000. Even small infractions, like reserving a sunbed and disappearing, could put a dent in your holiday budget.

At first glance, these measures might seem like biting the hand that feeds, since many of these destinations earn a significant amount of money from tourism. But authorities say the rules are aimed at protecting residents – and responsible holidaymakers.

"The rules, while they might sound rigid and punitive when listed out, are all about encouraging responsible and empathetic travelling," said Jessica Harvey Taylor, Head of Press at the Spanish Tourism Office in London. "They are designed to protect the holiday experiences of the vast majority of people who behave responsibly on holiday." [...]

While codes of conduct are common in environmentally fragile areas or culturally sensitive areas [...] their arrival in mainstream beach resorts signals a shift. Bad tourism behaviour has gone too far and authorities are trying to protect towns and residents from mass tourism's worst excesses.

"We must act with two main ideas in mind: the protection and preservation of the environment; and ensuring that tourism is in harmony with our society," said [the] mayor of Calvià, Mallorca, in a speech earlier this year. "Tourism cannot be a burden on citizens." [...]

"Locals are fed up," said a responsible tourism advocate. "These fines are signals that communities want to reclaim space. It's not that tourists are worse – it's more that the tolerance has gone. And it's important to consider that not every fine is a crackdown: some are calls for respect."

Anti-tourism and overtourism protests have been growing in Europe for years. While small measures [...] have come into play, these new fines are taking it further. [...]

It's too soon to say if the new fines are working. Robert Allard, who runs Go2algarve, a specialist travel firm serving the Algarve, has noticed new surveillance cameras and an increased police presence in Albufeira's nightlife areas. "Some people have been fined," he said, "but at the same time, people are not really aware of the new rules, even though leaflets are available in hotel lobbies and posters are visible."

Behaviour change campaigns take time to work, and one season won't transform visitor habits. But the message is clear: sun, sand and sea are still on offer, but only to those who agree to enjoy them sensibly, sensitively and a little soberly.

Adapted from *BBC News*
August 2025
(454 words)

THE ONE CHANGE THAT WORKED: I SOBERED UP – AND STARTED TO LISTEN TO MY BODY

Most of my adult life has revolved around music clubs, bars, festivals, house parties – anywhere I could dance to loud music. I loved how energising and cathartic it was to get immersed in it, to lose myself a little and move my body expressively without judgement. I'd get so absorbed that I would lose track of time: once, at Burning Man, I was awake for 36 hours exploring the festival, meeting new people and partying.

When I became a DJ, these kinds of events increased. Late nights out would last until the morning. Often, they became marathon weekend sessions, which ran from Friday night to Sunday lunchtime. It wasn't all dancing and shenanigans – there would be moments to sit around and chat with people, too. I'd be out at least three times a week. Even though I'd get tired, I would always find some way to push through to the early hours because I was scared to miss out on things. FOMO (fear of missing out) drove many of my decisions.

My work never suffered but my mental health did. I started to feel anxious and dangerously close to burnout. Consumed with self-loathing, I wanted to stop but couldn't figure out how – until I went on a 10-day silent meditation course.

It was then that I realised the life I was living was unsustainable. But it took a while to unravel my hedonism and habitual indulgence. I went sober because I wanted to rid myself of the brain fog and fatigue I was often bogged down with.

Learning to navigate nights out without a crutch to keep me going sparked an important shift in my approach to parties and festivals. Instead of giving in to FOMO, I have learned to listen to what my body is telling me rather than ignoring the signs. Tired legs usually spark a well-earned sit down or, in some cases, I will call it a night and get myself home to bed. This kind of behaviour was unheard of between the ages of 17 and 37, when I had my last drink. Back then, I would keep going even when I was exhausted.

It hasn't been easy, though. Being sober is hard work. Not having an easy escape can be very challenging. I had to learn how to be more confident and expressive without ingesting anything. Dancing while sober is still fun but it's tricky dealing with how self-conscious you feel.

Responding to my body's needs consciously and waving goodbye to FOMO have given me a real sense of stability.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
September 2025
(443 words)

THE RISE OF SINGLEHOOD IS RESHAPING THE WORLD

For most of human history, coupling up was not merely a norm; it was a necessity. Before reliable contraception, women could not control their fertility, and most were far too poor to raise children alone. Hence the centuries-old convention that, whereas a tragic play or saga ends in death, a happy one ends in marriage.

So the speed with which the norm of marriage – indeed, of relationships of any sort – is being abandoned is startling. Throughout the rich world, singlehood is on the rise. Among Americans aged 25-34, the proportion living without a spouse or partner has doubled in five decades, to 50% for men and 41% for women. Since 2010, the share of people living alone has risen in 26 out of 30 rich countries. A great relationship recession is under way.

For some, this is evidence of social and moral decay. Many in the “pro-natalist” movement believe that the failure of the young to settle down and procreate threatens to end Western civilisation. For others, it is evidence of admirable self-reliance.

In fact, the rise of singlehood is neither straightforwardly good nor bad. Among heterosexuals [...] it is largely a consequence of something clearly benign: as barriers to women in the workplace have fallen, their choices have expanded. They are far more able than in the past to live alone if they choose, and face less social stigma for doing so. The more they can support themselves financially, the less likely they are to put up with an inadequate or abusive partner. This shift has saved countless women from awful relationships, and forced many men to treat their mates better if they want to stay together.

However, it has also had unhappy knock-on effects. Flying solo can be liberating, but it can also be lonely. Plenty of singletons say they are content to remain so, especially women. But surveys in various countries suggest that 60-73% would rather be in a relationship.

Some think social media and dating apps have fostered unrealistic expectations [...] and excessive pickiness (most women on Bumble reportedly insist that a male must be six feet tall, thus filtering out 85% of potential matches). Another problem is the growing political gulf between young men and women, with the former leaning right and the latter leaning more to the left. Many singles insist that any partner must tick the same partisan boxes, which makes matching trickier. [...]

Other experts point to a decline in social skills as people spend more of their lives gawping at screens. [...]

A future with far more singletons is coming. Everyone, from construction firms to the taxman, had better prepare.

Adapted from *The Economist*
November 2025
(456 words)

THE TRASH VORTEX

You could save a turtle's life by using less plastic and making sure your garbage is properly managed. In the North Pacific is a 20 million square kilometer area of floating plastic rubbish rotating clockwise that chokes and traps millions of fish and animals.

Take a walk along almost any beach anywhere in the world and washed ashore will certainly be many plastic bags and bottles, drums of expanded polystyrene packing, pieces of polypropylene fishing net, discarded lengths of rope together with disposable lighters, tyres and even toothbrushes... This plastic trash has been casually thrown away on land or at sea and has been carried ashore by wind and tide.

Its durability, which makes plastic so heavily used domestically and commercially also makes it a major problem for our oceans, and will continue to do so for generations. Around 100 million tonnes of plastic are produced each year, of which about 10 million tonnes ends in the sea.

The larger items are the visible signs of a much bigger problem. At sea and on shore under the influence of sunlight, wave action and mechanical abrasion, these larger items slowly break up into smaller pieces. But plastic doesn't break down like natural materials – it doesn't go away and disappear, it just goes from being a floating bottle to tiny plastic particles that are easily eaten by fish and other marine species. A single one-litre bottle could break down into enough small fragments to put one on every mile of beach in the entire world. [...]

The North Pacific sub-tropical trash vortex often referred to as the Great Pacific Garbage Patch, [...] which covers an area equivalent in size to Texas, Turkey, or Afghanistan, contains astounding quantities of wastes – estimated at six kilos of plastic for every kilo of plankton.

Some of the larger items are consumed by seabirds and other animals, which mistake them for prey. Many seabirds and their chicks have been found dead, their stomachs filled with bottle tops, lighters and balloons.

A turtle found dead in Hawaii had over a thousand pieces of plastic in its stomach and intestines. It has been estimated that over a million seabirds and one hundred thousand marine mammals and sea turtles are killed each year by either eating or getting tangled in discarded netting, fishing lines and other bits of plastic.

Plastics can also act as a "chemical sponge", concentrating many of the most damaging pollutants such as POPs, which are persistent organic pollutants.

Bits of floating plastic can also provide easy transport for plants and animals to move into oceans beyond their normal habitat which often causes major problems by disturbing the natural balance of the ecosystem. [...]

Adapted from *Greenpeace*
November 2023
(449 words)

TOO SMALL TO MATTER

Thankfully, it's rare to encounter outright climate denial in public these days. But it is still common to hear justifications for delaying action.

One of the most pernicious and intellectually lazy arguments is the familiar nugget – that “Ireland's emissions are too small to matter”. It's a line still advanced by some politicians and business leaders. [...] This argument [...] defies basic common sense.

Climate change isn't a pass/fail exam, where we have lost if we cross a threshold. It's a cumulative problem: every tonne of carbon dioxide we emit adds to the blanket of heat-trapping gases around the planet, doing permanent and measurable harm. [...]

Mathematically speaking, climate change results from the cumulative choices of billions of people, so every source looks small if you zoom in close enough. [...]

But the logical outcome of this reasoning is that nothing and no one is responsible. [...] No country's emissions alone “matter”, not even China's. If China abandoned all fossil fuel use tomorrow, the world would still warm beyond 1.5 degrees within a few years unless others followed.

This is the essence of what is known as a collective-action problem. In these cases, everyone benefits if everyone takes action, but actors alone cannot benefit from their individual efforts, [...]. These problems can only be solved through co-operation.

That is precisely what international legal and diplomatic efforts on climate action are designed to achieve. The Paris Agreement is built on this principle – all countries must pursue their “highest possible ambition” in a collective effort to limit warming.

Practically speaking, limiting global warming simply can't be achieved without efforts from small countries. More than one-third of global emissions come from countries which individually emit less than 2 per cent of the global total. [...]

If we, with all these advantages and disproportionate responsibility, claim we're too small to matter, what message does that send to poorer or more vulnerable countries whose emissions truly are tiny and whose fates depend on global action? [...]

It's correct that cutting Ireland's emissions will not, on its own, protect Ireland from climate impacts. But by this logic, should I not evade paying taxes, because these are a tiny drop in the ocean of public finances?

Should I eat a doughnut for supper, given its irrelevance in the context of everything I eat over a lifetime? Of course not! Outcomes are determined by the collective of many small actions. Ireland's role will never be to single-handedly cool the planet, but to be part of the collective effort to turn the ship around.

So why, when no one would publicly advocate tax evasion, is the “too small to matter” argument so frequently advanced by serious-sounding people? Because it offers a comforting excuse for evading uncomfortable truths. [...]

Adapted from *The Irish Times*
December 2025
(457 words)

TRUMP'S AI POOP POST CAPS A WEEK OF MAGA INDIFFERENCE

An estimated 7 million Americans turned out Saturday to peacefully protest against the breakdown of our checks-and-balances democracy into a Trump-driven autocracy, rife with grift but light on civil rights.

Trump's response? An AI video of himself wearing a crown inside a fighter plane, dumping what appears to be excrements on these very protesters. In a later interview, he called participants of the "No Kings" events "whacked out" and "not representative of this country."

I'm beginning to fear he's right. What if the majority of Americans really do believe this sort of behavior by our president, or by anyone really, is acceptable? Even funny? A recent Economist/YouGov poll found that 81 percent of Republicans approve of his way of handling the situation. Seriously, the vast majority of Republicans are just fine with Trump's policies and behavior.

According to MAGA, non-MAGA people are just too uptight these days.

Vice Troll JD Vance has become a relentless force for not just defending the most base and cruel of behaviors, but celebrating them. House Speaker Mike Johnson has made the spineless, limp justification of these behaviors an art form.

Between the two approaches to groveling to Trump's ego and mendacity is everything you need to know about the future of the Republican Party. It will stop at nothing to debase and dehumanize any opposition – openly acknowledging that it dreams of burying in excrement. [...]

Not to be outdone, Johnson responded to the poop jet video by somehow insinuating there is an elevated meaning to it.

"The president was using social media to make a point," Johnson said, calling it "satire."

Satire is meant to embarrass and humiliate, to call out through humor the indefensible. I'll buy the first part of that. Trump meant to embarrass and humiliate. But protesting, of course, is anything but indefensible and the use of feces as a weapon is a way of degrading those "No Kings" participants so that Trump doesn't have to answer to their anger – no different than degrading Black people and women in that group chat.

Those 7 million Americans who demonstrated on Saturday simply do not matter to Trump, or to Republicans. Not their healthcare, not their ability to pay the bills, not their worry that a country they love is turning in to one where their leader literally illustrates that he can defecate on them.

But not everyone can be king. [...] Maybe 7 million Americans angry at Trump can't convince him to change his ways, but [...] the one thing Trump does fear is the midterms, when voters get to shape our own little corners of America – and by extension, whether Trump gets to keep using his throne.

Adapted from *Los Angeles Times*
October 2025
(454 words)

TRUMP'S WAR ON SCIENCE LEAVES US PUBLIC HEALTH EXPERTS REELING: 'THERE WILL BE LASTING DAMAGE'

Donald Trump's second presidency has spelled upheaval or worse for multiple spheres of US government. But for science – long a key driver of the US's global pre-eminence – it has heralded the perfect storm.

In public health, climate science, environmental protection and nuclear safety, seasoned career specialists have been left bewildered and often jobless under a ferocious onslaught from the president, apparently aimed at gaining control over a sector about which he has displayed strongly held views, if frequently flawed understanding.

Now, experts warn, the US faces a loss of scientific expertise that could take decades to restore in a purge that has seen thousands of government scientists fired and billions of dollars slashed from research programs. Some observers compare Trump's offensive to authoritarian regimes such as Hungary and Russia under Vladimir Putin. "The Trump administration is trying to undermine the scientific method as a basis of making determinations," said Paul Josephson, professor at Colby College. "It is designating which kinds of science are good and which are inappropriate." [...]

The administration captured headlines when the White House fired Susan Monarez, director of the CDC, after she clashed with health secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. over vaccine policy. Kennedy defended his purge of public health agencies and his anti-vaccine stance before the Senate.

The Union of Concerned Scientists documented 402 incidents it defined as "attacks on science" since Trump's inauguration, including firing or censoring scientists and halting data collection. Trump issued an executive order titled "restoring gold standard science," claiming that "confidence that scientists act in the best interests of the public has fallen."

Jennifer Jones, director of the Center for Science and Democracy, said US science was under an "unprecedented assault." "They're sidelining science," she said. "At the same time, they're uplifting junk science and quackery." Among the most affected areas are:

Public health: The Department of Health and Human Services shed nearly a quarter of its staff. Kennedy cancelled major vaccine research funding, halted gain-of-function studies, and limited access to Covid shots, moves denounced by medical associations. [...]

Climate: About 800 NOAA researchers were fired, climate assessments suspended, and budgets for climate programs cut by billions. The Pentagon stopped providing weather data, citing "cybersecurity concerns."

Environmental protection: The EPA moved to rescind the "endangerment finding" on greenhouse gases, dismantled its research office, cut 3,700 jobs, and ended mandatory carbon reporting.

Nuclear safety: The Nuclear Regulatory Commission has lost nearly 200 staff, creating a "brain drain" of expertise that former officials warn could raise the risk of future accidents.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
September 2025
(440 words)

TRUMP'S CRACKDOWN ON CHINESE STUDENTS

President Trump wants to stop Chinese students from enrolling in strategic technology fields at top U.S. colleges and universities. At the heart of this push lies the fear that the United States could fall behind in the science and tech race with China. This logic overlooks a startling new reality: China is already surpassing the United States in science and technology research. Chinese students no longer need to go to America for world-class research experience in the fields that will shape our future. Barring China's best minds from American campuses will only drive more of them into a Chinese academic research system increasingly integrated with the country's defense sector and geared toward building national power. Data suggests that U.S. universities trail their Chinese counterparts in cutting-edge research in dozens of emerging technologies. When it came to ranking universities around the world in 64 critical technologies, the findings were striking. China came first in 57 of those fields. In most of them, Chinese schools don't just take the top slot; they dominate the Top Ten.

But high-tech research performance often leads to industrial dominance. Beijing is also building a national innovation system – linking academia, industry and defense – designed to bolster China's military and technological strength. This expanding ecosystem and the professional opportunities it affords incentivizes students to study in China, fast-tracking them into careers in strategic industries. It also keeps the country's best and brightest cocooned within a politically secure domestic system, minimizing their exposure to notions of liberal democracy and human rights. [...]

In the past, no other country could compete with America's top universities – a potent source of soft power that helped reinforce core U.S. values such as freedom of academic inquiry and overall national prestige. Now, China is challenging the American policymakers' notion that access to the country's higher education system is a generous benefit bestowed upon the rest of the world. Its universities are already luring more foreign scientists and students, many of whom are drawn by research opportunities or repelled by Mr. Trump's policies and stratospheric U.S. tuition fees. [...] We may soon face a world in which U.S. universities must compete fiercely for top global academic talent. Price-conscious American science and technology students might even begin to put Chinese schools – many of which offer English-language programs at affordable costs — on the radar when college application season rolls around.

All of this puts China in a position to claim leadership in a defining sphere of human achievement: science itself. Cutting off promising Chinese students from studying in the United States will only hasten this trajectory, weakening American competitiveness and national security by funneling more of China's best talent into President Xi Jinping's superpower-building project.

Adapted from *The New York Times*
October 2025
(451 words)

U.S. TO PRESS EUROPE AND OTHER ALLIES ON ‘MASS MIGRATION,’ DOCUMENT SAYS

Secretary of State Marco Rubio has ordered American diplomats in Europe and in Canada, Australia and New Zealand to press their host governments to restrict most immigration and to file reports if the governments appear to be overly supportive of immigrants, according to a document sent to U.S. embassies and consulates.

Mr. Rubio told the diplomats to emphasize the effects of criminal acts by immigrants to encourage greater entry restrictions, according to the document, which is a diplomatic cable dated November 21. The text of the cable, which was obtained by The New York Times, has not been previously reported.

Diplomats should “regularly engage host governments and their respective authorities to raise U.S. concerns about violent crimes associated with people of a migration background” and “any related human rights abuses,” the cable said. It said that those episodes were “widespread disruptors of social cohesion and public safety.”

The diplomats should send reports on crime linked to immigrants to State Department headquarters along with analysis of how host governments handle the issues, including “policies that unduly favor migrants at the expense of local populations.”

The goal of these actions is to build “host government [...] support to address and reform policies related to migrant crime, defending national sovereignty, and ensuring the safety of local communities,” the cable said. The Trump administration often uses the term “sovereignty” to describe its efforts to get other countries to allow in fewer foreigners and harden their borders — even as it tries to impose policies on sovereign nations.

President Trump, his top aides and many of their supporters have talked about large numbers of migrants and immigrants as a scourge in the United States and Europe. They are determined to get governments to take draconian measures to limit immigration and increase deportations, even though statistics show that irregular border crossings in Europe have been dropping for many months and were decreasing in the United States late in the Biden administration.

In a speech at the United Nations in September, Mr. Trump denounced the “globalist migration agenda.” [...] Vice President JD Vance has been equally vocal. “We cannot rebuild Western civilization, we cannot rebuild the United States of America or Europe, by letting millions and millions of unvetted illegal migrants come into our country,” Mr. Vance said in February. [...]

Mr. Rubio, the son of Cuban immigrants, shifted his views on immigration policy during his [...] years as a Republican senator from Florida, and [...] now pushes the State Department to help enforce the Trump administration’s hardline positions.

The State Department said in an official statement on social media last week that “mass migration poses an existential threat to Western civilization and undermines the stability of key American allies.”

Adapted from *The New York Times*
November 2025
(460 words)

UK CAN CREATE 5,400 JOBS IF IT STOPS PLASTIC WASTE EXPORTS

The UK could end its reliance on exporting plastic waste by 2030 to support the creation of 5,400 new jobs and take responsibility for the environmental impact of its waste. Indeed, according to a report, up to 15 new recycling facilities could be built by the end of the decade. The increase in capacity would help generate almost £900 million of economic value every year, providing at least £100 million in new tax revenues annually. Besides, exporting plastic creates environmental problems for many countries that receive it, as they do not have the ability to recycle it. It also removes valuable feedstock for a British recycling industry.

Campaigners want the closure of the loophole that makes it cheaper to export plastic waste rather than recycle it in the UK. Exports to Indonesia have soared in the first part of this year, [...] and, by exporting the unprocessed plastic waste it produces, the UK is not only evading its environmental responsibility but is also denying itself an economic opportunity since it is only using half of its potential for recycling plastic waste. Indeed, 21 existing plastic recycling and processing factories across the UK have been shut down in the last decade owing to the cheap price of virgin plastic and an influx of cheap plastic products from Asia.

“Ending exports of unprocessed plastic packaging waste by 2030 would allow the UK to take control of its environmental responsibilities and seize a clear economic opportunity,” said Neville Hill, a partner at Hybrid Economics, the organization which produced the report. “Our analysis shows that the sector can expand significantly with no call on public funds, provided government sets the right framework.” Indeed, the way payments are made up today incentivises the export of plastic waste, rather than encouraging businesses to keep it in the UK to be recycled.

However, James McLeary, the managing director of Biffa Polymers, the company which commissioned the report, said they had recycled 10 billion plastic milk bottles in the last 20 years. He described this as a circular economy success story. “The lesson is simple,” he said. “When the right conditions are in place, UK recycling grows, investment follows and the environmental and economic benefits build year after year. The UK can replicate that success across all plastic packaging.”

The report is finally calling for a 50% increase in the plastic packaging tax which is imposed on producers who fail to include at least 30% of recycled plastic in their products and for a total phasing out of exports of unprocessed plastic packaging waste.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(451 words)

UK PARTY LEADERS URGED TO END 'PERNICIOUS CURRENTS' OF HATRED FUELLING ANTI-MIGRANT PROTESTS

More than 200 refugee organisations, charities and trade unions have signed an open letter calling on Britain's political leaders to end "pernicious and insidious currents" of racism and hatred that underpin a slew of anti-migrant protests. [...]

It was drafted in response to weeks of protests outside asylum seeker hotels in locations across the country, often countered by anti-racism activists.

The protests have come against a backdrop of inflammatory language or misinformation from senior politicians including the Reform UK leader, Nigel Farage, and the senior Conservative Robert Jenrick. In June, the prime minister, Keir Starmer, said he regretted a speech warning that Britain could become an "island of strangers".

This weekend, Jenrick prompted anger by claiming mass migration was putting at risk women and girls. He repeated the claim that 40% of sexual assaults committed in London last year were carried out by foreign nationals – one of several assertions about immigration that have been disputed or debunked in recent days.

On Monday, Reform UK claimed migrants from Muslim countries posed a threat to women's safety in Britain, [and] asylum seekers arriving on small boats held "medieval views".

The charities' open letter, sent to the main UK party leaders on Monday, says: "Anti-refugee protests across the country have been distressing to witness, with echoes of last summer's riots making them all the more alarming.

"The pernicious and insidious currents of racism and hatred underlying these protests are glaring evidence of a failing system. The responsibility to end the divisive politics, racist rhetoric and demonising language of the past is yours. Only then will you bring unity instead of division and cohesion rather than hate."

The letter concludes: "For those who need our compassion to be confronted with further torment here in the UK is shocking. But the outpouring of support from communities condemning the hatred is a powerful reminder that these views do not represent the vast majority. Today we stand in solidarity with those targeted, because this is what represents our country, this is who we are."

The chief executive at Freedom from Torture, said: "No matter who we are or where we come from, we all have the right to feel safe. We know from our clinical work that many men, women and children in these hotels came here seeking protection after being tortured in countries like Afghanistan and Iran." [...]

In Bristol on Saturday, estimates suggest the protesters were outnumbered by eight to one, with about 50 in the anti-refugee group compared with about 400 people standing in solidarity with refugees.

Together With Refugees is calling for a plan that upholds the UK's commitment under international law [...].

Adapted from *The Guardian*
August 2025
(453 words)

UNIONS FROM 36 COUNTRIES PROTEST TREATMENT OF MIGRANT WORKERS IN SAUDI ARABIA

Trade unions from 36 countries have filed a complaint with the International Labour Organisation over the treatment of migrant workers in Saudi Arabia.

The complaint calls for a “commission of inquiry” into labour rights in the country, one of the most powerful tools available to the ILO, a United Nations agency. The demand comes amid growing concern that not enough is being done to improve the conditions of workers as development begins to scale up before the Fifa World Cup, due to take place in the Gulf state in 2034.

The general secretary of the International Trade Union Confederation said the “scale and severity” of the issues in Saudi Arabia demanded the strongest response. “This is a call for immediate action towards genuine, inclusive and collaborative reform,” he said. “We cannot tolerate another death of a migrant worker in Saudi Arabia. We cannot remain silent while migrant workers, especially construction and domestic workers continue to face fundamental rights violations.” [...]

Human rights groups and trade unions have repeatedly warned that the World Cup, and other major projects, could be tarnished by abusive conditions endured by migrant workers in constructing the necessary infrastructure. These concerns include extortionate recruitment fees, non-payment of wages, false contracts, passport confiscation and exposure to extreme heat. Thousands of workers could be likely to die as construction ramps up, the rights group FairSquare has claimed.

The number of migrant workers in Saudi Arabia has surged in recent years to more than 13 million, driven in part by a massive construction boom linked to the World Cup [...].

Saudi Arabia’s agreement with the ILO is understood to include proposals for new measures to support fair recruitment and make it easier for workers to change jobs, the introduction of a minimum wage and the inclusion of migrant workers on workers’ representative committees. Trade unions remain prohibited in the country.

The agreement also sets out commitments to improve the compensation system for workers who are injured or killed. In the longer term, it promises to strengthen protections for domestic workers, who have been excluded from key provisions of the labour law.

The planned reforms have failed to satisfy trade union delegates. [...]
Fifa says the human rights policy submitted as part of Saudi Arabia’s bid for the World Cup commits the country to embedding ILO standards as part of the 2034 process. In a letter to Human Rights Watch in April, the secretary general of Fifa wrote that “the work to implement the measures outlined in the bid strategy has started and is a priority for Fifa”. The trade union complaint is understood to acknowledge that this dialogue has begun. [...]

Adapted from *The Guardian*
June 2025
(455 words)

‘WASTE IS A RESOURCE, NOT A NUISANCE’

It's a rare household that does not have a rusting tin of paint sitting around in a dark cupboard somewhere. About 55m litres of paint go to waste in the UK every year, which is why one organisation is trying to create a circular paint economy by recycling it.

Community RePaint is a UK-wide paint reuse network that collects leftover paint from drop-off points and redistributes it to individuals and groups in the community. They started in 1992 as a research project in Leeds called the Waste Wagon [...]. The goal was to find out how many homes had paint to dispose of, and how much.

Researchers went out to knock on doors, and according to David Squire, Community RePaint's community network coordinator, they found that "on average, 17 tins of paint were sitting there unused". So they decided they would collect it. A year later, the pilot project for Community RePaint was set up, and three decades later, 100 people staff the UK-wide network.

Growth is gentle, but now "businesses have started to reuse paint in the community", says Squire. [...]

One by one, barriers are being broken down. For example, many local councils do not accept liquid paint for recycling because it is considered hazardous. Although this is done, in principle, to protect the environment, it actually increases the likelihood of people leaving their leftover paint to waste. Community RePaint wants councils to see accepting paint as a "win-win" situation. "We're trying to change more councils to accept surplus paint: it saves council money as reuse is far cheaper than disposal."

For the past decade, Community RePaint have sold their own brand, ReColour, which is made up of 97% recycled paint, made by separating the collected paint and remixing it. [...]

They sell to schools, gardeners and community-led projects in particular. [...]

They've also been behind some distinctive street art, working closely with the street artist AlecLDN (real name Alec Saunders) to make the longest eco-mural in the UK, using their preloved paint. [...]

It feels, [Squire] thinks, like an idea that should be catching on. "People know places to get secondhand clothes, like Depop and Vinted, but they don't really think of that for paint." Reuse and recycling is slowly becoming mainstream, but it is still slow to take hold. "The government has struggled to produce a 'bottle return' scheme, which has been on the agenda for 10 years. We have to rethink waste as a resource, rather than a nuisance or something to get rid of."

To Squire, a circular economy is the key – an economic model in which resources and products are continuously reused, repaired and recycled.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
September 2025
(451 words)

WE CAN STOP ANIMAL TESTING

Science is a slaughterhouse. We rarely acknowledge the degree to which animal life underwrites the research that provides us with medicines. Live animals were used in 2.64 million officially sanctioned scientific procedures in the UK in 2024, many of them distressing or painful and many of them fatal. But the government's new strategy to phase out animal testing suggests that in the near future emerging technologies can largely replace the use of animals in our scientific endeavours.

The UK previously banned cosmetics testing on animals, and has already taken steps to reduce their use in research. But some needlessly cruel experiments still take place such as the forced swim test (FST) in which a rodent is placed in a body of water it cannot escape and researchers measure whether antidepressants extend the time it struggles for life. The government says no new FST licences will be granted, which means banning it. Similar targets are set over the next few years to end the testing of caustic chemicals on eyes and skin.

This is welcome, but there are many other widespread practices – such as giving mice tumours to research cancer – which most people would still consider acceptable, despite their obvious barbarity. The government will succeed only if it can convince scientists and the public that these trusted experimental methods can be replaced with something as good or better.

Fortunately, there are emerging alternatives. So-called organ-on-a-chip systems, which use lab-grown cells arranged into a miniature network that can simulate complex bodily systems, are already in use. And machine learning systems are proving efficient too. These approaches won't always provide perfect insight into how a given treatment might work for humans, but of course neither do animal tests. Undergraduate scientists are still taught these classic cautionary tales: paracetamol is toxic to dogs and cats, while thalidomide was shown to be safe in rats.

Unlike the slogans and aspirations in its AI strategy, the government appears to have a real plan for applying these technologies. There is £60 million in direct funding committed – and a focus on identifying specific animal research methods currently in use, measuring their effectiveness and validating animal-free alternatives that could provide similar results. [...]

This is an opportunity for both scientific and economic progress. Animal testing isn't just cruel, it is expensive and time-consuming. [...] And most importantly, there is a moral imperative to free these animals. Previous governments greatly reduced the number of so-called charismatic species – animals favoured by humans such as dogs and horses – used in experiments. Today, 95% of lab animals in the UK are rodents, birds or fish. Don't they deserve the same consideration?

Adapted from *The Guardian*
September 2025
(449 words)

WE WILL SOON BE ABLE TO TALK WITH OTHER SPECIES

Scientists have long avoided claiming that other animals have language. That is now changing, thanks to artificial intelligence's ability to spot patterns in huge data banks of animal noises and actions... could then the dolphin be the first non-human species to have its language decoded?

Neuroscientist Sophie Bodénès knew she was onto something special when she saw the cuttlefish extend two arms upwards while twisting its six others together. It was making what she calls the "up" sign – and it was throwing this shape in response to a video of another cuttlefish making similar movements. This was the first hint that these marine animals, which are cousins of octopuses, may communicate with a kind of sign language. [...]

If you have pets, no doubt you communicate with them – you know, for example, if they are hungry or want a walk. But that isn't the same as language. The human communication system consists of a vocabulary of words and the grammatical rules for using them. It uses sounds learned from others, rather than being innate, that are divided into categories such as nouns and verbs, which change to describe what happened in the past or will occur in the future. It also has a syntax that governs how the words are organized into sentences. All this allows us to create new words and combine them to make sentences that have never existed before. We can even discuss hypothetical things outside our own space and time, such as abstract distant targets. [...]

But even if another animal had a communication system anywhere close to ours, it isn't clear how we would go about demonstrating that, although some animal researchers suspect that our obsession with our own way of communicating holds us back from understanding the capabilities of other species. [...]

However, even if we can learn to decode different forms of communication, the next question will be "which animal language will we decode first?"

Whales are certainly up there when it comes to this question because we have already recorded so many of their calls. For instance, there are decades' worth of data on the songs of humpback whales in the South Pacific Ocean. Another challenger is the dolphin since a research program has already a good combination of long-term data about specific animals in their population... So it's definitely in the top five in terms of long-term studies. [...] But working with whales and dolphins is difficult. This is why the first animal to have its communication fully decoded will have to be easier to study, perhaps a species of social birds that live in groups and use vocalization to coordinate behavior, such as parrots...

Adapted from *New Scientist*
August 2025
(451 words)

WE'RE KILLING OUR INTERNAL ECOSYSTEM

Each human body is home to its own miniature ecosystem, made up of trillions of bacteria, as well as smaller communities of fungi and viruses. They live in a community in the same way animals, trees, water and rocks live together in a forest. These microscopic worlds are known as the human microbiome.

Picturing microbes all over our bodies might sound unnerving, but these ecosystems help us stay healthy. In the same way as we need to preserve ecosystems in nature, we also need to preserve them in our body. But it's not all about the gut. Microbes in the vagina keep it acidic and protect it from invading bacteria, while those on the skin are specialists in wound healing. More than 100 species of fungi live on the feet alone – every community is different.

The New Science of the Microbiome, describes the loss of microbial biodiversity inside our bodies as an “internal climate crisis”. Microbiomes are being destroyed by the misuse of medicines – particularly antibiotics – by ultra-processed foods and by the loss of contact with a healthy natural environment.

A growing body of research is linking two layers of biodiversity. There is the outer layer of biodiversity (soil, water, plants, animals, etc), and then there is the inner layer: the biodiversity that lives within and upon the human body.

Urbanisation isolates people from nature, reducing time spent in natural spaces, inhaling, touching and ingesting beneficial microorganisms. Planners are exploring how cities can help reconnect people with nature – bringing flowers, healthy water bodies and old trees into our cities.

Finland is leading the way on this with an impressive programme to boost nature contact in kindergartens. Across the country, 43 daycare centres have been awarded a total of €1m to rewild their yards and increase children's exposure to microscopic biodiversity. An amazing study showed that just one month of growing plants boosted skin bacteria and the body's immune response. It was not the act of gardening that was important, but contact with healthy, biodiverse soils. Another study found that having pets could be good for human health.

Humans are part of nature and covered in millions of beneficial bacteria that should be shared. People with larger social networks tend to have more diverse gut microbiomes. For example, teenagers have more diverse and resilient microbiomes, and similarly, when an elderly person goes into a care home, their microbiome diversity increases.

Meaningfully connecting with other people is important for all measures of our health, not just the microbiome. Each house, each room, has its own microbiome, eating with other people as a way to share microbiomes. The mouth is believed to be the most diverse bodily ecosystem. Some eighty million bacteria are transferred in a kiss.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
November 2025
(460 words)

WHAT AI-GENERATED TILLY NORWOOD REVEALS ABOUT DIGITAL CULTURE, ETHICS AND THE RESPONSIBILITIES OF CREATORS

Imagine an actor who never ages, never walks off set or demands a higher salary. That's the promise behind Tilly Norwood, a fully AI-generated "actress" currently being courted by Hollywood's top talent agencies. Her synthetic presence has ignited a media firestorm, denounced as an existential threat to human performers by some and hailed as a breakthrough in digital creativity by others.

But beneath the headlines lies a deeper tension. The binaries used to debate Norwood — human versus machine, threat versus opportunity, good versus bad — flatten complex questions of art, justice and creative power into soundbites. The question isn't whether the future will be synthetic; it already is. Our challenge now is to ensure that it is also meaningfully human.

Ironically, at the centre of this polarizing debate is a rare moment of agreement: all sides acknowledge that Tilly is not human. Her creator, [...] the CEO of an AI production company, insists that Norwood was never meant to replace a real actor. [...] The controversy [...] isn't just about what Tilly is, it's about what she *represents*.

Norwood represents more than novelty. She's emblematic of a larger reckoning with how rapidly artificial intelligence is reshaping our lives and the creative sector. The velocity of change is dizzying, and now the question is how do we shape the hybrid world we've already entered?

It can feel disorienting trying to parse ethics, rights and responsibilities while being bombarded by newness. Especially when that "newness" comes in a form that unnerves us: a near-human likeness that triggers long-standing cultural discomfort. Indeed, Norwood may be a textbook case of the "uncanny valley", a term coined by a Japanese roboticist [...] to describe the unease people feel when something looks almost human, but not quite.

But [...] what happens when audiences still feel something real while watching her on screen? If emotional resonance and storytelling are considered uniquely human traits, maybe the threat posed by synthetic actors has been overstated. [...] Who hasn't teared up in a Pixar film? A character doesn't have to *feel* emotion to evoke it.

Still, the public conversation remains polarized. [...] The conversation around AI right now is so binary that it limits our capacity for real thinking. [...] Synthetic actors aren't inherently villains or saviours, [...] they're a tool, a new medium. The challenge lies in how we build the infrastructures around them, such as rights, ownership and distribution. [...]

[...] Most people never get the chance to realize their creative potential — not for lack of talent, but due to barriers like access, capital, mentorship and time. Now, some of those barriers might finally lower. With AI tools, more people may get the opportunity to create.

Adapted from *The Conversation*
October 2025
(450 words)

WHAT IF WOMEN RULED THE WORLD?

Not so long ago, the idea that women might rule the world seemed totally ridiculous. But in an essay to mark International Women's Day, political analyst and former White House press secretary Dee Dee Myers argues it's now a topic that can be seriously discussed.

A few decades ago, women were thought to lack the intellectual capacity and emotional fortitude to make the difficult decisions that leadership required. It wasn't bias, it was biology... But in recent decades, attitudes and ideas have changed [...] a lot since a huge and growing body of research and experience makes it clear that empowering women makes things better. Not perfect. But better. Indeed, with women in governance, business is more profitable, governments are more representative, families are stronger, and communities are healthier, there is less violence, more peace, more stability and sustainability. Why? Well, it starts with the simple fact that women often experience life differently. And that experience affects the way we see problems - and think about solutions. [...]

Studies also show that women are more likely to be collaborative, inclusive and team-oriented - all characteristics that tend to be effective, particularly in today's less hierarchical, innovation driven world. [...]

Mary Robinson, the former president of Ireland, says that women also bring an inter-generational perspective to their work. "I think women are more likely to take decisions now that will make for a safer world for our grandchildren." For too long, women were expected to think like men and act like men if they wanted to succeed. But increasingly their differences are seen as a source of strength rather than a weakness to be overcome. [...]

Study after study shows that women's accomplishments have just been less valued even though they are the engine driving global economic growth. In 2014, women were responsible for \$28 trillion in spending. And when women have more cash, they spend it differently. They feed their families healthier diets and send their children to school. They invest in clean water, better schools, education and health care. They start businesses and hire other women. The entire community prospers. As a result, investing in women has become a strategic imperative for companies around the world.

Women are also essential to building and sustaining peace. When women are negotiating, they help bridge the gap between different groups and ensure that a broader range of issues, from food security to sexual violence, are addressed. As a result, peace is more likely to take root. [...]

So empowering women means investing in stronger economies and healthier communities, ending conflicts as well as sustaining peace. It means improving the quality of life for people all over the world.

Adapted from *BBC News*
March 2015
(455 words)

WHAT'S THE REAL CARBON FOOTPRINT OF A SINGLE EMAIL?

Going paperless sounds eco-friendly, but even our digital habits can have a serious environmental impact. Believe it or not, sending a simple email uses more energy than you think – and the numbers add up fast.

According to the Carbon Literacy Project, which is a UK accreditation body that assesses carbon costs and impacts of everyday activities, a typical email generates about 4 grams of CO². Add a big attachment, and it can reach 50 grams. For example, sending a 1 Megabyte vacation photo to ten friends creates as much pollution as driving 500 meters in your car. And even if you're just emailing your colleague across the office, that message travels thousands of miles through data centers, such as Google's or Yahoo's in the US, bouncing across servers and routers that all consume energy and need to be cooled.

Therefore, what is the real issue? Since we send a lot of emails, the average person in France gets about 40 emails a day ; in 2018, more than 280 billion emails were sent globally every single day. If each of those emails creates just 4 grams of CO², which is the minimum amount of CO² for an email, that totals around 410 million tons of CO² per year.

To put it in perspective, commercial aviation generated about 860 million tons of CO² in 2017, says the International Air Transport Association. And that email number is likely underestimated, since it doesn't even include spam, which makes up half of all messages. Even unopened spam emails emit 0.3 grams of CO², and a staggering 80% of emails are never even opened.

Besides, it's not just the act of sending emails that generates CO², storing them also consumes energy. According to Edouard Nattée, CEO of the startup Foxintelligence that has created the free anti-spam tool Cleanfox, the average person in France has 10,000 to 50,000 unread emails sitting in their inbox.

Those messages are stored in data centers, which together use more than 200 terawatt-hours of electricity annually and account for about 0.3% of global greenhouse gas emissions, according to Nature.

So, to cut down your email carbon footprint, you can do several simple things such as using your phone to send a text instead when it makes sense. You can also compress files, send a link instead of bulky attachments and unsubscribe from newsletters you never read. Don't forget to get rid of old email accounts that are just collecting dust and regularly clean out the inboxes you use...

Adapted from *Futura Science*
June 2025
(445 words)

WHO KILLED THE RAVE? LATE-NIGHT DANCING FALLS INTO GLOBAL DECLINE

New Year's Eve revellers at a thirty-five-hour-long event will be the last to grace the dance floor at the Watergate club, an iconic Berlin venue that has become the latest victim of club death. "The days when Berlin was flooded with club-loving visitors are over," the venue's management said in a farewell statement. Watergate's co-owner blamed cost pressures, declining tourism, lacking enthusiasm from Generation Z and the rise of music festivals for its closure. [...]

The proportion of club nights running beyond 3 a.m. fell in twelve of fifteen global cities between 2014 and 2024, according to an analysis of events on listings website Resident Advisor. "People can only go out for so many hours," said Lutz Leichsenring, co-founder of international night-time consultancy VibeLab. "There's a lot of competition between night-time and daytime events." [...]

Resident Advisor data reflected the rise in daytime parties, with several big cities showing a surge in events that end at 10 p.m. Melbourne lays claim to being the live music capital of the world and twenty years ago boasted a vibrant nightclub scene. Yet the sector has been in sharp decline in the city as consumer habits changed and the cost of running events rose, particularly after the pandemic. [...]

One executive in the entertainment industry said younger people were less inclined to go out raving until 6 a.m. as they were more health conscious and less frivolous with money than previous generations. This is reflected in Melbourne's nightclub closures – with more than one hundred shutting down in recent years – and fewer clubs staying open all night. Campaigners in Dublin estimated there were about twenty to twenty-five clubs left in the city and its suburbs, which are home to around one million people. "It's prohibitively expensive to open a venue now, or to even open your doors for an individual night," they added. [...]

But there are signs of hope for dance music. A recent study found that the electronic music industry had grown by seventeen percent in 2023, reaching an annual revenue of twelve billion dollars. Across the fifteen cities analysed using Resident Advisor event data, venues listing more than five events increased by sixty per cent in 2024 compared with a decade ago. More than thirty-five thousand artists had been booked to play in those cities since 2014 – up ninety percent over the same period. "People are still craving community", says Mike Vosters whose company Matinee Social Club organises early evening parties in New York. "People still want to go out. That hasn't been diminished and music is still the best way to do that."

Adapted from *The Financial Times*
December 2024
(453 words)

WHY AI IS BEING TRAINED IN RURAL INDIA

Virudhunagar, a town in southeastern India, can boast temples that date back thousands of years. But not far from those ancient sites, people are working on the latest tech - artificial intelligence. [...]

India has long been a centre for outsourced IT support, with cities like Bangalore being traditional hubs for such work. But in recent years firms have been moving that work into much more remote areas, where costs for staff and space are lower. The trend is known as cloud farming, and AI has given it another boost with numerous towns, like Virudhunagar, hosting firms working on AI. [...]

"We realised that instead of forcing people to migrate to cities in search of jobs, we could bring jobs to where people already live," says the chief executive of Desicrew. "For too long, opportunities have been concentrated in cities, leaving rural youth behind. Our mission has always been to create world-class careers closer to home, while proving that quality work can be delivered from anywhere."

Desicrew does all sorts of outsourced work including software testing for start-up firms, building datasets to train AI, and moderating content. At the moment 30 to 40% of its work is AI related, but this figure is expected to approach 100% in the near future. Much of that work is transcription - turning audio to text.

"Machines understand text far better. For AI to work naturally, machines must be trained to understand variations in how people speak. That's why transcription is such a crucial step, it forms the foundation for machines to comprehend and respond across languages, dialects, and contexts" says the CEO.

Doing such work in a smaller town is not a disadvantage. "People often assume rural means underdeveloped, but our centres mirror urban IT hubs in every way – secure data access, reliable connectivity, and uninterrupted power. The only difference is geography. "

Around 70% of his workforce are women: "For many, this is their first salaried job, and the impact on their families is transformative – from financial security to education for their children". [...]

But success is not guaranteed. While Desicrew says it has access to reliable and secure internet connections, that is not always the case in India's smaller towns.

A technology advisor commented: "Reliable high-speed internet and secure data centres are not always at par with metros, which makes data protection a constant concern. Even if good connections are in place, work needs to be done to reassure clients. The bigger challenge is the perception rather than a technical one. International clients often assume small towns cannot meet data security standards, even when the systems are robust. Trust has to be earned through delivery." [...]

Adapted from *BBC*
October 2025
(453 words)

WHY ARE BORDER AGENTS FLOODING INTO US CITIES?

Border patrol officers have become ubiquitous footsoldiers in Donald Trump's mass deportation plan, and lawyers and human rights advocates worry that the agency is expanding its aggressive tactics into cities far from its conventional range.

Border patrol agents have become a daily presence in several major cities across the US. [...]

This summer in Los Angeles, border agents on horseback swept through a public park – riding alongside national guard troops and other agents in military vehicles [...].

Agents have also made arrests in California's agricultural Central Valley and at New York immigration courthouses. They have set up immigration checkpoints in Washington DC.

Lawyers and human rights advocates say the agents, who are trained to block illegal entries, drug smugglers and human traffickers at the country's borders, may be ill-suited to conduct civil immigration enforcement in urban communities. [...]

Until recently, the agency usually worked close to the southern US border – especially along the south-western border – though the department has long had the authority to conduct patrols more inland.

[...] But now illegal border crossings are at a historic low, and the administration has deployed thousands of military personnel to the southern border [...]

It's unclear exactly how many Border Patrol agents have joined up with other federal agents in raids targeting Chicago, Los Angeles and other big cities.

[...] As border agents stray away from their original mission, legal experts have raised concerns that they are bringing along with them a culture of combative enforcement. "[Border Patrol] has a history of problematic treatment of people, in my opinion, perhaps worse than any other law enforcement agency," said a professor of legal studies [...].

Agents cannot pull people over without "reasonable suspicion" of an immigration violation, or search homes or vehicles without a warrant or probable cause.

In recent deployments, however, agents appear to be flouting these restrictions. Earlier this month, Border Patrol agents, along with other federal agents, conducted a military-style immigration raid of an apartment complex in Chicago. Video evidence showed agents indiscriminately bursting through front doors. [...]

Immigrant advocates have had limited success in opposing this type of indiscriminate enforcement. In a January operation [...], plainclothes border agents poured into California's Central Valley region, conducting random stops along the highway. [A] federal district court found that the operation violated the fourth amendment.

But proving such fourth amendment violations can be a big burden on advocates [...]. And Border Patrol has a long history of aggressive enforcement tactics. There's evidence of everything from legal and constitutional violations to physical and sexual abuse and mistreatment, and very little recourse or accountability [...]

A 2023 report by [...] migrant rights advocacy groups, detailed persistent human rights abuses without accountability within the agency.

Adapted from *The Guardian*
October 2025
(449 words)

WHY TECH GIANTS ARE OFFERING PREMIUM AI TOOLS TO MILLIONS OF INDIANS FOR FREE

Starting this week, millions of Indians will get one year of free access to ChatGPT's new, low-cost "Go" AI chatbot. [...]

Analysts say such offers shouldn't be mistaken for generosity as they are calculated investments and a long-term bet on India's digital future. "The plan is to get Indians hooked on to generative AI before asking them to pay for it," Tarun Pathak, an analyst at Counterpoint Research, told the BBC.

"What India offers is scale and a young audience," he says, adding that other big markets like China might rival India in terms of the number of users, but its tightly regulated tech environment limits foreign access. India, by contrast, offers an open and competitive digital market and global tech is clinching the opportunity to enlist millions of new users here to train their AI models. [...]

India has over 900 million internet users and offers some of the world's cheapest data. [...] Bundling these AI tools with data packs creates a massive opportunity for tech companies given India's data consumption outpaces much of the world. The more Indians use these platforms, the more first-hand data companies can access. [...]

While a win-win for AI companies, these free offerings raise questions from a consumer perspective, especially regarding implications on data privacy. [...] But this is where the government will have to step in, he says. [...] At present, India does not have a dedicated law governing artificial intelligence. There is the broader Digital Personal Data Protection Act [...] around digital media and privacy, but it is yet to be enacted. [...]

For now though, India's flexible regulatory environment allows companies like OpenAI and Google to bundle free AI tools with telecom plans, something far harder to do in other countries. For instance, the European Union's AI rules set tough standards for transparency and data governance, while South Korea's incoming regulations go a step further, requiring labels on AI-generated content and making operators answerable for how their systems are used. [...]

India needs both stronger user awareness and clearer regulation, but without stifling innovation. "At this point, we need light-touch regulation, but that will have to evolve as the extent of potential harm becomes clearer".

Until then, the global AI companies will be hoping that by offering these freebies they can replicate India's past experience of onboarding millions of new users with deeply discounted internet data. While AI is unlikely to follow a heavily monetised model and is instead expected to be adopted as a low-cost, value-driven service, the country's sheer volumes offer promise.

"For instance, even if just 5% of free users become subscribers, that's still a significant number," says Mr Pathak.

Adapted from *bbc.com*
November 2025
(451 words)

WHY WORLD RECORDS SEEM TO BE GETTING HARDER TO BEAT - ACCORDING TO MATHS

To the roar of the crowd at the Athletics World Championships in Tokyo, Armand "Mondo" Duplantis sprinted down the runway with his pole aloft. (...) The cheers became deafening. Then Duplantis flew.

The Swedish pole vaulter soared above the competition to assert his dominance over one of athletics' most technical disciplines – achieving a new world record in the event. His 6.3m leap saw Duplantis win his third consecutive world title and, astonishingly, break his 14th world record. He is, in every way, raising the bar again and again.

This is often what can happen in sport. Improvements in diet, technique or equipment can bring a sudden spate of world records, especially in technical disciplines like pole-vaulting and cycling where small adjustments make a big difference. Technical advances in running events have also seen records tumble in recent years.

In contrast, the men's world record in the long jump has been broken only once since 1968. (...) Perhaps we have reached peak long jump – a situation in which further improvement is impossible. (...) We refer to these sorts of situations as "stationary", in the sense that the overall trend in average behaviour is unchanging. Given a stationary system, we can ask how often we should expect records to fall due to random fluctuations. (...)

Decades of climate data, for example, show records are being broken at an alarming rate, suggesting our climate is rapidly warming and is no longer stationary due to the effect humans are having on the planet by emitting greenhouse gases into the atmosphere. (...)

What does this mean for sport? In athletics we don't typically have enough data to know if individual sports have reached this stationary state. Some studies have argued that data on peak sporting performance across a range of track and field events suggest that we are at or near peak physical performance and that we should now expect records to be broken with decreasing frequency. Others argue that human performance has yet to peak and will continue to improve. (...)

But after a swelteringly hot and humid World Championships in Tokyo in 2025, World Athletics president Seb Coe acknowledged that climate change may force athletics to rethink its tradition of holding summer events. Notably Duplantis' was the only world record broken in Tokyo. With three quarters of athletes reporting that climate change and heat are negatively impacting their health and competition performance, we may find that climate change itself will alter the rates at which athletics records are broken.

In the meantime, we should cherish those world records that do come along – the athletes who achieve them have beaten the odds to do something truly special.

Adapted from *BBC News*
October 2025
(459 words)

WILL AI MAKE YOU STUPID?

As anybody who has ever taken a standardised test will know, racing to answer an expansive essay question in 20 minutes or less takes serious brain power. Having unfettered access to artificial intelligence (AI) would certainly lighten the mental load. But as a recent study by researchers at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) suggests, that help may come at a cost.

[...] Across the board, the AI users exhibited markedly lower neural activity in parts of the brain associated with creative functions and attention. Students who wrote with the chatbot's help also found it much harder to provide an accurate quote from the paper that they had just produced. [...] Overall, a majority of workers reported needing either less or much less cognitive effort to complete tasks with generative-AI tools such as ChatGPT, Google Gemini or Microsoft's own Copilot AI assistant, compared with doing those tasks without AI.

Another study, by Michael Gerlich, a professor at SBS Swiss Business School, asked 666 individuals in Britain how often they used AI and how much they trusted it, before posing them questions based on a widely used critical-thinking assessment. Participants who made more use of AI scored lower across the board. Dr Gerlich says that after the study was published he was contacted by hundreds of high-school and university teachers dealing with growing AI adoption among their students who, he says, "felt that it addresses exactly what they currently experience".

Whether AI will leave people's brains flabby and weak in the long term remains an open question. Researchers [...] have stressed that further work is needed to establish a definitive causal link between elevated AI use and weakened brains. In Dr Gerlich's study, for example, it is possible that people with greater critical-thinking prowess are just less likely to lean on AI [...]

Moreover, generative-AI tools explicitly seek to lighten people's mental loads, as many other technologies do. [...] There is little evidence to suggest that allowing machines to do users' mental bidding alters the brain's inherent capacity for thinking, says Evan Risko, a professor of psychology at the University of Waterloo who, [...] coined the term "cognitive offloading" to describe how people shrug off difficult or tedious mental tasks to external aids.

The worry is that, as Dr Risko puts it, generative AI allows one to "offload a much more complex set of processes". Offloading some mental arithmetic, which has only a narrow set of applications, is not the same as offloading a thought process like writing or problem-solving. And once the brain has developed a taste for offloading, it can be a hard habit to kick [...] If stronger evidence emerges that AI makes people less intelligent, will they care?

Adapted from *The Economist*
July 2025
(453 words)

YOU AND ME, WE GONNA LIVE FOREVER ... AS AVATARS, AT LEAST

For \$199, you can live for ever. At least that's the promise of an app called HereAfter AI, which might let you haunt your family for generations.

The app is part of a fast-growing industry known as grief tech – a cluster of startups exploring how technology can commemorate, simulate or even resurrect the dead.

Users can upload an unlimited number of voice messages, text prompts, photographs and videos of themselves, and in return an algorithm melds together memories and media and spits out a “virtual you” – an avatar that can speak to loved ones on phone calls and through text messages “so that children, grandchildren and beyond can know what you're really like”. [...]

One South Korean company, DeepBrain AI, offers perhaps the most high-end example. For up to \$50,000 – plus thousands more in maintenance fees – it creates hyper-realistic 3D avatars of the deceased. A video of its technology went viral, showing a grieving mother embracing a VR version of her seven-year-old daughter, who had died three years earlier.

Bots are now “capable of generating novel content rather than merely parroting content produced by their creator while living”, according to a new paper from Google DeepMind. These “generative ghosts” might “reshape society in complex ways beyond our current imagining”.

Even today, our AI afterlives are an ethical minefield. Unlike HereAfter AI, apps like character.ai, Seance AI and Virtual You allow users to create companions without the consent of the deceased, based on old messages – or even just a written description.

“If I die and my children access my email account and reanimate me ... for me, personally, that's a horrific prospect,” says Professor Robert Sparrow of Monash University, who has written about the ethics of digital ghosts.

Sparrow says some people may benefit from the comfort of reconnecting with loved ones but the risks of such novel technology are vast. “One of the most interesting questions is whether these artefacts risk distorting or even poisoning your memory of your deceased relative,” he says.

Then there's data privacy – for the living human, who in grief may share deeply personal data with the commercial entity that owns the bot, but also for the ghost, which might inadvertently reveal an old family secret from beyond the grave.

Regulators and developers should consider the privacy risks. But more than anything, Sparrow thinks we should all reflect on how we prepare for the end. [...]

“And in the future, part of that process will actually be: what data do I want to leave behind? And do I want to give people instructions about whether they should digitally reanimate me?”

Adapted from *The Observer*
May 2025
(455 words)

YOUR AGE SHOULDN'T PUT YOU OFF LEARNING A NEW LANGUAGE

If you've always wanted to learn a new language, don't let age put you off. People aged over 60 can be independent and flexible in how they learn a language – and successful, too.

There is ample evidence from decades of research that, as we age, some of our perceptual and cognitive abilities gradually decline. Our hearing and vision are not as sharp as they used to be, we process information less speedily, and our memory may not be as good. (...)

What is noted less frequently is the possibility that these effects need not be deficits in themselves, but may arise from a lifetime of accumulated knowledge and experience. The older we get, the more information we have to sort through, and this may slow us down. (...)

In line with this, researchers have investigated language learning in late adulthood and shown that there is no age limit to our ability to learn a new language. (...) However, it is less clear which approach to language learning and teaching works best later in life.

Research with younger adults indicates that an explicit approach which includes explanations of the target language and spells out grammar rules, for instance, is most effective.

At first glance, we may assume that this should apply to older adults too, (...) given that it reflects a traditional approach to language instruction. (...)

In our new study, we compared an explicit with an incidental approach to language learning. In a small set of online lessons, 80 English-speaking volunteers aged between 60 and 83 learned the beginnings of Croatian – a language they were completely unfamiliar with.

In the explicit approach, a full explanation of the grammatical structure we targeted was given. In the incidental approach, there was no explanation, but additional practice exercises were available instead. We found that learners did equally well regardless of the instructional approach they experienced. (...)

We also explored (...) the volunteers' self-concepts: that is how they felt about their own health, happiness and abilities. In addition, we asked questions about their (former) occupations and prior language learning experience. Interestingly, we found a connection between the ability to learn implicitly (...), occupational status (whether someone was retired or still working) and self-concepts.

Specifically, people who reported a more positive self-concept showed better implicit learning abilities. Moreover, people who were still working at the time of the study showed better implicit learning abilities. (...) Importantly, this effect was independent of age. (...)

Taken together, the results of our study show that late-life language learners can be very successful. They seem to be sufficiently independent to choose the path that works best for them. (...) In addition, confidence is important; it appears to arise from a combination of ability and social status.

Adapted from *theconversation.com*

September 2025

(458 words)